THE FUNAMBULIST

Politics of Space and Bodies



PAN-AFRICANISM

BEHIND THE SCENES

Dear reader,

Exactly two years ago, I embarked on this journey as I was entrusted the responsibility of carrying out the strategic outreach for The Funambulist. And what a joyful, challenging and instructive ride!

After several months of planning, I'm delighted that we're concluding the 2020 editorial year with this new issue on Pan-Africanism. Issue 32 is a particular one, as it is a culmination of a collaborative effort and — for the very first time — shared editorial responsibility between the three of us currently forming the editorial team, namely Caroline, Léopold, and myself. And what an honor to help articulate questions close to my heart, especially in times of global Black uprising where those couldn't be more pressuring.

As we set out to examine the genealogies of Pan-Africanism and its implications on the political and cultural landscapes across the Continent and in the diaspora, we understood that Pan-Africanism is embedded with profound complexity. Our weekly editorial meetings about the overall planning and execution of various tasks associated with running a magazine — from distribution and logistics over administration to communications — quickly diverted to having a single focus: the coordination of this specific issue.

Departing from the notion of Pan-Africanism as an imaginary that allows for togetherness, the ambition was for this issue to serve as a toolbox of which the world could benefit from. As such, we formulated questions about the WHO-PAST-PRESENT-FUTURE. Along the way, we came to terms with what we initially had anticipated had to be narrowed down; not to lower our ambitions, but on the contrary, to be more precise. Consequently, we had slowly drifted from questions that were at the center of this particular issue, but simply couldn't find foothold, such as *what does Pan-Africanism mean in the realm of knowledge production* (i.e. a Pan-African University), or *what does the Congo mean to the history and present of Pan-Africanism*? If this shared editorial endeavor taught us one thing, it is that of our ability to engage with a strong sense of *determination towards a common goal* and perhaps most importantly, our interpersonal *reliance*.

Before I conclude, I would like to extend a very warm welcome to our newest team member, Amel Hadj-Hassen, who will be assisting as an intern in the office over the course of the next 12 weeks.

I sincerely hope that you will enjoy as well as learn from the many great contributions throughout this issue. I'm certainly doing so.

Margarida Waco
Copenhagen, October 14, 2020

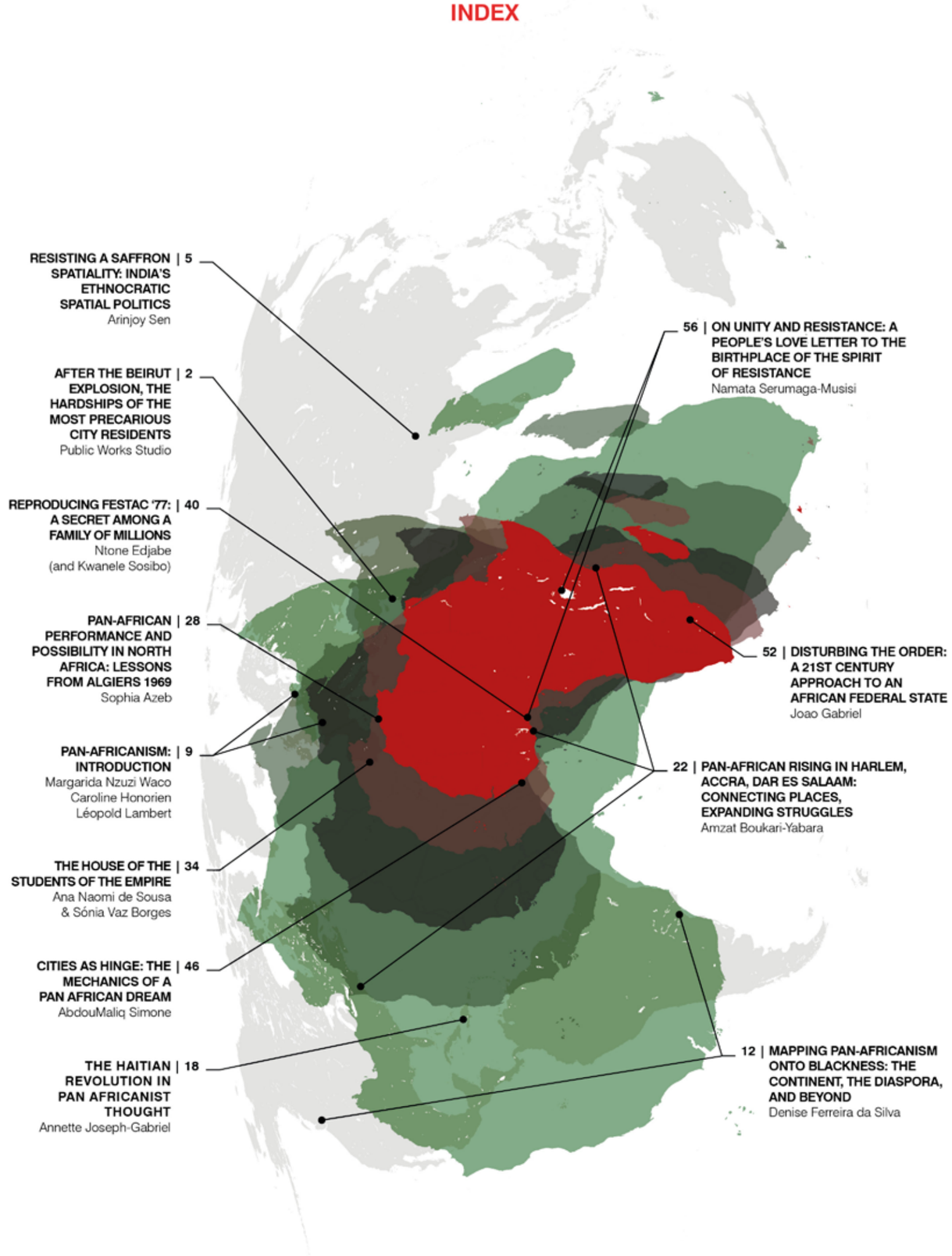


THE ISSUE'S COVER EXPLAINED

For this issue on Pan-Africanism, we commissioned Maya Mihindou to draw a cover for us. After rich exchanges between her and us, the issue's cover pays homage to historical figures of the Continent and the Afro Diaspora in this drawing. You may recognize most of them, but here is the list from top to bottom (just in case ;)): Ngugi wa Thiong'O (Kenya), Nanny of the maroons (Jamaica), Aimé Césaire (Martinique), Maryse Condé (Guadeloupe), Martin Luther King (U.S.), Stokeley Charmichael (U.S.), Jeanne Nardal (Martinique), Miriam Makeba (South Africa), Thomas Sankara (Burkina Faso), Winnie Mandela (South Africa), Claudia Jones (Trinidad), Maya Angelou (U.S.), Amilcar Cabral (Guinea Bissau), Franz Fanon (Martinique & Algeria), Kwame Nkrumah (Ghana), Pierre-Claver Akendengué (Gabon), Sarah Maldoror (Guadeloupe), Patrice Lumumba (Congo), Paulette Nardal (Martinique), Julius Nyerere (Tanzania), and Bob Marley (Jamaica).

Maya Mihindou was born in 1984 in Gabon. Self-taught and immersed for a while in graphic novels, she came to the image through illustration (for children books, press, and publishing). Drawing allows her to approach questions related to precarious, uprooted, fragile identities in creation. She also practices photography and writing to extend these reflections. In 2011, her first graphic novel, *Sabine*, was published by Editions Soleil. In January 2015, her work was exhibited between the walls of Procession at the CAPC of Bordeaux, accompanying the work of Julie Maroh and the museum's collection. She lives and works in Marseille and, since 2014, she contributes to the writing of articles and the creation of drawings, reportages, and interviews for various publications, in particular *Ballast*.

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AFTER THE BEIRUT EXPLOSION, THE HARDSHIPS OF THE MOST PRECARIOUS CITY RESIDENTS

PUBLIC WORKS STUDIO

TRANSLATED BY FAWWAZ ABU GHAZALEH

In the weeks that follow the deadly and massively destructive explosion in the port of Beirut, Public Works Studio has investigated the spatial politics of the reconstruction, in particular in the neighborhood of Mar Mikhael, where financial predation was already at work before the tragedy.

Since the Beirut port explosion of August 4, 2020, hundreds of buildings in the neighborhoods surrounding the port have been evacuated. Old and young, born there or recently resettled, tenants and owners, Lebanese and immigrants, residents and shopkeepers alike were forced to leave due to the damage and trauma. This mass flight poses an imminent threat to the possibility of reclaiming a viable city and lively neighborhood. The fear that rapid transition will turn into permanent displacement is justified. With the absence of disaster management plans, very few can afford the luxury of waiting for a government scheme to materialize or a compensation mechanism to take effect, especially when no one is taken to be responsible for the explosion. In addition, there is the risk of landowners selling their properties to investors who have coveted these areas since before the explosion.

Of course, fears of permanent displacement are fueled by previous catastrophic reconstruction scenarios and the compensation policies that accompanied them. Beirut and its suburbs have been previously destroyed, indeed, several times over. As we witness the destruction of other Lebanese cities, villages, and refugee camps, we understand that they were reconstructed so as to reproduce the root causes that originally led to their destruction. One example of such a root cause is class oppression, which finds its grounds for spatial division in order to serve specific interests. This has contributed to the additional displacement of marginalized people, the destruction of the local economy, and the creation of a large gap between the past and the present.

"THIS PRECARITY WAS EXACERBATED AS A RESULT OF THE BLAST. WALKING IN THE ALLEYWAYS ONE DAY, WE SEE SOCIALIZING SPACES, STAIRS AND COMMON AREAS COMPLETELY EMPTY, EXCEPT FOR THE RARE PRESENCE OF CIVILIAN OR MILITARY VOLUNTEERS, BUSY WITH SURVEYING THE DAMAGES."

Today, more than two months after the explosion, the government is still mired in its reluctance, recklessness, and inability to develop a policy to rehabilitate the stricken neighborhoods. It is in a quagmire — amidst endless surveys and unreliable relief operations, consequently wasting funds, in addition to making ambiguous the fate of donations.

Mar Mikhael is one of the area's residential neighborhoods where workers have historically found residence that is close to their workplaces around the port and the railway. Carpenters, shoemakers, and craftsmen have also resided there since the 1920s. During the 1950s and 1960s, the neighborhood became residential par excellence. The rate of rental housing grew, as homeowners added floors above their houses with the aim of renting them out to successive generations of newcomers moving to the city. Today, the percentage of tenants in old Mar Mikhael is about 55%. Since 2006, the neighborhood's low rent has been attracting investors. Appreciating its unique urban and social style, restaurants and bars began to pop up, replacing the old, small-scale industries. In 2014, about 50 new designer stores and artist shops were surveyed in the neighborhood, in addition to over 70 art galleries, bars, and restaurants. At night, the aforementioned spaces would be filled with patrons of the new cafes and bars. As a result of this economic transformation, between 2007 and 2015, apartment prices in Mar Mikhael rose from 2,100 USD per square meter to 4,000 USD. This increase in land and property prices have had a significant impact on housing affordability, resulting in many evictions of residents and old businesses.

This precarity was exacerbated as a result of the blast. Walking in the alleyways one day, we see socializing spaces, stairs and common areas completely empty, except for the rare presence of civilian or military volunteers, busy with surveying the damages. When we stepped into a red-colored building, we saw water leaking from tanks onto the entrance. The walls had collapsed in a ground-floor apartment where Syrian workers used to live. They had decided to leave, especially since they were injured, while tenants in the other apartments stayed. Sarah, Ababish, and Elsa are three of the five Ethiopian workers who continue to live in the same building. Their apartment walls did not collapse, however it was left with no windows or doors. Even after a month after the blast, the Ethiopian workers have not been able to fix the openings. They tried to fix the damages as much as possible using an amount of 50,000 liras donated to them. One of them managed to maintain her job, yet the others had lost theirs due to the country's financial crisis.



"Nothing is mine" written on the wall of a damaged house. Photo by Public Works (2020).

Nearby, a 70 year old woman sits in her apartment amidst the destruction, in a building overlooking a primary road. She is a lonely widow who rented her apartment under an old lease agreement for 40 years. Before the blast, the owner of the building was travelling and had sold his building to a big company. When the latter demanded the tenants to leave, they refused and asked for a five years grace period. Today, the new owner is fixing only one of the empty apartments, leaving the tenants to live in debris.

"*We cannot stay. It's all sand, gravel and cockroaches that get inside. There is neither a window nor a door; there is nothing. I sweep three or four times a day, and the sand reappears as if I hadn't done anything. This wall next you is quite scary. Three engineers came up and said:* 'Hurry up; the wall will collapse. You must support it and then replace it.' *But the repair process will take time. When will it be my turn? In a year, two years? And as far as we are concerned, we cannot afford to repair it ourselves. The landlady's house also got destroyed and she moved out of the city, also because a woman in their building had passed away. How do you expect us to stay?*"

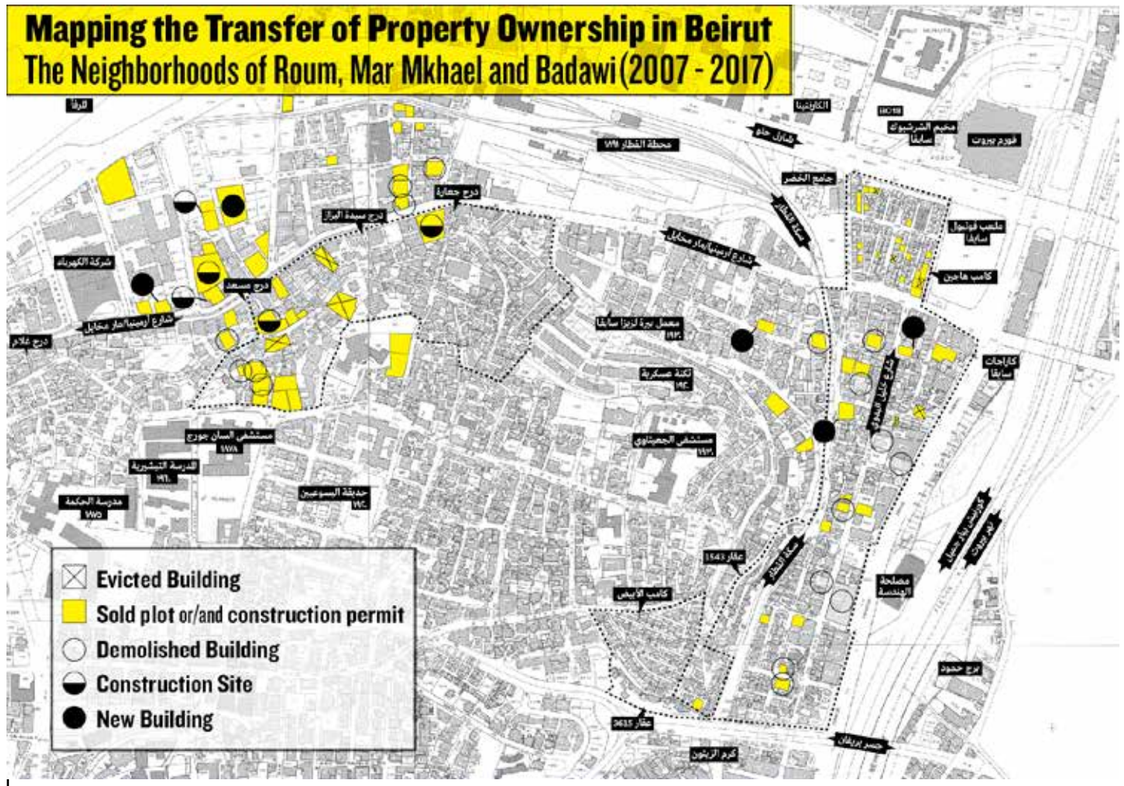
With these words, Martine told us that she and her family have decided to leave their home for good — the house they had rented for over 40 years. On the other side of the cracked wall, is where Farah has lived for two years. She had rented the house without signing a written contract with the owner. We found her as well, carrying her remaining belongings and moving out from the neighborhood. The owner had told her, "Don't return; I won't be repairing the house." Next door to them is a three-story building, where Zuzu and his family have lived since the 1990s. Zuzu was a security guard at a bank, but he recently lost his job with the financial crisis. As a result of the explosion, his son was injured in the head and needed 17 stitches. Unable to bear the costs for medical treatment, the family moved to their village, east of Saida. Alia, the girl who had lived on the third floor of that building for the past five years, has also left.

While some stories from the aftermath of the Beirut explosion may seem dissimilar or varied, there are still many whose story is similar to that of Martine's. People living amongst destroyed buildings have expressed their huge disappointment in the failure of separate surveying efforts, as well as the immediate help provided to residents in desperate need. Evidently, the provision of aid has also become a form of humiliation to people in need. The state's deliberate absence paved the way for multiple redundant surveys, unreliable relief operations, wasteful money spending, in addition to ambiguities in the fate of compensation funds. The residents have also witnessed the self-interested involvement of sectarian parties and religious bodies in the renovation efforts, contributing in the long run to re-imposing their control over urban space and feeding into clientelist relations at the expense of collective rights.

"WE CANNOT STAY. IT'S ALL SAND, GRAVEL AND COCKROACHES THAT GET INSIDE. THERE IS NEITHER A WINDOW NOR A DOOR; THERE IS NOTHING."

"PEOPLE LIVING AMONGST DESTROYED BUILDINGS HAVE EXPRESSED THEIR HUGE DISAPPOINTMENT IN THE FAILURE OF SEPARATE SURVEYING EFFORTS, AS WELL AS THE IMMEDIATE HELP PROVIDED TO RESIDENTS IN DESPERATE NEED."

Furthermore, residents are angry at the fact that they are being transformed into mere recipients of aid rather than active agents. During community focus groups that we held with them, residents described how: "some people have no other choice than to accept this aid. And some people are ashamed by this aid and remain silent about it." These community focus groups are part of a wider effort



Map by Public Works Studio of the transfer of land ownership in the areas of Mar Mkhael and Badawi, based on research conducted in 2015.

"OUR EFFORTS BEGIN WITH THE AIM OF REINSTATING PEOPLE'S VOICES, THEIR COLLECTIVE CONCERNS, AND THEIR ROLE IN DETERMINING COMMON PRIORITIES — WHETHER IT IS IN ENSURING HOUSING, BUILDING RECONSTRUCTION POLICIES, OR IN THE RELATION WITH DONOR ORGANIZATIONS."

at building a representational framework for all those affected by the blast. The efforts jointly initiated by Public Works and various other organizations, departs first by recognizing that people generally, specifically inhabitants of damaged neighborhoods, have been made absent from discussions around reconstruction priorities, as well as being dealt with individually, not collectively. Our efforts begin with the aim of reinstating people's voices, their collective concerns, and their role in determining common priorities — whether it is in ensuring housing, building reconstruction policies, or in the relation with donor organizations. Any opportunity for collective action and claim formation, in the absence of existing organizational structures or neighborhood committees, will be directly linked to the success of forming this representative framework with local communities. The years following the civil war (1975-1990) and its resultant neoliberal reconstruction policies have in fact dismantled the very notion of the "neighborhood" and disfigured relations between people and their city. Cities are made first and foremost of neighborhoods; of inhabitants living together in proximity, in spite of their familial or sectarian affiliations. Many share the same problems and require the same solutions, they use the same facilities and public utilities. Their experiences and their sufferings are identical.

Our main objective is to reclaim the socio-economic livelihood of affected areas and enable a dignified return of residents to their homes. To guarantee a rehabilitation process that is people-centered, their role and voice must be reclaimed and centered. Indeed, forming neighborhood committees and a framework that represents all victims of the blast is the first stepping stone towards that. ■

Public Works is a research-based studio that engages critically and creatively with a number of urban and public issues in Lebanon. By taking a right to the city approach, it aims to address and actively respond to the root causes of spatial inequality and the chronic challenges facing just cities and equitable development. The studio initiates multi-disciplinary projects that study, shape and implement counter strategies to urban planning and policy making in Lebanon.

RESISTING A SAFFRON SPATIALITY: INDIA'S ETHNOCRATIC SPATIAL POLITICS

ARINJOY SEN

Drawing from the mobilizing protests initiated in the neighborhood of Shaheen Bagh in Delhi against the recent BJP anti-Muslim policies, Arinjoy Sen proposes a spatial filter to read the protest and their violent suppression, but also the last 30 years of Hindu nationalism that brought BJP in power.

"*Right-wing propaganda, having infiltrated the Parliament at a legislative and judicial level with majoritarian support within the Parliament, has forced dissent to manifest in the streets.*" (Anonymous Shaheen Bagh protester)

"THIS CONTAINS A CRUCIAL ELEMENT OF TERRITORIALISATION AND AGGRESSION TOWARDS SYMBOLISM. ANY OCCUPATION OF TERRITORY — MOST ESPECIALLY THE CLAIMING OF PUBLIC SPACE BY MUSLIMS — IS THEREFORE IDENTIFIED BY THEM AS ILLEGITIMATE."

On December 14, 2019, a small group of local women moved to block Kalindi Kunj Road, a six-lane highway bordering the Muslim-majority neighborhood of Shaheen Bagh in southeast Delhi, using their bodies as a physical barricade/barrier. They came together to voice their dissent against the new Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) and the National Register of Citizens (NRC). From this first action of a group of women, Shaheen Bagh quickly emerged as the epicentre of anti-CAA protests in India, as well as a symbol of dissent, with almost 100,000 people participating to them over 101 days. As one participant of the protests noted, "The essential difference is that Shaheen Bagh was led and joined by women. And especially women of a minority community. This is what rattled the ethnocratic Hindutva activists and government. To see women reclaim their freedom and fight for their rights, shook the Hindu-nationalists to the core."

"THE SIGNIFICANCE OF THE PROTESTS LIES IN THE EMERGENCE OF THOSE WHO WERE ASSUMED TO BE POWERLESS."

The CAA, passed by the Parliament of India on December 12, 2019 as an amendment to the Citizenship Act of 1995, essentially reinforces the arsenal of anti-Muslim legislation constructed by the ruling BJP political party, reminiscing tendencies of ethnic cleansing towards a Hindu nation. It does so plainly, by excluding Islam from the religious faiths (Hindu, Sikh, Parsi, Buddhist, Jain, and Christian) eligible to avail a fast-track process of application for Indian citizenship. Ostensibly, the primary targets are people who may (or may not) hold citizenship of the neighboring countries of Bangladesh, Pakistan and Afghanistan, but who are residing in India without appropriate documentation. As such, the CAA must be read in conjunction with the NRC, which allows the rendering of persons as non-citizens if they fail to provide proof in the form of "satisfactory legacy papers."

It's not difficult to see the urban spatial scale of such events. Most of the incidents, including the Delhi riots earlier this year, originated in confrontations with rather peaceful sit-in protests. The protests themselves were the only 'provocation': a highly charged collective embodiment of space, experienced by Hindu-nationalists as spatialized resistance against their cause but also as an encroachment to the very idea of a Hindu territory, rooted in their Motherland — an idea known as *Hindutva*. This contains a crucial element of territorialisation and aggression towards symbolism. Any occupation of territory — most especially the claiming of public space by Muslims — is therefore identified by them as illegitimate.

The success of Shaheen Bagh as a site of resistance despite its small size could be attributed in part to its strategic location within the city. The area lies directly south-west of Noida, which shelters practically all of India's national media headquarters. It therefore enjoys a high level of connectivity to transport and other infrastructure. Closer still are a nexus of universities like Jamia Millia Islamia, Amity University, and Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU). This proximity allows not only for an increased participation but also an overwhelming media coverage which consequently acted as protection.

The significance of the protests lies in the emergence of those who were assumed to be powerless. The women of Shaheen Bagh, mostly Muslim residents of the neighborhood, are perceived (especially in the eyes of the Hindu nationalists) as being bound to the space of private domesticity. This supposedly oppressed minority/group had reclaimed what was not imagined to be theirs, and turned it into their resistance. A new (and unexpected) collective spatiality was being negotiated in plain sight, at the heart of Delhi. This is where Shaheen Bagh's strength was rooted.

However, the retaliatory aggression by both militant Hindutva nationalists and police in the surrounding areas





Above. Footbridge in Shaheen Bagh, covered with anti-NRC and anti-CAA signs. / Photo by Diplomat-TesterMan (January 7, 2020). **Below.** Female protestors gathered under a self-built canopee in Shahen Bagh. / Photo by DTM (January 15, 2020).

and institutions served as bitter proof of Shaheen Bagh's success, underlining the contested instrumentalisation of public space: at once a site of resistance, sanctioned terror, and the struggle for control. Squares, junctions and street corners became strategic elements in the spatialization of violence.

"AS SUCH, UNIVERSITY CAMPUSES ARE INHERENTLY SPACES OF POLITICAL ENCOUNTER. THESE ARE ENCLAVES WHERE SURVEILLANCE AND POLICING TARGET EARLY ON IN THE TIMES OF POLITICAL UNREST, BECAUSE STUDENTS ARE ASSUMED TO BE THE FIRST EXERCISERS OF POLITICAL EXPRESSION AND MARKERS OF DISSENT."

On December 15, 2019, Delhi police forcefully entered the campus of the Jamia Millia Islamia University (near Shaheen Bagh), launching a violent attack on the students. Nearly 100 individuals were detained by police; many were left heavily injured during the confrontation which saw the university library ransacked — all of this captured on CCTV. Prior to the attack, some students of Jamia Millia Islamia University had been protesting against the CAA.

Three weeks later, a masked mob of more than 50 individuals, armed with rods, sticks and acid attacked the campus of JNU, injuring over 39 students and teachers. This was generally accepted as a continuation of organized Hindu-nationalist aggression; the mob appeared to infiltrate the campus freely without police intervention, with students accusing the police of intentional inaction and complicity with the attackers. This attack initiated a string of protests in solidarity with the students of JNU, condemning the attack across various universities within India and beyond.

University campuses are not neutral or public spaces — there are numerous examples of clashes between the police and students within campus boundaries illustrating this. Academic campuses evidently provide a safe haven for students. More importantly, they offer a charged atmosphere where students can freely exercise their freedom of speech to an extent. The instrumentalization of university campuses towards political subjectivation may be decoded firstly, by the freedom of political expression made possible within the academy. Secondly, a sense of protection is delivered by the university boundary, around the collective spatiality that is formed within the confines of the campus. As such, university campuses are inherently spaces of political encounter. These are enclaves where surveillance and policing target early on in the times of political unrest, because students are assumed to be the first exercisers of political expression and markers of dissent.

This series of aggressions culminated on February 23, 2020, when a womens' sit-in against the CAA was confronted by right-wing activists in north-east Delhi's Jafrabad area, led by BJP's Cabinet Minister Kapil Mishra. As Mishra delivered an ultimatum to clear out the protest, violence erupted. This manifested in riots spanning multiple locations around Delhi over a week, in which a total of 53 people — two-thirds of whom were Muslims — were killed:

shot, slashed or set on fire, and more than 200 injured. Hundreds of properties — disproportionately Muslim-owned — were destroyed, including four mosques.

The prompts behind the current unrest — the passing of the CAA and the constrictive NRC — are the latest and perhaps most definitive motions towards the right-wing nationalists' idea of a Hindu nation. Punctuated with strategic flashpoints, the path that has led to this moment reveals the long and concerted spatial politics — once instrumentalized by India's colonizers, now by the Hindu right-wing — which call into question this country's idea of democracy and secularism.

One of the definitive moments in the historical development of radical Hindu nationalism was the demolition of the Babri Masjid. On December 6, 1992, Hindutva militants demolished the Babri Masjid, a 16th century mosque in the town of Ayodhya, Uttar Pradesh, prompting vast communal conflict across the country. Staged during a political rally of almost 200,000 participants, the demolition of the Babri Masjid marked a climax in a series of strategically orchestrated events, leveraging public space and sentiment within the "Ram Janmabhumi" narrative. A political movement cast in religious form, Hindu nationalists demanded the construction of a temple at the *janmabhumi* (mythical birthplace) of the Hindu god Ram following the demolition of the mosque. Babri Masjid, then, became operable as a strategic site for reclamation through aggression. The agitators were successfully able to impose their constructed image of the mosque as a symbol of Muslim atrocity and Hindu humiliation, exploiting myth to project religious meaning to an arbitrary site.

The Godhra train massacre followed 10 years later: 59 Hindu pilgrims returning from Ayodhya were killed in a fire inside the Sabarmati Express train, near Godhra, Gujarat. Evidently an horrific callback to the legacy of Babri Masjid and its ensuing violence, an investigation concluded that the fire was arson committed by a primarily Muslim mob of over 1,000 people. This in turn led to the 2002 Gujarat riots (also known as the Gujarat pogrom), wherein inter-communal violence shook the state over three months, culminating in 1,044 dead, 223 missing, and 2,500 injured, most of whom were Muslims. Under the aegis of Narendra Modi, then Chief Minister of Gujarat and current Prime Minister of India, the riots explicitly targeted the minority Muslim population, again resulting in further violent outbreaks nationwide.

Within the Gujarat pogrom, spatial configuration acted as a source of opportunity or restraint. An analysis of the neighborhoods worst affected by the ensuing violence point firstly towards a strategic identification of targets influenced by their spatial configuration — familiarity, morphology of streets, population of target demographic and possibilities of counter-attack. Secondly, it proves that beyond familiarity, the built environment itself has a significant contribution to the success or failure of an attack. It can facilitate or impede an attack depending on likely escape routes, segregation of neighborhoods, and vulnerability of the target. It is evident that not only does space reflect social relations but it can also actively facilitate social action through the manipulation, deployment and exploitation of spatial contexts.

Within the complexity of these decidedly urban confrontations, what stands out is the territorial antagonism and spatialization of violence. None of the above can be seen as isolated events: they form part of a complex historical development, precipitating in the spread and subsequent spatialization of Hindu nationalist ideology as well as the proliferation of right-wing power within India.

"PUNCTUATED WITH STRATEGIC FLASHPOINTS, THE PATH THAT HAS LED TO THIS MOMENT REVEALS THE LONG AND CONCERTED SPATIAL POLITICS — ONCE INSTRUMENTALIZED BY INDIA'S COLONIZERS, NOW BY THE HINDU RIGHT-WING — WHICH CALL INTO QUESTION THIS COUNTRY'S IDEA OF DEMOCRACY AND SECULARISM."

While an ethnocratic government does its best imitation of fascism in challenging the democratic and secular foundations of India, moments like Shaheen Bagh underline the pivotal importance of public space, of the *polis* and its streets as legitimate sites for democratic negotiation. Blunt legislation like the CAA and NRC, coupled with a heavily strategic sequence of spatialized aggression, set a marked contrast against crucial and spontaneous acts of resistance. Though moments like Shaheen Bagh become symbolic, as of yet and without more support, they fail to generate significant change in the legislative and judicial systems that target them today. Choreographies of oppression, exploitation, unfathomable inequalities and tendencies towards fascism are far from removed from the world. However, small gestures like a small group of women blocking a highway and making their voices heard have the symbolic power to generate greater actions of resistance — ripples of which can be felt across the world. ■

I would like to thank Shumi Bose for her constant support and guidance which were invaluable to this contribution.

Arinjoy Sen is currently a student of M.Arch architecture at the Bartlett School of Architecture, UCL in London. His focus ranges from the politics and aesthetics of architecture/space to the instrumentalization of spatial agents in socio-cultural and political phenomena. Drawing plays a crucial role in Arinjoy's work, where it becomes an apparatus and alternative space for the exploration and subsequent projection of thought processes and architectural discourse. Current research occupations include subaltern studies — towards a deconstruction of architecture's role within the realm of postcolonial discourse.

PAN-AFRICANISM

THE FUNAMBULIST Nº32

DENISE FERREIRA DA SILVA, ANNETTE JOSEPH-GABRIEL, AMZAT BOUKARI-YABARA, SOPHIA AZEB, ANA NAOMI DE SOUSA & SÓNIA VAZ BORGES, NTONE EDJABE, ABDOUMALIQ SIMONE, JOAO GABRIEL, AND NAMATA SERUMAGA-MUSISI.



The city of Allada in Benin wanted to honor Toussaint Louverture and, through him, the Haitian Revolution. They built a statue of the revolted General, and called him "Dignified Son of Allada." / Photo by Ozz 229 (September 2017).

INTRODUCTION

Welcome to the 32nd issue of The Funambulist. For once, we curated and coordinated its editorial line amongst the three of us (Caroline Honorien, Margarida Waco, and Léopold Lambert) in order to combine our perspectives on the topic. After our previous issues "Settler Colonialism in Turtle Island" and "Learning With Palestine," this particular issue dedicated to Pan-Africanism is the third one specific to a place in the world. Yet, we mean for this issue to interpret the geography of Pan-Africanism as a profoundly swaying one.

The African Continent is at the heart of this geography of course, and with it, the thousands of nations and non-settler diasporic groups that it hosts from Tunis to Cape Town, from Mogadishu to Dakar. But perhaps Pan-Africanism also extends to "map onto Blackness," as Denise Ferreira da Silva eloquently puts in our interview with her. Mapping onto Blackness, for us, incorporates the millions of Black people from the African diaspora in the Americas, the Carribeans, and Europe, whether they've been forcefully displaced in the Middle Passage or moved later throughout the world by way of opportunity or exile. But Blackness and Black movement does not stop there. While Blackness is usually discussed in the context of post-slavery societies, there exists other forms of blackness in broader colonial settings For instance, Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander nations in Australia embody "Blakness" (coined by KuKu and Erub/Mer artist Destiny Deacon) specific to their experiences of European colonialism stealing the lands on which they live, while the very name of Melanesians (Papuans, Kanak, Fijians, and Vanuatuans) — a name given by the European colonialists, but reclaimed by the Pacific Islanders it designates — bears in its very etymology the notion of blackness.

When deciding on the theme, our editorial argument departs from an understanding of Pan-Africanism as perhaps being the most ambitious political and cultural project in the world: a project transcending nation-states and unifying millions of people. It is a profoundly anti-colonial, anti-imperial and unifying political horizon that all people engaged in a liberation struggle can take inspiration from. Discussing the legacy and actualizations of Pan-Africanism, however, requires a high level of nuance as a comprehensive themed feature. Pan-Africanism is weaved by ebbs and flows, full of false starts and stops. At times, its black nationalist aspects have swerved into reductive narratives and dipped into essentialist discourses. Confronting these specters, as well as facing remergent Pan-Africanist currents and persistent myths has called for a crucial unravelling in our editorial endeavor. In this process, we have had to disambiguate words and come to terms with the contradictions of some Pan-Africanist idols.

As an editorial team of a magazine that consistently reaffirms its anti-colonial stance, confronting the legacies of these figures raises new questions. It has forced us to reconcile Pan-Africanism as the locus of divergent geographies, struggles, interests and strategies, with its internationalist claims. Who is African? From Brazil to Liberia, who is Indigenous and what does being Indigenous mean? How to turn fantasies of home and internationalist dreams into collective political action? These questions are thoroughly discussed by our contributors. As this particular issue attempts to articulate questions about the past, present and futurities of the Pan-African project through the perspectives of Africans and its diasporas, it is not solely concerned with the crucial discourses manifesting Pan-Africanist imaginaries as those put forward by Nkrumah, Senghor, Césaire, Fanon, Du Bois, et al. This issue attempts to provide a toolbox for solidarity and strategizing for global forms of solidarity, as expressed from the Haitian Revolution, the FRELIMO Liberation struggle in Mozambique, the anti-apartheid movement in South Africa, to the Black Lives Matter uprising to mention only a few illustrious examples.

As showcased by Algiers' Panaf 1969 and Lagos' Festac 77, turning to cultural festivals has proved to be most productive in our quest to locate past successes, failed attempts and its possible actualizations of movements. Caught between two influxes over the 20th century, African art was first concerned with finding an "African personality," a term coined by Edward Blyden and later popularized by Kwame Nkrumah, in the context of cultural nationalism. Likewise, artists from the diaspora sought self-affirmative Afrocentric aesthetics. Ultimately, these movements challenged and complicated colonial notions of Africanness, locality or nationalism. Pan-africanist cultural events and festivals allowed for the celebration of Black cultures, the reaffirmation of Afro-descendants unity in the global struggle against colonialism and anti-Blackness.

Our hope is that the dialogue created by the nine contributions to this issue's main dossier will be akin to Chimurenga's stunning maps (see the next double page for an example) tracing relationships between historical events, geographies, political figures, artists, books, and music. They simultaneously construct a non-imperial cartography of collective Pan-African imaginaries and provide an analytical framework to make sense of the interconnections between each of these temporal, spatial, biographical, artistic, literary, and musical components.

It is no accident that we conclude with an homage to Chimurenga, as we also pay tribute to those who have dedicated their entire life's work to documenting the Pan-African project. May this issue be a small token of our solidarity with them. We wish you an excellent read. ■

Margarida Nzuzi Waco is the head of strategic outreach of The Funambulist. She holds a degree in architecture and her research invokes the genealogies of neocolonial spatiality across the Continent. Originally hailing from Cabinda (Angola), thus politically displaced, consequently leading to exile in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, the Republic of Congo and subsequently Denmark, which has informed her quest to unravel notions of statelessness, dispossession and identity.

Léopold Lambert is a Paris-based trained architect and the founding editor of The Funambulist. Although his ancestry and current citizenship link him to no less than three colonizing European nations of the African Continent, and while bearing a much unfortunate first name acting as a reminder of this, he came to Pan-Africanism through (trans)formative radical encounters (people, organizations, places, authors, music, etc.) on/from the Continent (particularly in Johannesburg) and elsewhere.

When she is not editing with the Funambulist, Caroline Honorien works on her PhD on visual and sonic practices by French artists from the African diaspora. Her interest comes from a combination of her French Guianese-Antillean family history and encounters during the re-emergence of Black activism in France in the 2010s.

NEGRITUDE VS AFRO RADICALISM

"African culture will be revolutionary or will not be."











Set up Committee - Fortnight at Katalunia Republic

Senghor

Fela Kuti

Nigerian military regime

FESTAC 1977, LAGOS
'inventing the transnational black state'

University of Dakar renamed after Diop

dies in 1986

Work with UNESCO on "General History of Africa"

COLONIAL REGIMES

LIBERATION MOVEMENTS

"Manifeste culturel panafricain de l'OUA"

PANAF 1969, ALGERS
'culture as tool for liberation'

CODESRIA, 1973

Marcien Towa

Paulin Hountondji

Valentin Y. Mudimbe

Diop married "most influential African author of FESMAN of 20th century"

Guinea-Conakry

Malvina

Cuba

Algeria

FESMAN 1966, DAKAR
'celebrating Négritude'

Césaire

Senghor

Hassan II

Senghor is save African art'

vs.

Césaire 'develop African politics'

Sets up first African Radiocarbon Laboratory at University of Dakar

advocates for African unity and Federalism

becomes Senghor main political opponent

works are banned in Senegal

AMSAC

Nina Simone

LAGOS FESTIVAL OF 1961

AFRICA

EUROPE

returns to Senegal 1960

(Philadelphia 1960)

Anglophone rejection of negritude

AMERICAN SOCIETY OF AFRICAN CULTURE (AMSAC)

Second Congress ROME, 1959

- attacks on négritude by Diop, Fanon and Liberation movements

to ROME, 1959

"L'unité culturelle de l'Afrique noire"

"L'Afrique noire précoloniale"

proposes different historical background for African unity vs. Senghor emphasis on culture

publishes "Nations nègre et culture", 1954 with Présence Africaine

First Congress of Black Writers and Artists, PARIS 1956

'Cultural Bandung' - greatest assembly of black intellectuals of the time

FOUNDATION OF SOCIÉTÉ AFRICAINE DE CULTURE (SAC)

becomes secretary general of AERDA

doctoral thesis rejected in 1949

Librairie & Maison d'Editions, 1949

Alioune Diop — Présence Africaine, 1947

Aimé Césaire

Léopold Sédar Senghor

Léon Gontran Damas

Harlem

Haiti

Breton

Sartre

Léo Frobenius

Etiennne Léro, René Ménil, Jules Monnerot

Légitime Défense, 1932

PARIS COLONIAL EXPOSITION 1931

La Revue du Monde Noir, 1930

André and Paulette Nardal

André Gide wins Prix Goncourt 1927

René Maran wins Prix Goncourt 1921

France 1946

Saint Louis

*Senegal

CHEIKH ANTA DIOP

AFRICA

EUROPE

"Peau noire, masques blancs", 1952

fights for France in WWII

Martinique *

FRANTZ FANON

VS

Rome

"the Wretched of the Earth"

† 1961

Mali mission

Reopoldville 1960

to ROME, 1959

FLN representation in Accra 1958

links culture to racism vs. Senghor's cultural essentialism

Tunisia — edits El-Moudjahid

to PARIS, 1956

joins FLN, 1954

moves to Blida, Algeria Psychiatric Hospital 1953

A MOVIMENTO NEGRO UNIFICADO CONTRA A DISCRIMINAÇÃO RACIAL, 1978

Instituto de Pesquisa e Cultura Negra, 1975

Founding of ASSOCIAÇÃO CULTURAL DO NEGRO 1954

Teatro Experimental do Negro founded by Abdias do Nascimento, 1947

MOVIMENTO NEGRO

declared illegal 1937

FRENTE NEGRA BRASILEIRA, 1931

Black Paulista Press 1915

BRAZIL

CENTRE FOR AFRICAN STUDIES

Founded in 1950, Lisbon, Portugal

Amilcar Cabral

Agostinho Neto

Mario de Andrade

Marcelino dos Santos

Mensagem

First Caribbean Festival of Arts PUERTO RICO, 1952

CARIBBEAN

WEST INDIES FEDERATION, 1958 political federation of Caribbean States

First Carifesta in 1972

Federation abandoned in 1962, soon as utopian, writers et artists focus on creating a cultural union

Caribbean Writers and Artists convention, GEORGETOWN, 1966

CARIFESTA JAMAICA, 1976

dedicated to celebrating Caribbean Heroes

CARIFESTA CUBA, 1979

"Negritude vs. Afroradicalism." in *Chimurenga Chronic* October 2018. / Courtesy of Chimurenga.

MAPPING PAN-AFRICANISM ONTO BLACKNESS: THE CONTINENT, THE DIASPORA, AND BEYOND

WITH DENISE FERREIRA DA SILVA

In this opening interview, scholar Denise Ferreira Da Silva discusses the politics of Blackness in the context of Pan-Africanism. She touches upon its layers and breaks, ultimately pointing to how Pan-Africanism can be effective and extended to people beyond the Continent and its diaspora.

LÉOPOLD LAMBERT: When we talk about Pan-Africanism, the questions of "where" and "who" are crucial, although the impossibility to give an exhaustive answer to these questions is probably what makes the Pan-African project so inspiring too. In our own case, we're thinking of course of the Black Indigenous nations of the Continent, the African Diaspora in the World, but also the non-Black Africans, and we also wonder if there's a place for Black non-Africans such as Aboriginal people of the Australian continent, Maoris, Papuans, Tamils, etc. Could you lead us in your own fluid cartography of where Pan-Africanism is, and through which bodies it exists?

"OF COURSE, THOSE TWO SHIFTS ARE NOT UNEXPECTED, BUT I THINK APPROACHING PANAFRICANISM IN A MOVE FROM THE TEMPORAL TO THE SPATIAL [...] HAS IMPLICATIONS THAT ARE IMPORTANT TO HOW WE THINK ABOUT IT."

DENISE FERREIRA DA SILVA: Yes. There is something about, a reference to place in your question, which is conveyed by the names and references to both the "where" and the "who" as well as to bodies. I think it invites a shift from the historic to the geographic, and from the historical to the global, as a point of departure for approaching PanAfricanism. Of course, those two shifts are not unexpected, but I think approaching PanAfricanism in a move from the temporal to the spatial — so to speak — has implications that are important to how we think about it. But then, of course, when I say "historic" or "historical," I am and I am not referring to the history of PanAfricanism and its historical conditions of emergence and the historical conditions as they unfolded up to now. As you know, PanAfricanism was initially at least an anti-colonial left-oriented communist or socialist project. I mean, if we approach it historically, we can go back to the early 20th century and how it articulates a notion of self-determination in political and national like cultural historical terms, even though it's not framed as a nationalist project. But the idea of the national, the cultural, or the historical is very important to the assembling of the project. It is also very important to the possibilities suggested by your question. So, just bear with me as I go back to that, and then I come back to answering your question properly [laughs].

"IN MY VIEW, THIS KIND OF RACIAL SUBJUGATION IS CHARACTERIZED BY THE AUTHORITY TO DEPLOY TOTAL VIOLENCE, WHICH CAN BE TRACED TO SLAVERY AND COLONIAL SUBJUGATION, AND WHICH REMAINS OPERATIVE IN BLACKNESS, AS A CATEGORY."

Thinking of PanAfricanism in the context of the processes of independence and of the anti-colonial struggles, the nation-states that came out of it had to deal with the former colonizer, but also with the global apparatus set up in post World War II, like the U.N. and all its branches, and the Bretton Woods Organizations, etc. And they did so while they were engulfed by the Cold War, that is, by both the "hot" moments (seemingly endless independence wars fueled by the U.S. and the Soviet Union), as well as its "cold" (diplomatic and aid related international policies). And I think much of the transformative element of the anti-colonial project that was there in PanAfricanism from early on — I'm thinking back to the 1910s-1920s, when W.E.B. Du Bois was writing about PanAfricanism, and many others were involved — eventually dissolved... But anyway, I'm not going to go into this historical reference, since others in the issue will deal with it much more intelligently than I.

Thinking back and considering the 1910s and 1920s, the anti-colonial (also anti-imperial and anti-capitalist) mobilizations of which PanAfricanism was part, that is, also including the historic, I find it generative to make the shift from the historic to the geographic, but also from the historical to the global. Since early on, one can see PanAfricanism operating geographically, mapping onto the continent and the diaspora, with Africa as a place, and Africa as a place of origin. However, I find this limiting, of course, because Blackness in its political activation, including this anti-colonial activation has a reach, which is in a way always related to, but which exceeds the continent. For instance, if we move from the geographic to the global, and map PanAfricanism onto Blackness, it would include the Pacific. What I mean is that, as a racial category, Blackness is a global signifier, and, as such, it captures a particular kind of racial subjugation (which is now called anti-Blackness). In my view, this kind of racial subjugation is characterized by the authority to deploy total violence, which can be traced to slavery and colonial subjugation, and which remains operative in Blackness, as a category.

For this reason, Blackness is a descriptor that can be applied to other places, where one finds that kind of authority unleashed against bodies named Black, even if they are not part of the Atlantic slave trade and slavery in the Americas. I am thinking about non-African Black persons and populations, such as Aboriginal folks in Australia, as the Maori,



Mass at the Church of Our Lady of the Rosary of Black Men on Dia da Consciência Negra (Black Consciousness Day) in São Paulo, on November 20, 2017. / Photo by Rovena Rosa / Agência Brasil.

as Papuans, and Tamils. No wonder folks in the Pacific, for instance, having placed different kinds of Black expressions such as rastafarianism and hip hop.

Just to summarize: what I'm proposing is that, if we shift and think of it from geographically to globally, while retaining Blackness as a reference to PanAfricanism, it makes sense that the political concept of PanAfricanism then expands as a political descriptor for a political project that responds (resists or counters) in social contexts where Blackness is deployed to describe populations under a mode of racial subjugation characterized by the authority to deploy total violence.

CAROLINE HONORIEN: Up to the 1980s, the word "Black" referred to Commonwealth immigrants in the U.K. of African and South Asian descent, but also South Asians from the Indian subcontinent. From Black internationalism, to South Asian activism, without forgetting anti-Blackness, it is difficult to pinpoint exactly why this is not the case anymore. But it does pose questions on the place of non-Black people in Pan-Africanism but also of the existence of blackness(es) outside of the canonic Black diaspora. Could you address that?

DFS: Like you, Caroline, I don't know exactly why the shift did take place. But I know about this shift, because that's my generation's. I was coming out of age, in the 1980s, exactly as the shift was taking place. Back then, I was involved in the Black Brazilian movement. Much of my work has to do with reflecting on that moment, trying to make sense of what my generation did, I mean, that particular political moment. To me, it is a shift in the political discourse, in the lexicon and the grammar, itself; in particular, in terms of how what we would now call a "racial subject" should be articulated. In the case the U.K., as we know, up to the 1980s, maybe more explicitly than other places, but in the U.K.,for instance, the term "Black" included folks from the overseas holdings of the British Empire. That framing of the Black political subject foregrounded the colonial, as part the trajectory of PanAfricanism was talking about before — that is, the Black subject as a political subject is defined as the colonized or anticolonial subject. So the term "Black," as it foregrounded colonial subjugation under the British, obviously had the capacity to embrace folks from other visions of the Empire. Now this of course had a lot to do with the left orientation of that political discourse laying emphasis on economic subjugation and what happened in the 1980s.

"TO ME, IT IS A SHIFT IN THE POLITICAL DISCOURSE, IN THE LEXICON AND THE GRAMMAR, ITSELF; IN PARTICULAR, IN TERMS OF HOW WHAT WE WOULD NOW CALL A 'RACIAL SUBJECT' SHOULD BE ARTICULATED."

Anyways, I think the shift happened with my generation. In my case, for instance, in the early 1980s, I made the move from the Communist Party, to the Black movement. What happened then was precisely the ascension of culture as the basis for a political discourse, in particular, the emergence of what was then called identity-based social movements. To situate the shift, you can think in term of the framing of the political discourse in the field was — even if it included anti-colonial movements — basically divided between the liberal framing of the political in which you know, that privileged the juridical, in which you have political parties, the state, the unions, and the left framing in in which you have a division between the working class and the capitalists right, the one

that privileged the economic. Of course, social movements — Black and feminist, for instance — did not emerge in the 1980s; they were there before. In any event, the shift that took place in the 1980s was marked by the emergence of social movements that took cultural difference and identity as the basis for the delineation and the definition of their base for representation.

"SO, IN RECLAIMING BLACK CULTURE, WE HAD TO RECLAIM FROM WITHIN THE NATION INSTEAD OF JUST CELEBRATING OR PROPOSING SOMETHING UNIQUELY OR EXCLUSIVELY BLACK. OUR STRUGGLE WAS FOR THE RECOGNITION THAT CERTAIN KNOWN CULTURAL PRACTICES WERE EXCLUSIVELY BLACK."

More importantly, if you think in terms of the racially based movements like the Black movement, that notion of culture is not the one that I mentioned before in regards to PanAfricanism, which could be called "cultural-historical" and was modelled after the notion of the nation. What emerges — or perhaps consolidates in the 1980s political discourse — is what can be called an anthropological or sociological notion of culture, the one that fixes, that highlights borders — borders that also take into account racial difference. They close and fix the borders of the political subject by rendering it racially contained. In the case of the U.K., the effects are more evident, as the term "Black" was broken along racial lines — even within the general term BAME (Black, Asian, and minority Ethnics) which no longer convey a colonial enveloping.

However, I think the issue now is whether there will emerge a version of PanAfricanism that both reflects what's covered in what we mentioned before, that has the capacity to embrace the non-Black (of African Descent) populations? A version of PanAfricanism, as we were talking before, that recalls the anti-colonial framing of Blackness. And I think that's a possibility; precisely because of the current global conditions as we see being more dramatically in the U.S., with this resurfacing of white supremacy under Trump, but also in Europe. Perhaps its explicit fascist orientation, precisely because of its element of total violence, might recall the anti-colonial framing of the political subject that we left behind back in the 1980s. But who knows?

"PERHAPS ITS EXPLICIT FASCIST ORIENTATION, PRECISELY BECAUSE OF THE TOTAL VIOLENT ELEMENT OF IT, MIGHT RECALL THE ANTI-COLONIAL FRAMING OF THE POLITICAL SUBJECT THAT WE LEFT BEHIND BACK IN THE 1980S."

LL: Just as a small follow up, do you think that, in the context of Brazil specifically, the ultimate victory against the military dictatorship, which is right in the middle of the 1980s, might have played any role in that?

DFS: Well, it's difficult to say no. Of course, the military dictatorship delineated the immediate struggle, the specificity of the local conditions, but I think it was more of a shift that was a global shift in the political discourse. I remember how, in the early 1980s, while we were all still very much organizing and protesting against the military dictatorship, many of us who are involved in the Black Brazilian and other social movements. Back then in college, we were reading what was coming out in the literature and social movements. In that critical literature in which the notion of the culture was very much brought forward as an important political concept. My inclination is to see the shift as a global one. But then, of course, in different contexts, social movements had to deal with different issues. So, while in the U.S., you could have someone like Ron Karenga on the Afrocentrics successfully proposing Black celebrations, such as Kwanza. In Brazil, we couldn't do that, because of Black culture in Brazil was part of national culture. So, in reclaiming Black culture, we had to reclaim from within the nation instead of just celebrating or proposing something uniquely or exclusively Black. Our struggle was for the recognition that certain known cultural practices were exclusively Black. That was one difference. But in general, I think the general grammar, I mean, the political text was the same.

CH: Since the mid-1970s, it seems that a shift occurred from Pan-Africanist discourses and its internationalism to discourses revolving around the "African diaspora," a diaspora that actually accounts for continental Africans as well. We went from Jamaican political activist Marcus Garvey's foundational Pan-Africanist myth of return to Africa to Martiniquean poet and philosopher Édouard Glissant discourse in *Politics of Relation* (2009) talking about the relevance of the Africanization of the Caribbean. Could you tell us how and why such a shift happened in your opinion?

DFS: I think this is part of the same shift of the basis of the political discourse that I was talking about before, in regard to the trajectory of PanAfricanism, but also the changes that we just talked about in the U.K.. But, one thing I did not mention in relationship to PanAfricanism — because I was focusing on the Marxist aspect of the project — is the fact that at least with Marcus Garvey (and others in the early 20th century), the basis for identification was very much racial. The United Negro Association was racially based, it wasn't necessarily anti-colonial, and it actually had its own colonial desires (and plans for the improvement of the race) attached to it. But the idea of an African diaspora, which is, insofar as slavery did force people out of the continent, there is such a thing. Hence, that is a diaspora. There is a group of people to which the name diaspora can be applied. That has been there all along.

The difference is how it is mobilized. We can approach the shift in terms of changes of the same entity when talking about the African diaspora, but that is too Hegelian, even for me! Though I like to spend time thinking against or unthinking Hegel, I prefer to see these shifts in terms of the political discourse; shifts that reflect the rearrangement of the global political economic context, both on the national level and the regional level. And then as I mentioned before, as onto-epistemological shifts, in terms of knowledge, of the formulations and concepts that become part of the political lexicon and enter in the articulation of political subjects. So I think that the African diaspora has been "redefined," in definite moments in response to both global and onto-epistemological shifts.

LL: The Pan-African project is, of course, not just a geographic project; far from it, and the question of the cultural imaginary linked to it is as much what makes it exist as the land on which it takes roots. Can you tell us what aspects of this imaginary are particularly important to you?

DFS: I'll separate the imaginary from the cultural. I leave the cultural behind because, if I keep it, things will become complicated, because of what I said earlier. Perhaps a bit indirectly but, in a couple of answers, I did a sort of a genealogy of the concept of the culture, of how it has changed over many hundred years, from the cultural-historical (nationalist) anti-colonial projects to the social scientific cultural (anthropological, sociological) of the 1980s, etc. A PanAfrican imaginary, if considered in view of the global political architecture, that imaginary has a lot to offer.

Again, it comes down to the anti-colonial aspect of it; in particular, as it foregrounds juridical domination and economic subjugation. So a PanAfrican imaginary would allow us to look at the global present in such a way that we can immediately grasp economic dispossession, extraction, and exploitation as it affects people of color, Indigenous populations across national, regional, and local borders. A PanAfrican imaginary allows us to speak of Black subjugation in the same breath as we speak of settler colonialism. Even considering all the differences between where I am right now — the situation of the First Nations throughout Canada — what's happening to Indigenous populations across the Continent — in the Americas as a whole — and what's happening to the Black populations in the U.S., Brazil, and elsewhere. Precisely because if with an anti-colonial frame, the PanAfrican immediately foregrounds the juridic and economic, as it animates demands that we ask the question of subjugation. It does so, not solely from the point of view of the Black subject, organizing, coming together, fighting for emancipation, as the concept of the cultural (historical and social scientific) does, and in doing so also closes off, sutures, and fixes.

A PanAfrican project with an anticolonial imaginary will focus upon conditions that bring about subjugation. I'm just feeling like an old fashioned Marxist talking this way, but, well, that's where the reflection takes me! Anyway, I do think we need more of that. Not that Marxism can deliver it; it can't. But that is why a PanAfrican anticolonial imaginary becomes necessary, precisely because historical materialism cannot do it all by itself.

CH: In many respects, Pan-Africanism as a political movement questions our sense of belonging as people of African descent. Belonging to a transnational community, but also to a territory. The idea that the diaspora's destiny is tightly knitted to the continent and its inhabitants still remains. Even as a cultural movement, Pan-Africanism is tied to Négritude and other cultural nationalisms that have been concerned with this sense of belonging and home. Nowadays discourses around Blackness are prevalent. Blackness on the other hand, is a political identification endorsed by people of African descent, that goes beyond time and place. In the diaspora as well as on the continent, blackness is fluid and multiple. How can we think about how Blackness complicates our understanding of Pan-Africanism and, maybe, its past aporias?

DFS: I have been responding to your questions by suggesting that PanAfricanism, if approached globally, has a correspondence to Blackness — but in a more conceptual sense. And then, of course, because Blackness is a racial category that captures this subjugation of people of African descent, including in the Continent — I'm thinking of South Africa in this case. It's a matter of the claim. if it is a claim of belonging along the cultural anthropological lines, so Blackness and even PanAfricanism breaks apart. It's not only that Blackness would complicate our understanding of PanAfricanism or the other way around, they just break apart because they are fixed and then and all the different divisions come to the fore.

"SO A PANAFRICAN IMAGINARY WOULD ALLOW US TO LOOK AT THE GLOBAL PRESENT IN SUCH A WAY THAT WE CAN IMMEDIATELY GRASP ECONOMIC DISPOSSESSION, EXTRACTION, AND EXPLOITATION AS IT AFFECTS PEOPLE OF COLOR, INDIGENOUS POPULATIONS ACROSS NATIONAL, REGIONAL, AND LOCAL BORDERS. A PANAFRICAN IMAGINARY ALLOWS US TO SPEAK OF BLACK SUBJUGATION IN THE SAME BREATH AS WE SPEAK OF SETTLER COLONIALISM."

Now, as I was saying before, when I was going all Marxist about it, it is a claim of subjugation (economic, juridical, ethical, and symbolic): common history of extraction, subjection to total violence, being ethical indifference, and of being presented subjectable to humiliation. Then Blackness and Pan-Africanism become just different perspectives from which we make the claim and assemble political statements and programs on the basis of the same historical-global conditions and events. Maybe that's the kind of conversation we may want to have now. Since I don't think we should be tied to any particular formulation of the political subject or the racial subject. So what kind of claim actually makes sense given the current political conditions, particularly given the ways in which extraction, total violence and humiliation become so prevalent in descriptions and considerations of Black existence.

LL: I am trying to think through something you just talked about: this relationship to settler colonialism. I wonder if we can say that Black people on the other side of the Ocean from the Continent could be politically defined as non-settler inhabitants on Indigenous land? And I wonder if Pan-Africanism is in any way present in the relationships that Black people in all the Americas have or don't have with Indigenous nations of Turtle Island, South America, and the Carribean?

DFS: We have quite a bit of work to do in regards to how to think Black subjugation in the settler colonial context, and also in the distinct settler colonial contexts on this side of the Atlantic. So to the first part of the question about whether Black people can be considered or should be considered non-settlers, evidently, we are not settlers, because the reasons

why we are here, those of us who are a descendant of slaves — never forget that there are other Black people who are not — it was not our decision to come, and there was no decision to stay. So that's obviously not on the one hand.

But then on the other hand, Black populations in the Americas do not inhabit these national or regional or local contexts in the same way as white populations precisely because of the history of racial subjugation that followed slavery. And I'm thinking primarily in that definition of Black subjugation that I shared before; the authorized violence, but also humiliation and extraction. So we are not settlers and we have not conquered and colonized.

On the...third hand (!), how do we describe, how can we make sense of both Black subjugation and of a Black political project, given that positionality to use the term? I think there, again, an anti-colonial PanAfrican imaginary becomes important. For one thing, and that's the simplest thing possible, it connects the population that descends from slaves to the populations that were colonized in the Continent. This gives the intuition of a similarity that does not have to be actualized in the Americas because the trajectory of Black folks here are different, but of a similarity of a colonial trajectory shared by Indigenous populations here and Indigenous populations on the African Continent. The idea is that Blackness, because it's a move from Blackness considered from within the national contexts, which allows us to make sense of the trajectories, but also prevents us from thinking about the larger context of possibility for existing as Black persons in the Americas, anywhere.

"THE IDEA IS THAT BLACKNESS, BECAUSE IT'S A MOVE FROM BLACKNESS CONSIDERED FROM WITHIN THE NATIONAL CONTEXTS, WHICH ALLOWS US TO MAKE SENSE OF THE TRAJECTORIES, BUT ALSO PREVENTS US FROM THINKING ABOUT THE LARGER CONTEXT OF POSSIBILITY FOR EXISTING AS BLACK PERSONS IN THE AMERICAS, ANYWHERE."

So moving from that to a global, but primarily colonial context, which, with slavery, colonialism, and settler colonialism make sense along the lines of the colonization of the Continent itself. Such an approach, for instance, would allow folks — Black folks in particular — to make sense of our investment in the settler colonial state: the making of demands for rights to the settler colonial state is an act, a statement that legitimizes the settler colonial state as such, and its constructions as acceptable, as correct. When we make those claims, then the violence that has made those states possible, is also erased. So if the Black political discourse takes into account this triangle, this connection, the American context and colonialism in the Continent, and the slave trade that connects the two (Americas and Africa), if we think with that triangle in mind, we will be more attentive to the kinds of claims made to the settler colonial state and perhaps understand why they are never met because they are never supposed to be attended.

LL: In the political definition I indicated, I was less attached to the idea of Black folks in the Americas being "non-settlers" — because, as you said, it is evident — but I was more thinking about this idea of inhabiting Indigenous land. Do you think that there's something in this relation between Black folks in the Americas and the many Indigenous nations of this double continent that goes beyond their common experience of European violence? And can Pan-Africanism perhaps, give us a hint about this?

DFS: Yes, that's interesting. In Brazil, what we have, for the most part, especially to talk about culture, in the anthropological sense, in many of these cultural elements, some cannot distinguish what would be Indigenous and what would be Black, but, for the most part, everything is very much mixed. For instance, we have Indigenous medicine men (*Pages*) who are also *pais de santo* (leaders in Umbanda, which is an Afro-Brazilian religion). There is no contradiction in that. But then when I think of here, but then of course, here I'm a migrant. I'm an immigrant.

I live in the Musqueam reservation, which is very close to the university [University of British Columbia in Vancouver], which is located on unceded Musqueam land. I pay rent to the Musqueam because they own the place where I live. There are two forests nearby: the Musqueam forest (in front of my house) and the Pacific Spirit Regional Park (five minutes away). After living here for almost five years, earlier this year, I was walking in the Pacific Spirit Park, which is gorgeous; it's like fairytale forests. I was looking at some parts of the forest and really wondering whether or not they were sacred. I'm sure many of them are, but I don't know. So no matter how long I live here, I will never know. While my landlords, my Musqueam neighbors, will always know because the knowledge is passed from generation to generation.

Why was I wondering about it? Because I grew up in an Afro-Brazilian religion, learning about things sacred, places and practices, about places that are sacred, like, you know, waterfalls, or sacred places. Maybe it's that distinction I tried to make in your question before about imaginary and the cultural. So on the one hand, you could, I will never know if it is about the cultural, or it's about the content. But if we think of the imaginary is just this image of existence, this frame, that is a frame for growing up in Brazil, in the middle of Afro-Brazilian religion that gives me that frame. And that allows for the question of, is it a sacred place? Even though I'll never know the answer. Around that, along these lines, yes, I think there is something that is not immediately given by colonial violence.

CH: The Atlantic slave trade, colonization, and Apartheid have all challenged the humanity of people of African descent around the world. Can you talk about the ways Pan-Africanism did, tried, or failed to reclaim this humanity, but also contrast this trial to what is happening around this concept in Black discourse today. I was thinking about how racism hast emerged with the slave trade, was based on denying of the humanity of Black people based on their reason, and I was



Afrobrazilian Black Lives Matter organizers in front of the Zumbi dos Palmares monument, in Rio de Janeiro, on June 7, 2020. / Photo by Jorge Hely Veiga.

thinking about Léopold Sédar Senghor who, at one point, talked about how emotion was Negro and the reason was Greek? And now we have thinkers, such as Sylvia Wynter, who would rather cancel the concepts of humanity and reason altogether. Could you address that?

DFS: I feel that I can't answer the question and if I were to answer the question, it would not make sense because in a way, my argument is rather similar to Wynter's in relation to humanity. The other reason why it would not make sense is because I chose to answer the question about PanAfricanism by privileging the juridical and economic aspect and not so much the ethical basis for the demand. And I did that, because I knew if I had started from the ethical basis for the demand, which takes us to the concept of the cultural, then it would not have been possible to answer any of the questions. Because then I would have to qualify more than I did in terms of how the concept of the cultural has shifted, etc. So that's why it's very difficult.

Yet, in saying that, I am answering your question. But the last part of the question about the concept of humanity in the Black discourse today, I am not sure if I can say much about that. But thinking of Black Lives Matter, because "Black lives matter" is an ethical claim. It's a claim that Black lives have value. But if you take the phrase all by itself, it doesn't go back to humanity. It doesn't say *Black lives matter because we are humans*. It doesn't go all the way there, which means that you can take that ethical statement and then attach it to two different ethical bases that do not return and recall the very discourse that within which Black lives don't matter. That's the problem that makes it so very difficult to talk about in ethical terms, because the prevailing discourse, even as it operates as the basis for political discourse, the ethical core of those discourses is precisely the one that devalues Blackness and where Blackness or anything identified as such, is subjectable to authorized violence and extraction and humiliation. So while I was going to refuse to answer the question, that refusal is really impossible. Because starting today, we have to shift all of that. So... Black Lives Matter. ■

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THE HAITIAN REVOLUTION IN PAN AFRICANIST THOUGHT

ANNETTE JOSEPH-GABRIEL

Pan-Africanism was not even a word. But to this day, the Haitian Revolution is hailed as a pivotal moment in the struggle for Black liberation. This article by Annette Joseph-Gabriel examines the legacy and the uses of this rebellion against slavery and settler colonialism in the Pan-Africanist literary imaginary.



"Toussaint Louverture," digital preparatory artwork by Raphaël Barontini (2019).

"WHEN ENSLAVED PEOPLE IN FRANCE'S MOST PROSPEROUS COLONY DECLARED THEIR HUMANITY, FREEDOM, AND RIGHT TO SELF-GOVERNMENT, THEREBY CREATING THE FIRST FREE BLACK REPUBLIC IN THE NEW WORLD, IT STRUCK A FATAL BLOW TO THE INSTITUTION OF SLAVERY THAT WAS FELT THROUGHOUT THE ATLANTIC WORLD."

The Haitian Revolution is one of the most significant acts of Black liberation in the Pan African imaginary. Haitian historian Michel Rolph Trouillot described it as an "unspeakable" event. When enslaved people in France's most prosperous colony declared their humanity, freedom, and right to self-government, thereby creating the first free Black republic in the New World, it struck a fatal blow to the institution of slavery that was felt throughout the Atlantic world. The Haitian Revolution was indeed unspeakable, because it represented colonists' deepest fears made manifest.

It is therefore no surprise that Haiti's revolutionary history has been simultaneously disavowed by imperialists, venerated by descendants of the enslaved, fiercely debated in scholarship, and abundantly represented in fiction. Reflecting on the Haitian Revolution today requires looking simultaneously back at a long intellectual tradition of Black thought, and forward to the world that enslaved people imagined in the moment when Saint Domingue became Haiti, a world that for many is yet to come. This simultaneous reflection on the future and the past encapsulates the ethos of *sankofa*, the Akan vision of new knowledge as composed of a series of returns. For this reason, Pan African thinkers have taken up the Haitian Revolution in three primary ways: as an expression of the ideals of freedom and equality, as a reflection on the promises and pitfalls of Black leadership, and as an avenue to explore the vital, everyday contributions of Black people to global history.

"THIS RECOGNITION REMEDIED CRUCIAL GAPS AND ERASURES IN HISTORICAL NARRATIVES THAT SAW BLACK PEOPLE AS AN AFTERTHOUGHT."

In 1925, in the midst of the United States' occupation of Haiti, African American author Anna Julia Cooper defended her dissertation "*L'attitude de la France à l'égard de l'esclavage pendant la révolution*" ("Slavery and the French Revolutionists") at the Sorbonne, in which she examined the intertwined nature of the French and Haitian Revolutions and highlighted the historical significance of the actions of the enslaved. A little over a decade later, against the backdrop of Italy's invasion of Ethiopia, the Trinidadian historian and playwright C.L.R. James published *The Black Jacobins* (1938), a text that remains today a landmark historical account of the Haitian Revolution. *The Black Jacobins* is one of James's many writings and rewritings of Toussaint Louverture's revolutionary leadership, reflections that were as much about 20th century anticolonial struggles throughout the Black world as they were about Haiti's overthrow of slavery.

With his essay "Africa and the French Revolution" (1961), W.E.B. Du Bois took his place in an intellectual tradition that emphasized the deep imbrication of the French and Haitian revolutions. Du Bois explained that more than the United States and French revolutions, it was Haiti's freedom struggle that most incarnated the ideal of liberty and equality for all, and not simply for a small caste of land and slave-owning bourgeoisie. For Du Bois writing in the early 1960s, the stakes of recognizing what was radical about Haiti's demands for freedom were incredibly high. This recognition remedied crucial gaps and erasures in historical narratives that saw Black people as an afterthought. To this end, he began his account of the Revolution with the following provocation: "If you should penetrate the campus of an American Ivy League college and challenge a Senior, ask what, in his opinion, was the influence of Africa on the French Revolution, he would answer in surprise if not pity, 'None'." With this opening, Du Bois establishes his account of Haiti's contribution to the Enlightenment as a pedagogical project of writing back to a whitewashed historical record. His essay illuminates a crucial fact: to write the Haitian Revolution is to rewrite history.

The geography that Du Bois' essay traced in its publication and circulation, attests to the Pan Africanist nature of its pedagogical project. "Africa and the French Revolution" first appeared in the African American journal *Freedomways* in summer 1961. The daily newspaper *Ghana Evening News* republished it later that year. In 1962 it took on a new form as a pamphlet printed by a Nigeria-based publisher. Du Bois may have been writing *to* a hypothetical elite U.S. student audience about Haiti, but he was very much writing *for* a global Black audience.

Du Bois' project of placing Haiti at the center of a transatlantic story of freedom, finds its poetic parallel in Aimé Césaire's *Notebook of a Return to the Native Land*, in which the Martinican poet invokes "Haiti is where negritude rose for the first time and stated that it believed in its humanity." Césaire's allusion to the Haitian Revolution does something very interesting to Western ideas about linear time. Negritude, an artistic and intellectual movement that sought to valorize Blackness and articulate a shared Black diasporic history and identity, began among a community of African and Caribbean students in Paris in the 1930s. It has sometimes been described as a francophone Pan Africanism. Although this description is not entirely accurate, Negritude does have fundamental tenets in common with Pan Africanism's vision that Black people around the world have a shared history and culture.

"IF THE CLAIM THAT NEGRITUDE EXISTED BEFORE THE NEGRITUDE MOVEMENT SEEMS CIRCULAR, IT IS BECAUSE IT PRESENTS AN ALTERNATE SPACE-TIME THAT REFUSES THE LINEARITY OF WESTERN TIME. [...] TIME BENDS BACK ON ITSELF AND THE REVOLUTIONARY PAST IS THE FUTURE."

Césaire himself has been credited as one of the founders of Negritude. However, when the Martinican poet evokes the Haitian Revolution in *Notebook*, he presents a different genealogy. The formal Negritude movement may have begun in Paris between the two World Wars, but its spirit and ethos go back to the moment when enslaved Africans liberated themselves and declared the free and independent Republic of Haiti. If the claim that Negritude existed before the Negritude movement seems circular, it is because it presents an alternate space-time that refuses the linearity of Western time. In Césaire's sankofa-like vision, the Haitian Revolution is one of multiple sites of return. Time bends back on itself and the revolutionary past is the future. With a deceptively simple allusion, Césaire shows how the Pan Africanist ideals of Black liberation that undergirded the Haitian Revolution were also timely centuries later when he wrote *Notebook* in 1939. They remain critical in our current moment.



"Bug-Jargal," artwork by Raphaël Barontini (2017). / Screen-printing and digital print on fabric, volcanic sand.

The idea of the Haitian Revolution remains a powerful force that guides contemporary visions of Black freedom. But confining it to the abstract realm of symbolism alone, obscures the agency of the very real people who wrested their liberty from their enslavers, sometimes with their bare hands. In his work, historian Laurent Dubois includes crucial information about the guerilla tactics that enslaved people employed during the revolution: "A group of women attacked the French troops while wearing mattresses to protect themselves from musket fire. As one early account of the war put it, 'everywhere the land harbored enemies, in the woods, behind a rock; liberty gave birth to them'." (*Haiti: The Aftershocks of History*, 2012).

"LIKE THE GUERILLA TACTICS THEY EMPLOYED, THEIR PRESENCE IN THE ARCHIVE IS SPECTRAL, SHADOWY. HOWEVER, CONSTRUCTING A HISTORY OF WHAT CAROLYN FICK CALLS 'THE HAITIAN REVOLUTION FROM BELOW,' MAKES IT POSSIBLE TO RESIST ARCHIVAL ERASURE AND TO FOREGROUND THEIR CONTRIBUTIONS."

The ideal of liberty remains at the core of this account of the revolution. Yet in the intriguing image of grassroots fighting, it is not only the handful of prominent male leaders such as Toussaint Louverture and Jean Jacques Dessalines who define liberty, it is also the thousands of unnamed captives who incarnate the very idea of freedom. Like the guerilla tactics they employed, their presence in the archive is spectral, shadowy. However, constructing a history of what Carolyn Fick calls "the Haitian Revolution from below," makes it possible to resist archival erasure and to foreground their contributions.

Who were the mattress-clutching women who defied death in the fight for their freedom? Where the archives remain tight-lipped, fiction creates possibilities for imagining otherwise. Caribbean novels such as Marie Vieux Chauvet's *Dance on the Volcano*, Alejo Carpentier's *The Kingdom of this World*, Isabel Allende's *Island Beneath the Sea*, and Évelyne Trouillot's *The Infamous Rosalie*, do this work of imagining the varying freedom dreams of those who remained invisible or muted in official historical accounts of the Haitian Revolution. Their protagonists are enslaved Africans, free women of color, and children coming of age under the brutal conditions of plantation slavery, whose often-ignored perspectives become the focal lens for seeing the Haitian Revolution anew.

Unlike Cooper, James, Du Bois, and Césaire, whose writings about Haiti's liberation explicitly engaged with Pan African concepts of recovering Black history and centering that history in a broader global narrative, these novelists are not Pan Africanists in a traditional sense. Their writings nevertheless also undertake the recovery of Black humanity, creativity, resistance, and liberation that is at the heart of Pan Africanism.

While these novels contribute to Pan Africanist thought, they also complicate it significantly. Évelyne Trouillot's story, *The Infamous Rosalie*, in particular, disrupts the heroic framing of earlier narratives about the Haitian Revolution. *The Infamous Rosalie* is inspired by the historical account of an enslaved midwife in Saint Domingue who took the lives of the children in her care so that they would not have to endure slavery. Throughout the novel, the story of the midwife, fictionalized as the protagonist's great aunt Brigitte, remains — to return to Rolph Trouillot's formulation — *unspeakable*. The young protagonist, Lisette, comes of age in the shadow of this story that haunts the women in her family although they refuse to recount it. Lisette eventually learns the story as the rumblings of the revolution draw near, and it inspires her to undertake her ultimate act of resistance.

What is particularly poignant about the novel is that because it is not invested in writing back to a whitewashed historical canon, it departs from the Pan Africanist focus on Black resistance struggle as always heroic, to think about the tragedy and pain of what is lost through struggle. Through her act of mercy killing, the enslaved midwife uses the power that is available to her to resist the continued commodification of Black people over generations. But that power is limited, and her act does not easily fit into a victorious narrative of resistance.

These contemporary literary representations of the Haitian Revolution allow us to reflect on a critical question that Pan Africanism has sought to answer in various ways: what is the common thread that unifies Black people worldwide? Is it, as the Senegalese poet and politician Léopold Sedar Senghor claimed, a shared African essence? Is it the history of Black uprooting and displacement during the slave trade and slavery in Americas whose effects Caribbean writers such as Césaire, Maryse Condé, and others have explored in their works? Or is it the political unification of African states for which Kwame Nkrumah, Shirley Graham, Du Bois and Eslanda Robeson advocated? It is perhaps not a coincidence that the titles of the novels cited here invoke spaces that are central to Black diasporic constructions of identity. Taken together, the volcano, the kingdom, the island, and the slave ship (*The Infamous Rosalie*), constitute a map of Black historical, cultural, and political presence in the modern world.

"TAKEN TOGETHER, THE VOLCANO, THE KINGDOM, THE ISLAND, AND THE SLAVE SHIP (THE INFAMOUS ROSALIE), CONSTITUTE A MAP OF BLACK HISTORICAL, CULTURAL, AND POLITICAL PRESENCE IN THE MODERN WORLD."

The nuanced view that Trouillot's novel offers, nudges us to think beyond the Haitian Revolution as success or failure. Neither romance nor tragedy, it underscores for us today the radical political vision that emerged when those that Europe had cast out of its conception of the human rose up to assert their humanity as Black people and their regard for Black lives. Pan Africanist thinkers have long understood Haiti's struggle for independence as the opening salvo in an on-going battle for Black freedom from imperialism on a global scale. It is an example to be emulated and a cautionary tale. But above all, it is incomplete, because the ideals of liberty and sovereignty that crystallized in the revolutionary period, remain ever urgent today in the face of fascism's unapologetic rise. ■

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"BUT ABOVE ALL, IT IS INCOMPLETE, BECAUSE THE IDEALS OF LIBERTY AND SOVEREIGNTY THAT CRYSTALLIZED IN THE REVOLUTIONARY PERIOD, REMAIN EVER URGENT TODAY IN THE FACE OF FASCISM'S UNAPOLOGETIC RISE."

PAN-AFRICAN RISING IN HARLEM, ACCRA, AND DAR ES SALAAM: CONNECTING PLACES, EXPANDING STRUGGLES

AMZAT BOUKARI-YABARA

This article by Amzat Boukari-Yabara is a mandatory reminder of Pan-Africanism history since its inception, in particular in three of its geographic poles: Harlem, Accra, and Dar es Salaam. His text maps a story of transnational resistance, circulation, and exchanges across the Atlantic.

Born in the resistance to deportation and enslavement of Africans in the Americas and the Caribbean, Pan-Africanism is the history of Black socio-political experiences that transcend geographical boundaries. Intersecting anti-racism, anti-capitalism, and anti-colonialism with a high regard on African roots, Pan-Africanism called early for emancipation and repatriation. Whether it be the hundreds of Jamaican Maroons or freed Africans sent by the British in Sierra Leone, or the colonization of Liberia by 15,000 Black Americans, the first Back-to-Africa migrations were controlled by Western colonial interests. As Nemata Blyden mentioned in *West Indians in West Africa, 1808-1880* (2000), many Black people believed that their experience in the christianized and so-called "civilized" New World gave them a right upon Indigenous Africans.

"IN THE LARGEST WORLD METROPOLITAN AREA, WITH RESIDENTS COMING FROM ALL OVER THE U.S., THE CARIBBEAN, AND AFRICA, HARLEM WAS A MICROCOSM OF THE BLACK WORLD AT A TIME WHEN PAN-AFRICANISM FOUND A NEW POLITICAL IMPETUS."

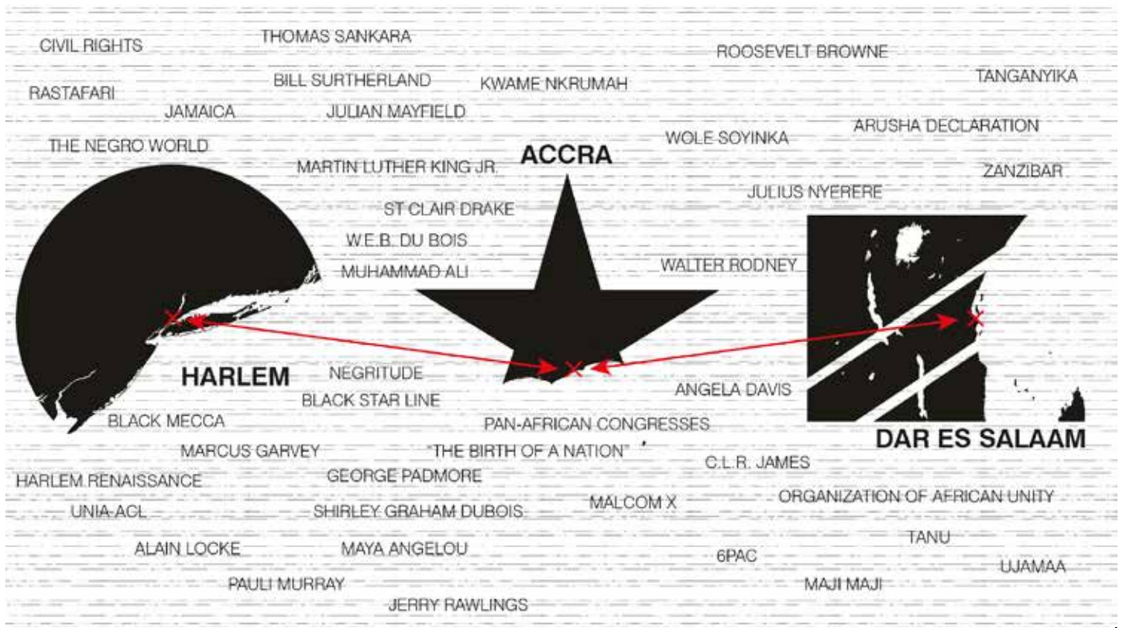
This vision changed radically when, the 1920s Harlem Renaissance and Pan-African Congresses — then the 1930s Rastafari and Negritude movements — emerged and articulated new networks between London, New York, Kingston, Paris, and Addis-Ababa. After World War II, the U.S. Civil Rights and Black Power movements respectively led by Martin Luther King Jr. and Malcolm X, the battle for African freedom launched by George Padmore and Kwame Nkrumah, and the final disillusionments of the Sixth Pan-African Congress in 1974 that spanned Harlem, Accra, and Dar es Salaam in a geopolitics of the Black world. This text does not pretend to exhibit thousands of Afrodiasporics, in other words African Americans, Caribbeans, Afro-Brazilians, and so on, who lived within intersections and schisms in the genealogy of Pan-Africanism but, rather, to sketch the principles of Pan-Africanism on a map.

Harlem, African Fountain of Youth ///

During the Reconstruction following the abolition of slavery in the United States, Black people organized themselves and gained political power by ruling several local communities in the South. However, in 1896, the institutionalization of racial segregation reinforced the vision of the U.S. as a large prison for Black people. Moreover, due to the economic crisis, millions of Black people left the rural South and joined northern industrial metropolises. The progressive reputation of the northern states vanished as Black people were segregated in urban ghettos. After the "racial riots" of the Red Summer of 1919, a new generation of Black activists decided to fight oppression by any means necessary.

The New York neighborhood of Harlem became the center of this new kind of resistance. In the largest world metropolitan area, with residents coming from all over the U.S., the Caribbean, and Africa, Harlem was a microcosm of the Black world at a time when Pan-Africanism found a new political impetus. From 1919 to 1927, in Paris, London, Brussels, Lisbon, and finally New York, Pan-African Congresses took place under the leadership of W.E.B. Du Bois. On August 1, 1920, a decade of Black political dystopia emerged in the streets of Harlem when 2,000 delegates from 22 countries opened the First International Convention of the Negro Peoples of the World organized by Marcus Garvey's Universal Negro Improvement Association and African Communities League (UNIA-ACL). With the world's highest concentration of conscious Black people, artists, musicians, and writers, Harlem produced a new intelligentsia that Alain Locke studied in *The New Negro* anthology published in 1925.

Harlem Black bourgeoisie and middle class constituted the social base of Du Bois' activism based on the "talented tenth" doctrine, while Garvey was the champion of proletarian, women, and youth groups. Through his powerful speeches on Negro pride and Black awakening, Garvey stimulated the feelings of many Black people who rejected European culture assimilated to slavery, racism and colonialism, and wanted to learn more about African culture and history that had been reduced to pure folklore by racist propaganda.



"From Harlem to Accra, to Dar es Salaam." / Map by Léopold Lambert (2020).

With contributions of Duse Mohamed Ali, Claude McKay, Zora Neale Hurston, Arthur Schomburg, and many other Black luminaries, UNIA's newspaper *The Negro World*, circulated in Black communities throughout the U.S. and the rest of the world, being banned in most of colonial Africa. Calling for "Back-to-Africa" and "Africa for Africans", Garvey founded the Black Star Line, a Black-owned shipping company that would link North America, Caribbean, and Africa in commercial and touristic ties. However, the project ultimately failed and, with it, his attempts to repatriate thousands of Afrodiasporic families in Liberia.

While the Black Renaissance faded after the 1929 crisis, Harlem kept alive the burning desire for identification with Africa, and so it won the title of "Black Mecca." Since then, going to Harlem would be a pilgrimage for both millions of anonymous and rare anti-imperialist African presidents like the Ghanaian Jerry Rawlings or the Burkinabè Thomas Sankara, the latter explaining during his visit in 1984 that "any African Head of State who comes to New York must first pass through Harlem. This is why we consider that our White House is in Black Harlem."

"ANY AFRICAN HEAD OF STATE WHO COMES TO NEW YORK MUST FIRST PASS THROUGH HARLEM. THIS IS WHY WE CONSIDER THAT OUR WHITE HOUSE IS IN BLACK HARLEM."

Black Stars in the Night of Accra ///

Before Sankara, Kwame Nkrumah championed Pan-Africanism when he brought it back to continental Africa while keeping connections with the Diaspora. It could not have been possible without his 10 year sojourn (1935-1945) in Philadelphia and New York. In Harlem, Nkrumah socialized with other African and Caribbean migrants. He focused on the specific experience of U.S. Black communities in the global Pan-African movement, which he would take over in 1945 after the Manchester Pan-African Congress.

When he returned to the Gold Coast (the colonial name of Ghana) in 1948, Nkrumah was then close-toy assimilated to an African American identity. When he won the 1951 Gold Coast general election with his Convention People's Party (CPP), African Americans really considered that Nkrumah was one of them. Since he controlled the immigration services, Accra became a shelter for many Afrodiasporic militants who were looking for a safe place, that is to say, a country ruled by Black people. They were not disappointed when Nkrumah printed Garvey's Black Star symbol on the new Ghana flag and invited Du Bois at the end of his life to Accra.

In *African Americans in Ghana* (2006), Kevin K. Gaines details the trajectories of hundreds of Black expatriates or visitors in Accra: Bill Sutherland, Maya Angelou, Shirley Graham Du Bois, Julian Mayfield, Pauli Murray, Muhammad Ali, St Clair Drake, and



Maya Angelou, Julian Mayfield, Malcolm X and friends in Accra in 1964. / Unknown photographer.

the list goes on — like a who's who of the Black militant world. Gaines dedicates a chapter to Richard Wright who, in *Black Power* (1954), expressed his difficulty to embrace African lifestyle, concluding that his visit to Gold Coast proved to him that he was not African but American.

Accra was yet a modern city then, and so living there as a Black expatriate — a social condition that was linked to whiteness — was a complex situation. Integration of Afrodiasporics in the African daily life may require a disengagement from this same mimicry Western lifestyle adopted by Ghanaian petite-bourgeoisie. Of the greatest significance were the effect of wearing a dashiki or natural afro hairstyle, getting an African name or learning African languages. It was about the sense of achieving a consciousness as "authentic" to Africans, in order to reach a new stage of Black Power.

"TINSPIRED BY HIS ATTENDANCE AT GHANA'S INDEPENDENCE CEREMONY ON MARCH 6, 1957, MARTIN LUTHER KING JR. WROTE 'THE BIRTH OF A NATION,' A POWERFUL SERMON WHERE HE EXPLAINED THAT 'THE OPPRESSOR NEVER VOLUNTARILY GIVES FREEDOM TO THE OPPRESSED'."

Since Western governments never felt the sense of having to account for the racist treatment of Black people living on their soil, Afrodiasporics who never had a power upon which they could rely, understood that Ghana could be this *Black Power.* Inspired by his attendance at Ghana's independence ceremony on March 6, 1957, Martin Luther King Jr. wrote "The Birth of a Nation," a powerful sermon where he explained that "the oppressor never voluntarily gives freedom to the oppressed." In Accra, King was raised to an international dimension, but he was reluctant to acknowledge that Nkrumah inspired his non-violent political activism.

During his first official visit to the United States in 1958, Nkrumah was welcomed by crowds in Harlem. He attended a rally with Malcolm X who, influenced by the 1955 Bandung Conference, already thought of how to internationalize the U.S. Black struggle. Indeed, in 1964, after his break with Nation of Islam, Malcolm X toured in Africa. His narrative underlines the importance of his meetings with the revolutionary Marxist leader Abdulrahman Babu in Dar es Salaam, and with Afro-American activists living in Accra and supporting Nkrumah's regime.

For many of them, the situation was getting more and more difficult. Those who ran away from Western capitalism realized that neo-colonialism in Africa was not any better with local puppets, mercenaries and international firms. Debates around a political doctrine of Pan-Africanism freed from race consciousness was difficult because the racial-based consciousness exclusively developed in the U.S. was meaningless for Africans. The transition from race to class was a challenge for Afrodiasporics who did not master the local codes on class and ethnicity.

In the meantime, with the enduring contradictions of promoting a transnational Pan-African ideology from a single nation-state, and the international pressure to evince him from power, Nkrumah's rule turned authoritarian. His fall in February 1966 during a military coup questioned the role of Black expatriates that U.S. foreign policy had trained, in order to penetrate African countries without being accused of racism or imperialism. Any "brother" could work for the CIA. The fall of Nkrumah changed the atmosphere radically. Since the new regime operated a reactionary turn, Ghana ceased to be a welcome society for non-Ghanaians.

African Revolution in Dar es Salaam ///

In a public rally in Zanzibar in 1959, Julius Nyerere said: "An African is anyone who has made Africa his or her home and fights for the rights of the country and equality." Soon, Dar es Salaam succeeded Accra as the political heart of Pan-Africanism. Located in East Africa on the shore of the Indian Ocean, Tanzania did not belong to the traditional North American-West African transatlantic joint. The country was born in April 1964 from the political union of continental Tanganyika with Zanzibar revolutionaries who had just removed the Arab neo-colonial elite from power.

The one-party state government of the Tanganyika African National Union (TANU) surprised some Afrodiasporics, but the headquarter of the Committee of Liberation of the Organization of African Unity (OAU) was based in Dar es Salaam. Tanzania hosted several African governments in exile, political refugees and armed liberation movements. As a "frontline state," Tanzania strongly supported the fight against racist and colonial regimes in Southern Africa. In *A Motorcycle on Hell Run: Tanzania, Black Power, and the uncertain future of Pan-Africanism, 1964-1974* (2017), Seth Markle provides detailed information about those who made Dar es Salaam "the intellectual revolutionary hub of East Africa, Africa and the Third World generally," as the Kenyan writer Ngugi Wa Thiong'o also outlined in *Moving the Centre* (1993).

In 1967, Nyerere proclaimed the Arusha Declaration which defined Tanzania as a socialist state with a doctrine based on self-reliance. The quest for a true economic alternative disengaged from Western capitalism was relevant for many Afrodiasporic scholars and activists. Additionally, the endogenous philosophy of *Ujamaa* (familyhood) meant that Tanzania would foster solidarity with the Black world. In Nkrumah's footsteps, Nyerere advocated pacifism but he also gave crucial and decisive support to African armed liberation movements. At the 1964 OAU Summit, he insisted on issuing a statement of condemnation of the U.S. government for their racist treatment of Black people.

"THE QUEST FOR A TRUE ECONOMIC ALTERNATIVE DISENGAGED FROM WESTERN CAPITALISM WAS RELEVANT FOR MANY AFRODIASPORIC SCHOLARS AND ACTIVISTS. ADDITIONALLY, THE ENDOGENOUS PHILOSOPHY OF *UJAMAA* (FAMILYHOOD) MEANT THAT TANZANIA WOULD FOSTER SOLIDARITY WITH THE BLACK WORLD."

As a *Mwalimu* (teacher in Swahili), Nyerere's political leadership allowed the development of collective ideas and debates in a community of scholars with a degree of freedom which, according to Walter Rodney, "was greater and remains greater than that which is accorded academics in most parts of the Third World. That allowed us to pursue scientific socialist ideas within a political framework that was not necessarily supportive of those ideas, but was not repressive in any overt sense."

Dar Writes History with Walter Rodney and Angela Davis ///

All the African universities at independence, including those in Legon and Dar es Salaam, were strategic places to work on new concepts and to "decolonize" academia. In the 1970s, Dar es Salaam was deeply influenced by the Guyanese historian Walter Rodney. Graduated from the University of the West Indies (UWI), Rodney obtained his doctoral degree at the London School of Oriental and African Studies (SOAS) before joining University College of Dar es Salaam as a lecturer in 1967. He explained that he hoped to get his first position in West Africa, but he could not find a country where the production of history was in symbiosis with participation in politics — until he had heard of the Tanzanian process.

In early 1968, Rodney left Dar es Salaam for a new teaching position at UWI, Jamaica. On October 15, 1968, after he attended a Black Writers' Conference in Montreal, Rodney was forbidden to return to Jamaica. Students, scholars, workers and youth took to the streets and the biggest riots of modern Caribbean burst forth. When he heard of Rodney's ban, Nyerere

"BEING A BLACK ANTI-IMPERIALIST COULD NOT MEAN AN ESCAPE FROM STRUGGLING IN THE HEART OF THE WHITE POWER SYSTEM BUT, RATHER, AN INVOLVEMENT TO FIGHT DOMINATION SIMULTANEOUSLY AT HOME AND ABROAD."

"HE COULD QUESTION HOW THE UNIVERSALITY OF MARXISM MAY STRENGTHEN THE IDEOLOGICAL BACKGROUND OF AFRICAN REVOLUTIONS AND, IN REVERSE, HOW MARXISM'S ORIGINAL EUROPEAN SCHOLARSHIP MAY BE DECOLONIZED THROUGH CRITICAL AFRICAN CONTRIBUTION."

spoke loudly in favor of his return: "This young man is a son of Africa. If you don't want him, we have a place for him here!"

Rodney's last period in Tanzania was fruitful with the publication of his seminal book *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa* in 1972. He felt that Dar gave him the tools to develop a really positive intellectual orientation because there was no obsessive need to react to white scholarship. He could question how the universality of Marxism may strengthen the ideological background of African revolutions and, in reverse, how Marxism's original European scholarship may be decolonized through critical African contributions. In addition to his courses on African history, economic history of Tanzania, international political economy, and history of English, French and Russian Revolution, Rodney created in 1970 the first courses on "History of Black People in the Americas."

This made Dar es Salaam the ideal place for Afrodiasporic and Global South scholars dealing with an African perspective connected with Latin American dependency theories. Rodney also questioned African history without falling into a straightforward glorification of the African past, as it was common in the Afrocentric cultural nationalist approach. Rodney's impact on the Dar es Salaam school of historiography exhibited the ideological division between Afro-Marxists, who were ready to join the international proletarian revolution, and cultural nationalists who believed in the international Black revolution.

While the theoretical works of Frantz Fanon, Che Guevara, or Amilcar Cabral were put into practice in the African wars of liberation, the socio-political environment in Dar es Salaam offered facilities to navigate between academia and the guerrilla camps. Rodney managed to establish a lasting relationship with freedom fighters and diplomats. Speaking on the historical commitment of Vietnamese diplomats based in Tanzania, he considered that their "truly revolutionary" vision was "a real achievement because the diplomatic set, irrespective of their social background, or the political background of their state, can often be extremely backward." Needless to say that contrary to Vietnamese, Black U.S. diplomats in Africa were not revolutionaries.

In August 1973, Angela Davis was invited by the ruling party to visit the campus. Her presence inspired women, mothers, and sisters since she was not seen merely as a Black Power icon, but as "a mirror through which the Tanzanian women could see themselves. There was before them, was a shining example of the type of woman socialism can create," explained C.C. Liundi in the February 1974 edition of the student magazine *Maji Maji*.

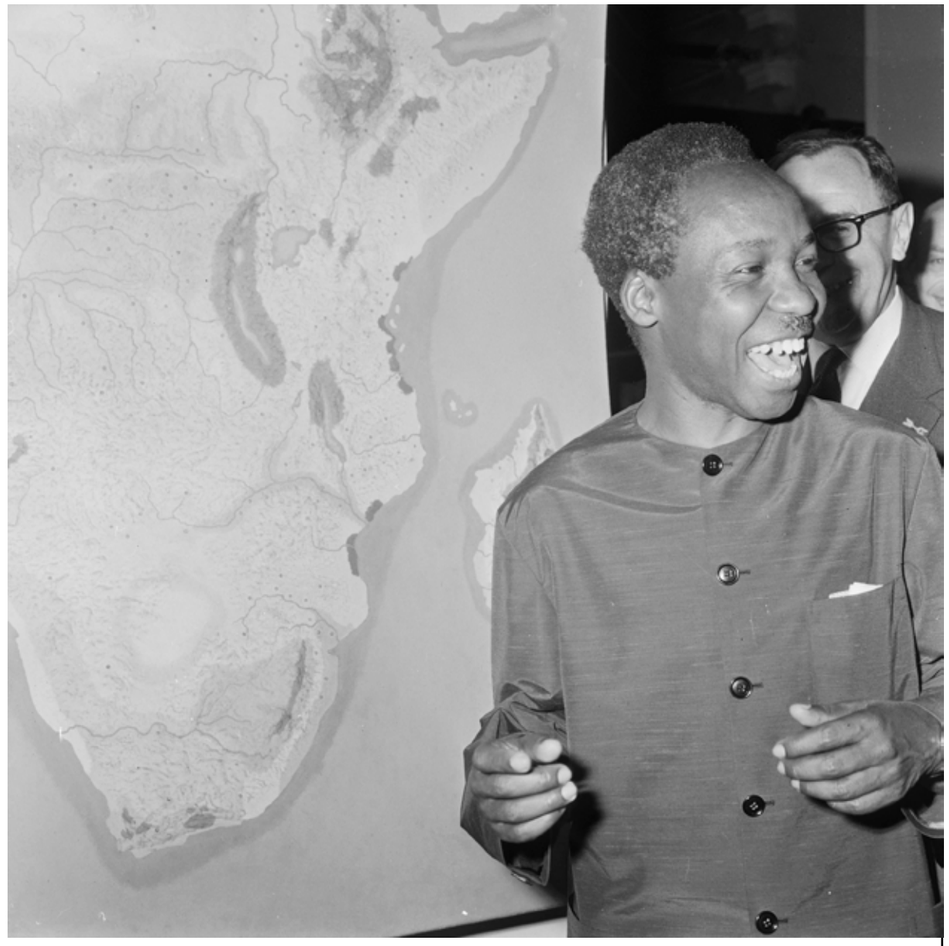
Like Garvey, Malcolm X, and Rodney, Davis explained that Afrodiasporics should fight wherever they are. The Back-to-Africa option should not be an excuse to escape the local confrontation with Western imperialism. Being a Black anti-imperialist could not mean an escape from struggling in the heart of the white Power system but, rather, an involvement to fight domination simultaneously at home and abroad.

The Sixth Congress in Dar: the Beginning of the End ///
For Lessie B. Tate, "the well-traveled United States/Tanzania transatlantic bridge saw a dramatic increase in traffic" when the decision was made to organize the Sixth Pan-African Congress (6PAC) in Dar es Salaam. The project of 6PAC started in 1969, during a Black Power Conference organized in Bermuda by a local deputy, Roosevelt Browne, with C.L.R. James. From his exile in Conakry, Nkrumah sent a letter of support calling the participants to go ahead in the organization of the event that finally took place in June 1974.

Because African and Caribbean governments feared that 6PAC served as a platform for their local opponents, state delegations were also invited, contrary to the non-governmental tradition of Pan-African congresses. 6PAC was a political tragedy with a series of divisions: non governmental organizations versus African states, cultural nationalists versus Afro-marxists, Afro-Americans versus other Africans from the Diaspora, Continentals versus Afrodiasporics, etc.

In letters sent to Rodney, Wole Soyinka expressed his disappointment at 6PAC and Horace Campbell remarked that Rodney's paper "would help to strengthen the understanding of Pan-Africanism in this decade." Indeed, Rodney fell ill and he wasn't there to deliver his speech entitled "Aspects of the International Class Struggle in Africa, the Caribbean and America." His absence was a relief for C.L.R. James who, having read the draft of Rodney's paper, had tried to convince him to remove the part of the text because it would produce explosive reactions: that Afrodiasporics could support, but they should not give lessons and instructions to Africans.

It was already difficult to get the delegates to sit down and listen carefully to a presentation with positive and constructive advances that could be set in practice. With an analysis imported from the U.S., the Afro-American delegation could not impose her vision upon Cuban or Mozambican delegates who had a true stature of revolutionaries and freedom fighters. For African liberation movements, it was counterproductive to emphasize race or class divisions before imperialism was crushed. Dar es Salaam was the place where Afrodiasporics had to break with Black nationalism and Black Power, a time to bury political slogans that could not implement political practices.



President Julius Nyerere and East Africa. Official visit at Amsterdam's Tropenmuseum on April 21, 1965. / Photo by Eric Koch - Anefo (Nationaal Archief).

In an interview for *Africa is a Country* (2018), Seth Markle gives the keys to the open doors of Harlem-Accra-Dar es Salaam Pan-African tradition beyond the tensions and schisms raised during the 6PAC and still pertinent: "This moment was transformative for so many people. It was an important stage of political development in their lives. It shaped people's racial, political, gender, and cultural identities in many positive ways. I hope readers don't lose sight of those small victories. This is why I'm reluctant to look at this movement as a complete failure or Pan-Africanism as a problematic ideology and practice. The problems they encountered provide lessons for future generations of Pan-Africanists." Between the ups and downs of Pan-Africanism, new ways of connecting peoples, places and issues allowed the rising of both grassroots and global Black progressist coalitions. This new spirit of activism must find sustainability in the legacy of those continuous interchanges between Harlem, Accra, and Dar es Salaam. ■

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PAN-AFRICAN PERFORMANCE AND POSSIBILITY IN NORTH AFRICA: LESSONS FROM ALGIERS 1969

SOPHIA AZEB

What is the place of North Africa in Pan-Africanism? Sophia Azeb takes a step back from the common narrative surrounding Algiers' Panaf and confronts the absences and the failures of the event to complicate our understanding of the multi-layered history of Pan-Africanism.

On July 21, 1969, the First Pan-African Cultural Festival (Panaf) convened with a massive parade through the streets of its host country's capital, Algiers. As much of the world was otherwise enraptured by two U.S. astronauts landing on the Moon, the African continent had all eyes on Algiers. Scores of Algerians joined their visiting African counterparts along the city's major boulevards, below buildings covered with fluttering Algerian flags and scars from the Algerian war for independence, which had ended seven years prior. Contingents of writers, political figures, artists, musicians, and dancers from 24 nations and still active liberation movements — including Guinea, Angola, and Mozambique — from across the continent and diaspora danced, marched, and sang in organized formations under placards denoting their national or internationalist affiliations, snaking their way through the streets and greeted with joyous celebration at every turn. In her narrative history of the founding of the International Section of the Black Panther Party, former BPP Communications Secretary Kathleen Neal Cleaver recalls that on this occasion, Algerian president Houari Boumédiène's welcoming remarks emphasized the bonds that the "anti-colonialist zeal" on the African continent and through-out its diaspora offered the prospect for African unity, and that in no uncertain terms, "culture is a weapon in our struggle for liberation."

"FURTHERMORE, IT ILLUSTRATES HOW AFRICAN AND AFRICAN DIASPORIC PEOPLES AND ORGANIZATIONS WEIGHED NORTH AFRICA'S ROLE IN THE LONG HISTORY OF BOTH PAN-AFRICAN UNITY AND DIVERGENCE."

"CULTURE IS A WEAPON IN OUR STRUGGLE FOR LIBERATION."

The presence of the Black Panthers in Algeria was no coincidence. Drawn to Algeria by the legacy of Martiniquan-Algerian Frantz Fanon, whose analysis of "a world cut in two" by colonialism appealed to radical Black internationalists such as the Cleavers, the Panthers joined a plethora of other anti-colonial movement leaders, militants, intellectuals, and cultural figures for the festivities. Kathleen Neal Cleaver's account of the Panthers' experiences in Algeria, a history she documented in an amended version of her 1983 Yale graduate thesis, "Back to Africa: The Evolution of the International Section of the Black Panther Party (1969-1972)," illustrates the significance of the festival for the many participants who joined it, while also casting light onto the unevenness of Algeria's claims and commitments to pan-Africanism. The pan-Africanist aims of the festival were keenly self-aware, but the festival's very structure as a performance of African unity also reveals the often-superficial strategy behind Algeria's desire to appeal to other African nations and non-state actors and organizations. Though it would seem that orienting this history through the perspective of the International Section of the Black Panther party centers African American perspectives on political and cultural pan-Africanism, in fact attending to the evolution of the Panthers' internationalist vision demonstrates the expansiveness of pan-Africanism as a global project and one that is anchored across the African diaspora, inclusive — in this time and place — of North Africa. Cleaver's measured account of the festival and the founding of the International Section of the Black Panthers therefore establishes an important archive of the otherwise thin historical accounting of pan-Africanism in North Africa. Furthermore, it illustrates how African and African diasporic peoples and organizations weighed North Africa's role in the long history of both pan-African unity and divergence. Crucially, Cleaver demonstrates how pan-Africanism in this moment and this North African space was most coherent in the unlikely encounters and interactions that were made possible in 1969 Algiers.

Like the 1966 Dakar World Festival of Negro Arts (FESMAN) three years prior, the Pan-African Cultural Festival in Algiers extended invitations to a number of national delegations on the continent and in the diaspora. Unlike FESMAN, however, organizers in Algiers also invited non-national organizations and liberation movement representatives, such as the African National Congress (ANC), The Mozambique Liberation Front (FRELIMO), Zimbabwe African People's Union (ZAPU), the African Party for the Independence of Guinea and Cape Verde









Stills of *Festival panafricain d'Alger 1969*, a film by William Klein (1969). The two images at the bottom show dancers in the courtyard of the legendary Climat de France building.

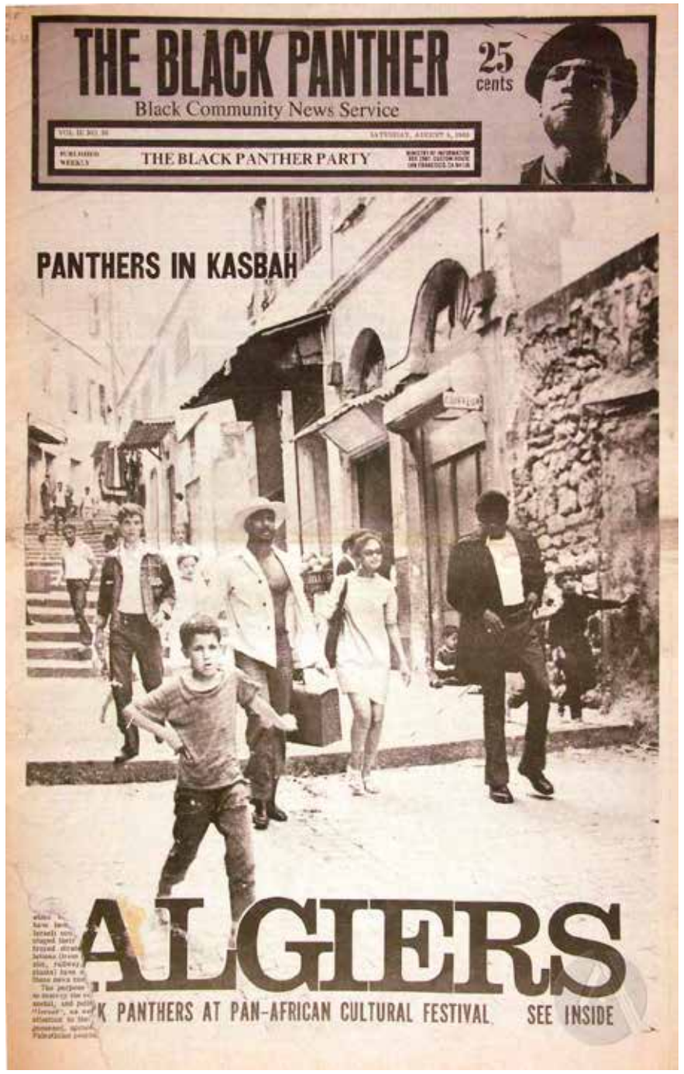
(PAIGC), and the People's Movement for the Liberation of Angola (MPLA). Before the festival convened, the Panaf organizing committee's manifesto laid out the core rationale for a "First" Pan-African Cultural Festival, which elaborated on the decision to include non-national parties and slyly distinguished itself from FESMAN, hosted by Senegalese President Léopold Sédar Senghor. FESMAN received sponsorship from both the French Cultural Ministry and UNESCO, an insensible arrangement for Africans still battling for liberation from the last semblance of European empires. The Panaf manifesto also provides fascinating insight into the Algerian investments *in* and interpretation *of* pan-Africanism. "*Le manifeste culturel panafricain*" shifted Panaf's aims away from the *under*-politicized call to cultural commonality that had characterized the Dakar festival three years prior, and also resisted the urge to render "African culture" a generic or singular denotation.

The manifesto opens with a definition of African culture that assigns its very existence to the broadest aspect of society: the people themselves. It begins, "The people are the starting point of culture insofar as they create themselves and they transform their surroundings. Culture is not received by the people, but made by them." Addressed against the coercive and corrosive effects that colonialism wrought on culture in all contexts, the manifesto *claims* to make *no* claims of a pre-colonial cultural past that might be resurrected intact. Rather, "African artists and intellectuals must situate themselves within their society and assume the particularly decisive responsibilities that are theirs. Their actions should instill the radical transformation of minds [...]. The people must be the first beneficiaries of their cultural and economic wealth."

"THE PEOPLE ARE THE STARTING POINT OF CULTURE INSOFAR AS THEY CREATE THEMSELVES AND THEY TRANSFORM THEIR SURROUNDINGS. CULTURE IS NOT RECEIVED BY THE PEOPLE, BUT MADE BY THEM."

Though the manifesto does not shy away from cultural *difference* on the continent and in the diaspora, it does attempt to massage the Senghorian concept of "Africanité," or an African way of being, to address the local, regional, and international call to African culture that the Algiers festival represents:

"Africanité obeys the law of a dialectic of the particular and the general, of specificity and universality; that is to say, [a dialectic of] truth at the base and unity at the top. African culture,



Cover of The Black Panther's *Black Community News Service*, vol III no. 16, August 1969.

art, and science, whatever the diversity of expression, do not rest on any essential difference. They are only singular expressions of the same universality."

"INDEED, AS THE REST OF THE MANIFESTO PROCEEDS TO EXPLICATE THE VARYING DEGREES BY WHICH CULTURE MAY INTERCEDE IN AFRICAN LIBERATION AND ON AFRICAN SOCIAL AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT, IT INCREDIBLY NEVER ONCE INCLUDES THE IDENTIFIER: 'ARAB'."

This interstitial space the manifesto identifies — the "singular expression" of the "same universality" — is a captivating proposition. Indeed, as the rest of the manifesto proceeds to explicate the varying degrees by which culture may intercede in African liberation and on African social and economic development, it incredibly never once includes the identifier: "Arab." The Pan-African Festival of 1969 was hosted by the Algerian government and the Front de Libération Nationale (by then a deeply fractured party displaced from the central government), put on in the capital city of Algiers, and overtly tied itself to the pro-Arab, pan-Africanist Casablanca bloc of the OAU. And yet "Arab" is never summoned. This notable absence can be read in a number of ways. In one light, the Algerian impulse to act as custodians of liberation in this era was directly linked to Boumédiène's hope that an assertion of Algeria's continued leadership of decolonization would maintain his influence in Algeria and on the continent. But perhaps the choice not to invoke "Arab" as a point of identification also speaks to the fundamental tension of North African political prerogatives versus its own and varied attempts to define itself in light of prevailing nationalist economic interests and *internal* racial and colonial processes that characterized nations including Algeria, Egypt, Libya, Tunisia, and Morocco.

By refusing to name an Algerian Arab — much less Amazigh — identity — or indeed, an Arab cultural *character* — the manifesto *abstracts* the concept of Africanité and the practice of pan-Africanism. This has parallels with how Senghor, in the years prior to Panaf, had *qualified* Africanité by articulating an immutable African/Arab *difference*.

This attempt at abstraction may be traced through these festivals: whereas Dakar's cultural exhibitions celebrated the "high arts," Algiers embraced both the traditional and the avant-garde. Whereas Dakar's colloquium asserted that the production of a new humanism is a *revolutionary* act, Algiers' impetus was to articulate pan-African political innovations as a *cultural* venture. The Algiers festival's re-reading of Africanité muddied Algeria's attachment to Arabness and Arabism in order to *perform* pan-Africanism in an *affective* reframing of the African diaspora. This is the nation that Fanon himself claimed to be the vanguard of African revolutionary fervor — why then, the manifesto seems to conclude, *name* the signifiers that belie the Arab North's mutual singularity?

If true liberation from colonialism is predicated, as Fanon maintained in *The Wretched of the Earth* (1961), on abjuring European colonial determinations of race, then Algeria's place in pan-Africanism and an expansive conception of global Blackness is upheld by the language of the manifesto. Indeed, the manifesto *was* received by a global Black audience, including the Black Panthers, as precisely the desired challenge to the lingering colonial structures that loomed over FESMAN. So, as an example, if the Black Panther Party represented what Stuart Hall once referred to as the "adoption and adaptation of Fanonism within the *black* movement in the United States," then Algeria was for the Panthers the obvious place for an *International* Party to take form. Or, as Kathleen Neal Cleaver writes: "The Black Panther Party believed the liberation of Blacks from racist oppression and capitalist exploitation required a social revolution to transform the economic and political institutions of the United States, and its presence in Algiers signified its identification with African struggles to end colonialism."

Kathleen Neal Cleaver's arrival in Algiers followed soon after Eldridge Cleaver had been smuggled into the nation by a sympathetic Cuban diplomat, an international itinerary owed to various disagreements and misunderstandings between Cuban authorities and Cleaver as well as Algeria's temporary lack of diplomatic ties — and indeed the continuing refusal of many Western nations to recognize an autonomous Algeria at all — with the U.S., from which Eldridge Cleaver was a fugitive. Elaine Mokhtefi, former Press Secretary to the recently deposed Ahmed Ben Bella, used her governmental connections to secure official Panaf invitations for both Cleavers and a delegation of other Black Panther Party members. The delegation opened the Afro-American Information Center one day after the festival began and staffed it with French-speaking African Americans flown in from France by Julia Hervé (the daughter of celebrated African American writer and expatriate to France, Richard Wright). Kathleen Neal Cleaver noted "the Algerian visitors to the Center were intensely curious [...] convinced [...] that American imperialism was an enemy of their country, and [...] warmly expressed their solidarity with its Black opponents visiting their home," in spite of their overall ignorance of the Black freedom struggle in the U.S.

An essential component of the Panthers' presence at the festival was that it facilitated meetings between the Panthers present in Algiers — who would go onto establish the International Section of the Black Panther Party at a villa in the El Biar neighborhood, donated to Eldridge Cleaver by the Vietcong in 1970 — with diplomats, delegations and freedom fighters from all over the African continent and throughout the Third World. Eldridge Cleaver was far from the only fugitive in the nation, and the festival itself was overseen by Houari Boumédiène — the same leader who had led a coup against Ahmed Ben Bella in 1965 — in order to "place Algeria (and also its army) in the political leadership of Africa, the Arab world, and nonaligned nations" on the international stage. Kathleen Neal Cleaver slyly noted that "Algeria's foreign policy supported all struggles against colonial domination, if not materially, rhetorically." Indeed, the Algerian military government refused to offer formal meeting or housing facilities to the Panthers at the festival's end (diplomatic status was eventually granted to the Panthers in early 1970, with the assistance of Elaine Mokhtefi and Mohammed Yazid). However, Boumédiène's regime permitted the Panthers to organize with other liberation movements present in or passing through the North African state. Although a significant language barrier meant the Panthers' ties with these movement representatives were often unbalanced in favor of their English-speaking comrades; "in political terms, the Panthers found their strongest support among those directly harmed by United States' policies: the Palestinians, the Vietnamese, the North Koreans."

IF TRUE LIBERATION FROM COLONIALISM IS PREDICATED, AS FANON MAINTAINED IN THE WRETCHED OF THE EARTH (1961), ON ABJURING EUROPEAN COLONIAL DETERMINATIONS OF RACE, THEN ALGERIA'S PLACE IN PAN-AFRICANISM AND AN EXPANSIVE CONCEPTION OF GLOBAL BLACKNESS IS UPHELD BY THE LANGUAGE OF THE MANIFESTO.

The 1969 Pan-African Festival thus marked a critical moment in the coalescence of North African approaches to liberation and ties to pan-Africanism on the African continent. Its accessibility and relative openness to debate further positioned Algeria as a hub for new evocations of pan-Africanism that embraced the Arab North as an active participant in global African diasporic politics and cultures. However, it is also apparent that just as the festival embraced performance as a central aspect of the festival's activities, the pan-Africanism that the Algerian festival put on display was also performative. Momentary, but not consistent. The enactment of pan-Africanist politics and cultures were largely thanks to the festival's participants, not the immediate output of the Algerian government. Instead, the festival presents a moment of opportunity alongside the broader historical trajectory of moments when (and where)

"ITS ACCESSIBILITY AND RELATIVE OPENNESS TO DEBATE FURTHER POSITIONED ALGERIA AS A HUB FOR NEW EVOCATIONS OF PAN-AFRICANISM THAT EMBRACED THE ARAB NORTH AS AN ACTIVE PARTICIPANT IN GLOBAL AFRICAN DIASPORIC POLITICS AND CULTURES."

"PAN-AFRICANISM FAILED TO SETTLE INTO THE INFRASTRUCTURE OF THE NATION, EVEN AS IT CONSTITUTED THE ARCHITECTURE OF THE FESTIVAL ITSELF."

Black and Arab and Black Arab peoples create the conditions in which to meet, talk, and experience joy alongside one another. Though the longer history of the Panthers in Algiers precipitated a great deal of internal strife in the Party and among the Americans themselves (Eldridge Cleaver's rancorous misogyny a chief contributor to both issues), their time in Algiers led Party members to Peking, Hanoi, and Brazzaville, where conversations between liberationists were transcribed and brought back to Algiers to be translated into English for the Panthers to disseminate.

"THE REVOLUTIONARY BOND BETWEEN 'THE AFRICAN COLONIAL WORLD' AND 'THE WORLD IN WHICH AMERICAN BLACKS LIVED' WAS FAR FROM INNATE: IT DEMANDED CULTIVATION, AND A MUTUAL ATTENTION TO RELATION AND DIFFERENCE THAT SHE FREELY ACKNOWLEDGED NEITHER HER COMMUNITY NOR THE ALGERIANS THEY LIVED AMONG COULD FULLY MANAGE."

Kathleen Neal Cleaver's rich and frank exploration of the lack of mutual understanding between herself and fellow Panther members' and the Algerians they interacted with, both in terms of politics and quotidian life in Algeria, also marks a set of moments when a pan-Africanist sensibility and practice is reshaped and takes on new life. It is true that the limited perspective of the Panthers revealed their lack of overall historical context regarding Algeria's place in this pan-African moment, but by virtue of the fact that we are still reading and reflecting on Kathleen Neal Cleaver's careful and continued documentation of this history some 50 years on also means that mediations such as hers are critical for unearthing both the frustrations and longevity of Algeria's imaginary and active presence in the Black radical imagination.

The lack of mutual understanding between the Panthers and the Algerians they encountered every day is not in itself unusual. Algeria, after all, was still dealing with the trauma of its long and bloody struggle for independence from France, and the marks the war left went far beyond the nation's landscape, which Cleaver describes:

"Bombed out buildings still stood as grim reminders of the war that had left no family in Algeria unscathed. The French colonial past was evident in the striking architecture of the city and the complex bureaucracy of the state, while the daily calls to prayer and veiled women attested to the resurgence of Algeria's Islamic heritage. Arabic was the dominant language, but everyone in Algiers still spoke French, the language of government and commerce. The complicated tribal and ethnic divisions among Arabs, Berbers, and Africans bewildered Panthers accustomed to simple stratifications of color and class…Thus adapting to life in Algiers, where nothing was remotely similar to America, presented a shock for which none of the Panthers was prepared."

Algeria's bloody war for liberation eventually hardened into the continued production of rigorous boundaries for Algerianness that hewed evermore toward the "Arab" rather than the "African" that was extolled in the Panaf manifesto of 1969. Pan-Africanism failed to settle into the infrastructure of the nation, even as it constituted the architecture of the festival itself. Kathleen Neal Cleaver articulates the difficulty of reconciling the Algeria of Frantz Fanon's writings with the complex social, political, and cultural landscape she found herself in during these years. The revolutionary bond between "the African colonial world" and "the world in which American Blacks lived" was far from innate: it demanded cultivation, and a mutual attention to relation and difference that she freely acknowledged neither her community nor the Algerians they lived among could fully manage. The most coherent legacy of Algeria's role in pan-Africanist movement building is therefore captured in a series of moments and feelings rather than a structure of societal upheaval.

The International Section of the Black Panther Party in Algiers likewise operated in a series of moments and was ultimately short-lived. In 1971, it separated from the American Panthers and rebranded itself as the Revolutionary People's Communication Network. In July 1972, two subsequent airline hijackings by American radicals who landed in Algiers, infuriating Boumédiène. They included Black American and Vietnam war veteran Willie Roger Holder, who then joined the International Section of the BPP, as well as fugitive envoys of the Black Liberation Army. The Algerian government was in the process of discretely negotiating natural gas sales to U.S. oil companies, and Boumédiène's willingness to hand back over 1 million USD in ransoms collected by multiple hijackers infuriated Eldridge Cleaver right back. Cleaver penned an open letter to Boumédiène that referenced the Algerian leader's own experiences in the war and gestured to other Arab states' "conciliatory gestures towards the United States" towards capitalist ends. The Algerian leadership felt this letter would rightly be interpreted by the broader Arab public as an abandonment of the anti-Zionist commitments many pan-Arab leaders had been lately quick to shed. Kathleen Neal Cleaver observed that Eldridge Cleaver "came to see the emotional and political identification with Africa as a 'skin game' and realized that the kind of problems that America's Blacks faced bore little relationship to the Africans' problems." Indeed, the eventual limits of North African commitments to pan-Africanism arose just as nations such as Algeria and Egypt, the latter under the leadership of Anwar Sadat, courted favor for primarily nationalist rather than African federationist or internationalist concerns while simultaneously foreclosing their nations' prior anti-colonial ideals by seeking out economic and political alignment with Western states. The Cleavers ultimately left for Paris on New Year's Day in 1973, and soon after Algeria's slow turn to authoritarianism under Boumédiène displaced the nation's previous anti-colonial pan-African and pan-Arab pursuits.



Back cover of The Black Panther's *Black Community News Service*, vol III no. 16, August 1969.

Pan-Africanism's legacy in North Africa is disappointing, but not unimportant. pan-Africanist politics and cultural ties were not solely the provenance of a government or a conference or a festival. The First Pan-African Festival in Algiers *did* contribute to the expansion of African diasporic ties that continue to inform pan-Africanist thought and practice today, a condition of possibility itself the result of the momentary surges of transnational encounters enabled by such festivals. These failures marked the futurity of pan-Africanism as we might recognize it today: brief moments of lucidity in a global landscape otherwise marred by miscommunication and mistranslation, but ripe for interpretive possibility when regarded from a different position in time and space. Pan-Africanism is not an event, but a condition of possibility for Black people to realize their political and cultural power and exchange ideas about the future of Black liberation and pan-African ideals. Although pan-Africanism may have slowly been abandoned in North Africa throughout the 1970s, the African and African diasporic peoples who left Algiers carried with them what they learned, what they wanted, and what they needed of the pan-Africanism they made in Algiers, 1969. ■

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"THESE FAILURES MARKED THE FUTURITY OF PAN-AFRICANISM AS WE MIGHT RECOGNIZE IT TODAY: BRIEF MOMENTS OF LUCIDITY IN A GLOBAL LANDSCAPE OTHERWISE MARRED BY MISCOMMUNICATION AND MISTRANSLATION, BUT RIPE FOR INTERPRETIVE POSSIBILITY WHEN REGARDED FROM A DIFFERENT POSITION IN TIME AND SPACE."

THE HOUSE OF THE STUDENTS OF THE EMPIRE IN LISBON

ANA NAOMI DE SOUSA
AND
SÓNIA VAZ BORGES

How does a common home initially founded by mostly white students and supported by the Portuguese government birth one of the most fiery and radical Pan-African publications? In this text, Ana Naomi de Sousa and Sónia Vaz Borges explores the history of the *Casa dos Estudantes do Império* in Lisbon.

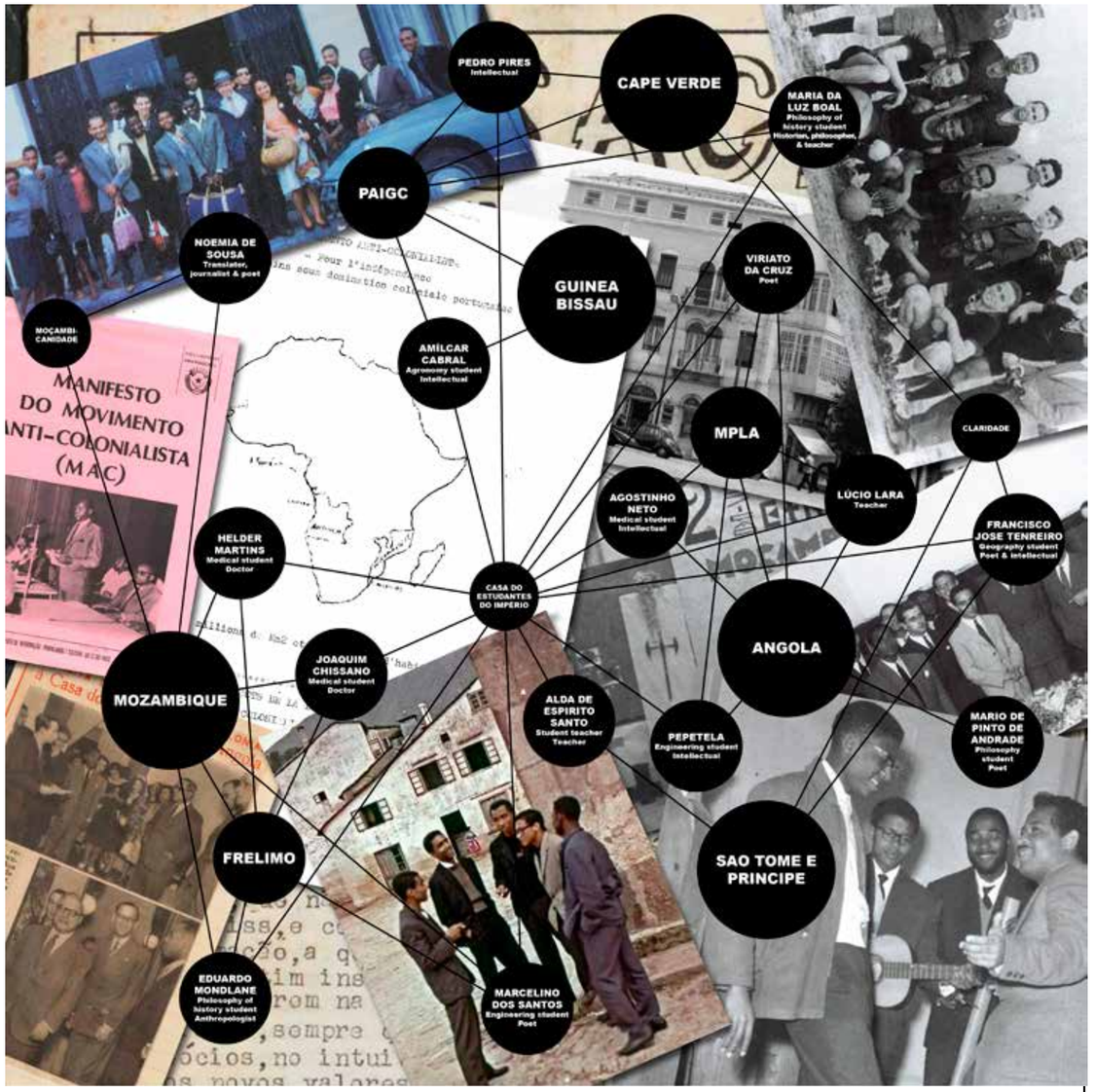
"I could never have dreamt of things such as this — it is sublime [...] infinitely human [...]. This book brings me so much, including the certainty that the Black man is awaking in the world." These are the words written in 1948 by a young African agronomy student in Lisbon, upon reading the *Anthologie de la Nouvelle Poésie Nègre et Malgache* (Anthology of New Black and Malagasy Poetry), published that year. The young writer was Amílcar Lopes Cabral, the revolutionary intellectual who would go on to lead the Bissau Guinean and Cape Verdean independence movement until his untimely death. At that time, however, he was still a university student, and one of the regulars at Lisbon's *Casa dos Estudantes do Império*, an association for students from Portugal's many colonies that was to play a crucial role in the downfall of the very regime that created it.

With Portugal already 20 years deep into the oppressive rule of Antonio Salazar, the first "House of the Students of the Empire" was founded in 1943 in Lisbon, by mostly white, African-born university students, who were closely connected or outwardly sympathetic to the *Estado Novo* regime. Suggesting that their distinct experience as children of the empire needed its own space in the metropolis, they were supported by the Ministry of the Colonies, who believed the *Casa* would reflect and nurture the colonial and ideological values of "*Portugalidade*." This was related to the way in which Portuguese colonies in Africa and Asia were rebranded in the mid-1940s, henceforth referred to as "overseas provinces" ("*provincias ultramarinas,*" or simply "*ultramar*"), as if part of a single Portuguese nation that spread across the continents from Europe to Africa to Asia under the slogan "Portugal is no small country." Assimilation had been introduced throughout the colonies under the *Estatuto dos Indígenas* (Native Charter), meaning racialized colonial subjects could apply for the near-white status of being "assimilated" (understood as having been "europeanized" and thus "civilized"), and gain access to the colonial city, to employment and, crucially, to higher education in Portugal. Becoming assimilated meant denouncing indigenous language, religion and social customs in favor of the Portuguese and it was a system that both ensured a favored, educated, creole elite to administer the colonies; and helped to market Portuguese colonialism as a benevolent endeavor that would implement a kind of "racial union." A side effect of this racist system of segregation (built on the foundations of *Lusotropicalismo*), a small but growing number of Black and brown students began to make their way to Portugal in the mid-1940s to attend university from Angola, Cape Verde, Guinea Bissau, São Tomé, Macau, Mozambique, and Goa. It was the three *casas dos estudantes do império*, located in the university cities of Lisbon, Porto and Coimbra, that brought them together under the same roof.

This first generation of "students from the empire" would later come to be known as the "Cabral generation," named after its most famous proponent, Amílcar Lopes Cabral, who arrived in Portugal from Cape Verde in 1945 to study agronomy. His contemporaries included the medical student, António Agostinho Neto (the future President of Angola) who came in 1947; Angolan philosophy student Mário Pinto de Andrade (founding member of the Movimento Popular de Libertação de Angola, MPLA, movement); and others such as the São-Tomense student teacher Alda do Espirito Santo, and geography student Francisco José Tenreiro, both of whom already lived in Lisbon. Not to mention many familiar names such as Mozambicans Noémia de Sousa and Eduardo Mondlane, who passed through the doors during those decisive years. The *casas* functioned as social clubs, providing cheap meals and reading rooms, hosting football tournaments, live music, social dances and, increasingly, staging literary and political discussions. Geographically, the students may have been located at the heart of a repressive regime that had colonized their homelands; but the *casas* became an oasis that thrived with the sounds and experiences the students brought with them.

For, although Portugal in the 1940s was impoverished, highly illiterate, oppressive, and isolated, a whole new world was on the horizon for Black and brown students arriving at the *Casa dos Estudantes do Império*. In the face of colonialism, slavery, apartheid and oppression, Black intellectual and literary production was flourishing around the world — from the *The New Negro* of Harlem's Renaissance to Cuba's *negrismo* movement, from Haiti to Brazil, to Kwame Nkrumah flying the Pan-African flag in London, to African Europe. In Paris, writers had been cultivating a new francophone movement of Black consciousness rooted in Pan-Africanism, including the magazine *Présence Africaine*. A number of Pan-African and Black internationalist associations and publications (not always in agreement with each other) had already emerged in Portugal from the 1920s, and W.E.B du Bois himself had accepted an invitation to visit Lisbon in 1923. Unwittingly, the *casas* provided an ideal location for these publications and ideas to be shared, for new expressions of their own to find a common tongue; and for the early seeds of resistance to Portuguese colonialism to be sown years later, Mario Pinto de Andrade would recall: "To the Portuguese, we African *assimilados*, had adopted their living habits and trappings and sociality. Yet we had not had the chance to think about our own cultures." Not, that is, until they encountered each other in the casas.

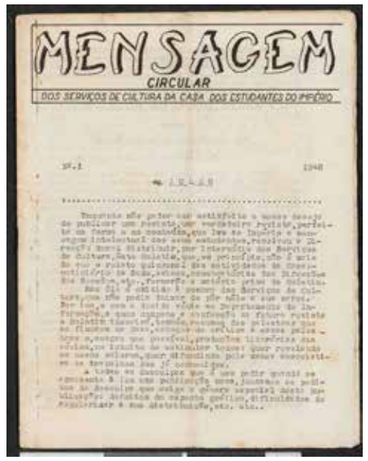
In 1948, the Senegalese poet Léopold Sédar Senghor, published the ground-breaking *Anthologie de la Nouvelle Poésie Nègre et Malgache* (Anthology of New Black and Malagasy Poetry) in Paris, consolidating the work of Black francophone thinkers (including Aimé Cesaire, Alioune Diop, the Nardal sisters, Léon-Gontran Damas, et. al) around conceptions of *Négritude* and with a fiery anticolonial foreword entitled *Orphée Noir* (Black Orpheus) by Jean-Paul Sartre. The collection challenged the European construction of the African, and responded by seizing the colonial language — in their case, French — to express Blackness in their own terms. Pan-African, anti-imperial, and written in resistance to the "civilizing" violence of

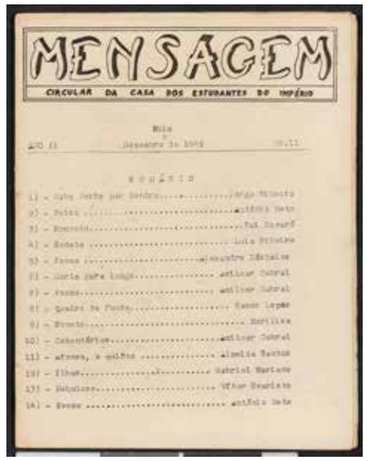


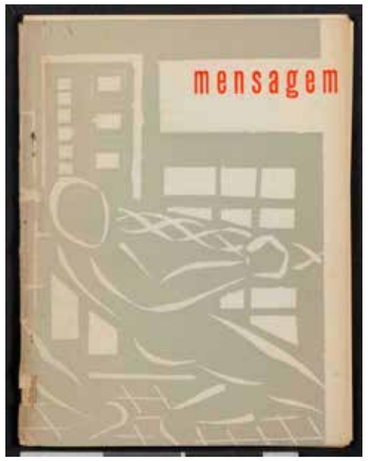
Hommage to "the students of the Empire." / Data and illustrations by Ana Naomi de Sousa & Sónia Vaz Borges; artwork by Léopold Lambert (2020).

"GEOGRAPHICALLY, THE STUDENTS MAY HAVE BEEN LOCATED AT THE HEART OF A REPRESSIVE REGIME THAT HAD COLONIZED THEIR HOMELANDS; BUT THE CASAS BECAME AN OASIS THAT THRIVED WITH THE SOUNDS AND EXPERIENCES THE STUDENTS BROUGHT WITH THEM."

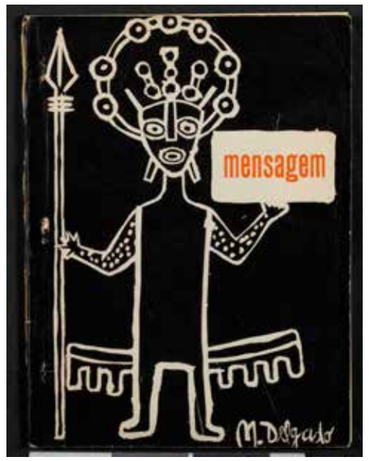
"IN THE FACE OF COLONIALISM, SLAVERY, APARTHEID AND OPPRESSION, BLACK INTELLECTUAL AND LITERARY PRODUCTION WAS FLOURISHING AROUND THE WORLD."













Covers of *Mensagem*: no. 1 (July 1948), no. 11 (May-Dec. 1949), no. 5-6 (1960), no. 1 (April 1963), no. 2 (June 1963), and no 1 (July 1964).

"THESE WRITINGS CHALLENGED ROMANTIC PORTUGUESE DEPICTIONS OF LIFE UNDER ITS COLONIAL REGIMES, AND ASSERTED THE DIVERSITY OF EXPERIENCE — AND THE BRUTALITY — OF BLACK LIFE IN THE COLONIES."

European assimilationist colonialism, this radical expression of Black consciousness resonated powerfully among those subjected to Portuguese colonialism, among them Cabral and his peers at the CEI. The Angolan philosophy student Mário Pinto de Andrade, began to work earnestly towards an equivalent contribution in the Portuguese language, from what was quickly becoming a political home for Portuguese *Negritude*, at the *Casa dos Estudantes*.

That same year, amidst a flurry of poetry readings and exchanges, the *Casa* began publishing the literary newsletter *Mensagem*, a periodical of poetry, fiction, essays and interviews mostly about Africa or from African contributors — including many of white or of mixed African and European heritage. *Mensagem* alluded to, translated and conversed with other contemporary writings of Black Consciousness. Mario Pinto de Andrade, for example, edited a series of translations of Langston Hughes' poetry; whilst Noémia de Sousa wrote a poem entitled "deixa passar o meu povo", which clearly references Paul Robeson and Marian Anderson's recording of "Let my people go". The poets published in Mensagem spoke ardently and poetically of the lived pain of colonialism. The very first issue included the poems *Canção de embalar meninos pretos* ("Song for embalming Black boys") by António Agostinho Neto and *A sombra das galera* ("The shadow of the galleys") by Alexandre Dáskalos, as well as an excerpt from Baltasar Lopes da Silva's novel *Chiquinho*. These writings challenged romantic Portuguese depictions of life under its colonial regimes, and asserted the diversity of experience — and the brutality — of Black life in the colonies.

Se me quiseres conhecer / Noémia de Sousa
Se me quiseres conhecer,
estuda com olhos de bem ver
esse pedaço de pau preto
que um desconhecido irmão maconde
de mãos inspiradas
talhou e trabalhou
em terras distantes lá do Norte.
Ah, essa sou eu:
órbitas vazias no desespero de possuir a vida.
boca rasgada em feridas de angústia,
mãos enormes espalmadas,
erguendo-se em jeito de quem implora e ameaça,
corpo tatuado de feridas visíveis e invisíveis
pelos chicotes da escravatura...
Torturada e magnífica.
Altiva e mística.
África da cabeça aos pés
- Ah, essa sou eu!
Se quiseres compreender-me
vem debruçar-te sobre minha alma de África,
nos gemidos dos negros no cais
nos batuques frenéticos dos muchopes
na rebeldia dos machanganas
na estranha melancolia se evolando...
duma canção nativa, noite dentro...
E nada mais me perguntes,
se é que me queres conhecer...
Que eu não sou mais que um búzio de carne
onde a revolta de África congelou
seu grito inchado de esperança.

If you want to know me, Noémia de Sousa

If you want to know me,
Study with well seeing eyes
This piece of black wood
Which an unknown Makonde brother
With inspired hands
Wielded and worked
In far away lands up North.
Ah, that is me:
empty orbits despairing of possessing life.
mouth torn in wounds of anguish,
enormous flattened hands
raised as if to implore and threaten,
body tattooed with wounds visible and invisible
by the slaving whip...
Tortured and magnificent.
Proud and mystic.
Africa from head to toe,
- Ah, that is me!

If you want to understand me
Come come to dwell in my African soul,
In the groans of the Blacks on the docks
In the frenetic beats of the muchopes
In the rebelling of the machanganas
In the strange melancholy evaporating
Of a native song, night within...
And ask me nothing more,
if you do want to know me...
For I am nothing more than a conch of meat
where the African uprising froze
its cry filled with hope.

This period of intense literary and poetic output led, in 1953, to the publication of the *Antologia de Poesia Negra de Expressão Portuguesa* (Anthology of Black Poetry expressed in Portuguese), edited by Francisco José Tenreiro and Mario Pinto de Andrade, which included the work of Agostinho Neto, Noémia de Sousa, and Alda de Espirito Santo among others. These writings were extremely important within Portugal, but they also had an impact in the colonies themselves, where they found their way thanks in part to clandestine networks across the empire that were emerging around the *casa*. Literary and cultural movements in Angola, Cape Verde, and Mozambique, in particular, consolidated the growing need to push back against Portuguese imperial ideals, and helped sow the crucial first seeds of resistance to the colonial regimes. Amílcar Cabral, in *Les Étudiants noirs parlent*, an article for *Présence africaine* (1953), stated "it is fair to say [...] that today the black student from the Portuguese colonies begins gradually to become aware of his position in the world: that of a Black man who must be fundamentally concerned with serving the cause of the emancipation of Black men, so serving humanity [...] fighting for the liberation of the African masses, for his own liberation."

"IT IS FAIR TO SAY [...] THAT TODAY THE BLACK STUDENT FROM THE PORTUGUESE COLONIES BEGINS GRADUALLY TO BECOME AWARE OF HIS POSITION IN THE WORLD: THAT OF A BLACK MAN WHO MUST BE FUNDAMENTALLY CONCERNED WITH SERVING THE CAUSE OF THE EMANCIPATION OF BLACK MEN, SO SERVING HUMANITY [...] FIGHTING FOR THE LIBERATION OF THE AFRICAN MASSES, FOR HIS OWN LIBERATION."

Up until this time, having all these students "from the empire" under one roof had seemed convenient for the fascist regime's secret police, the PIDE, who believed they could be monitored with relative ease. By the early 1950s, however, the activities of students from the *casa* began to raise concern among the eyes and ears that followed them. Marcelino dos Santos and Agostinho Neto were among members who were arrested, and the running of the *casa* was brought under regime control. From 1951-53, the *casa*'s most significant political activities took place, instead, at the apartment of the Espirito Santo family, where the clandestine *Centro de Estudos Africanos* (CEA, Center for African Studies) was founded. Located at no. 37 Rua Actor Vale and also known simply as "37," the CEA was to be a place where its disciples would learn more about Africa, and rediscover themselves as Africans within the colonial context: "We needed to become conscious ourselves of African culture in its globality, and of the diverse Black cultures on the continent and all over the Black world," according to Mário Pinto de Andrade. His study plan for the CEA, drawn up with Francisco José Tenreiro, would focus on *Land and Man; African socio-economics / the problems of the Portuguese 'ultramar'*; and *Black thought, the Black man in the world and the Black man as a colonizer in the New World; and the central impediments to the progress of the Black world*.

Tactically, the CEA became another node in a small but important network of locations that included the *casas* in Lisbon, Porto and Coimbra, and Lisbon's *Clube Maritimo Africano* (African Maritime Club), across which anti-colonial political organizing was galvanized in the 1950s. The *casas* were, in the words of Helder Martins, homes in which a very special "friendship, solidarity, and camaraderie" were forged.

"THE "CABRAL GENERATION" OF THE 1940S GAVE WAY TO THE "UTOPIAN GENERATION" OF THE 1950S; THE FINAL COHORT OF DREAMERS AND RADICALS TO PASS THROUGH THE DOORS OF THE CASA BEFORE HITTING THE ROAD THAT LED, INEVITABLY, TO THE ARMED STRUGGLE FOR LIBERATION."

And, of course, the PIDE were right to be worried; the literary movement of Black Consciousness had transformed into explicit anticolonialism, and to urgent political movement building. So the "Cabral generation" of the 1940s gave way to the "Utopian generation" of the 1950s; the final cohort of dreamers and radicals to pass through the doors of the *casa* before hitting the road that led, inevitably, to the armed struggle for liberation. The diverse members of the CEA and the *casa* had formed connections with underground political opposition movements in Portugal at the time, among them the *MUD Juvenil* (the youth wing of the United Democratic Movement, an initially state-sanctioned opposition movement which had become a trojan horse for the communist party) and the de-facto clandestine Portuguese communist party, both of which also served as conduits for important political influences, notably Marxism-Leninism, and as practical channels along which an armed resistance might be supported.

In 1952, Amilcar Cabral left Portugal for Guinea Bissau at the invitation of the Portuguese Ministry of the Colonies, to continue his work as an agronomist. But this work was increasingly and inextricably tied to his independentist political trajectory, and he was forced to leave for Angola in 1955. Meanwhile, knowing he was at risk of being imprisoned, Mário Pinto de Andrade had fled Lisbon for Paris in 1954, where he became the editor of *Présence Africaine*. There he was in contact with other African independistas including Nelson Mandela and Senghor, and met his future wife, the French-Guadeloupean filmmaker Sarah Moldoror.

Back in Lisbon, the students had managed to regain administrative control of the casa from the regime in 1957 — the year in which Agostinho Neto was released from another, two-year spell in prison; and the year in which Neto, Cabral, Pinto de Andrade and others penned a joint manifesto for the *Movimento Anti Colonial* (Anti-Colonial Movement or MAC), calling for the "total liquidation of Portuguese colonialism in Africa." Cabral, Andrade, Marcelino dos Santos were among those who met frequently at Pan-African summits over the following years: Dar es Salaam, Accra, Tunis, Cairo, Rabbat, and Algiers, all played a role on this circuit of African anti-colonialism. Neto, meanwhile, remained in Lisbon, where he was still often seen at the *casa* until 1959, when he left with his young family for Luanda. However, as other European countries began to concede independence to their colonies, Portugal tightened its grip. In a wave of repression that was particularly violent in Angola — where the PIDE set up their operations — anti-colonial agitators were imprisoned and tortured, many sent to the concentration camp of Tarrafal in Cape Verde. Portugal began assembling a huge conscripted military force to fight across the empire; the armed struggle against Portuguese colonialism was by now unavoidable.

"FROM CRADLE OF FACIST-COLONIAL IDEOLOGY TO THE BIRTHPLACE OF PORTUGUESE NEGRITUDE, BLACK NATIONALIST LIBERATION, AND ANTI-COLONIALISM, THE STORY OF THE HOUSE OF THE STUDENTS OF THE EMPIRE, REMAINS ONE OF THE MOST POETIC BACK-FIRINGS IN THE HISTORY OF IMPERIALISM."

At the same time, the Portuguese regime continued to pitch *Lusotropicalism* — the fantasy of a "multiracial utopia" — as an alternative to decolonization, despite growing international criticism of the violent realities in the colonies — brutality, forced labor, and de facto segregation, by now well documented. "In Angola 200,000 Portuguese rule by terror," Frantz Fanon (already in close contact with Pinto de Andrade, Cabral and others) told the Positive Action Conference in Accra, in April 1960. The Pidjiguti massacre by the PIDE of at least 50 striking port workers in Guinea Bissau in 1959 only further undermined the Portuguese cause — and marked the official turning point for the PAIGC from non-violent to armed resistance — but the Salazar dictatorship was only at the beginning of its most violent and tyrannical stage. Meanwhile, the MPLA steering committee moved to Conakry in May 1960, shortly before the incarceration, in June 1960, of Agostinho Neto and other key Angolan organizers, which became an international cause célèbre — and one of Amnesty International's first campaigns for political prisoners. These events were galvanized in December 1960 by the Baixa de Cassanje revolt in Malanje, Angola, which led to the outbreak of the Angolan war for independence in February 1961.

For the politicized students of the *casa*, Lisbon was an increasingly hostile environment, exacerbated by fear of the PIDE, at the same time that anti-colonial struggle was becoming an urgent reality abroad. Many of the students feared being drafted into the Portuguese army that was being deployed to fight against the freedom forces they really supported. In 1961, a French-American church network helped 60 African students to escape overnight from the casa, across Portugal's northern borders and overland via Spain to France — among them Joaquim Chissano, Pedro Pires and Henrique Iko Carreira. Many of them were headed for the newly independent cities of the Pan-African movement, among them Conakry, Dakar, Kinshasa, and Brazzaville.

The doors of the *Casa dos estudantes do império* were finally closed by the PIDE in 1965, by which time it was, in the words of Agostinho Neto's famous poem, too late to "stop the rain" (1960). From cradle of facist-colonial ideology to the birthplace of Portuguese negritude, Black nationalist liberation, and anti-colonialism, the story of the House of the Students of the Empire, remains one of the most poetic back-firings in the history of imperialism.

Construção da Vida - F. Costa Andrade
Dois fios de aço
Goteja
A esperança.



Casa dos Estudantes do Império. / Unknown photographer (UCCLA – União das Cidades Capitais de Língua Portuguesa).

O muito que se espera
Do nada que virá.
Avoluma-se o grito
No cimento
Correndo as veias
Da estrutura do progresso.
Traços feitos sobre areia
De mistura com os trovões do mar.
Constrói-se o mundo?
Os homens nascem todos
Arquitetos.

Construction of Life - F. Costa Andrade
Two steel wires
Dripping
The hope.
How much is expected
Of the nothing that will come.
The scream swells
In the cement
Running through the veins
The structure of progress.
Traces made on sand
Mixing with the thunder of the sea.
The world is built?
Men are all born
Architects. ■

Ana Naomi de Sousa is a documentary filmmaker, journalist, and researcher who works around history, identity, resistance and spatial politics. She is the director of *The Architecture of Violence, Guerilla Architect, Hacking Madrid* and *Angola : Birth of a Movement*, among other films. As a collaborator with Forensic Architecture she was the filmmaker on the Saydnaya project for Amnesty International.

Sónia Vaz Borges is an interdisciplinary militant historian and social-political organizer. She also describes herself as an enthusiastic traveler, an avid language learner, and an attentive listener. Sónia received her Ph.D. in Philosophy, and is the author of the book *Militant Education, Liberation Struggle; Consciousness: The PAIGC education in Guinea Bissau 1963-1978* (2019). Along with filmmaker Filipa César, Sónia co-authored the short film *Navigating the Pilot School*. She is currently a researcher at Humboldt University Berlin and is working on the project *Education for All* with a special focus on Mozambique and the FRELIMO liberation movement, and the Sandinistas revolution in Nicaragua. Parallel to this, Sónia is developing a book proposal, based on a personal research project focused on her concept of the "walking archives," the liberation struggle, memory, generation, and imaginaries.

REPRODUCING FESTAC '77: A SECRET AMONG A FAMILY OF MILLIONS

WITH NTONE EDJABE AND KWANELE SOSIBO

In this interview, Ntone Edjabe discusses with journalist Kwanele Sosibo about Chimurenga's latest editorial project on one of the largest cultural and political events of Pan-African history: the second World Black and African Festival of Arts and Culture, aka Festac' 77.

KWANELE SOSIBO: Can you talk about the timing of this project? Festac took place at the beginning of 1977, after a difficult planning period. What is its continued relevance to the diaspora, in particular now?

NTONE EDJABE: In the first decade of the 2000s we experienced a wave of gruesome attacks across the continent on what I'd call "the Familiar Other," we saw this in Côte d'Ivoire, Senegal, Nigeria, Sudan, Kenya, across the Great Lakes and, of course, during the Afrophobic violence in South Africa of May 2008. It is a depressingly long list and the reasons are specific to each context but it seems what is continuously and violently contested is, who belongs where, the perennial question of the nation-state in Africa since the independence period. And, by extension, the question of the circulation of Black people in our world. These questions have been at the center of our work since the first issue of *Chimurenga*. But I think the most immediate trigger for this project was the failure of South Africa's World Cup in 2010 — we knew Bafana Bafana [South Africa's national team] were not going to win it and that it wouldn't deliver all the jobs-jobs-jobs promised. The developmental logic was unsustainable. The justification for the megalomaniac spending for an event of that scale had to be cultural — to alter, fundamentally, the way Africans see themselves and how the world sees us. Instead we produced that waka-waka nonsense. But it wasn't enough to point to the failure of the imagination: we began to research global cultural events that the continent had hosted in the 20th century, that were not restricted by the instrumental logic that guided South Africa's World Cup.

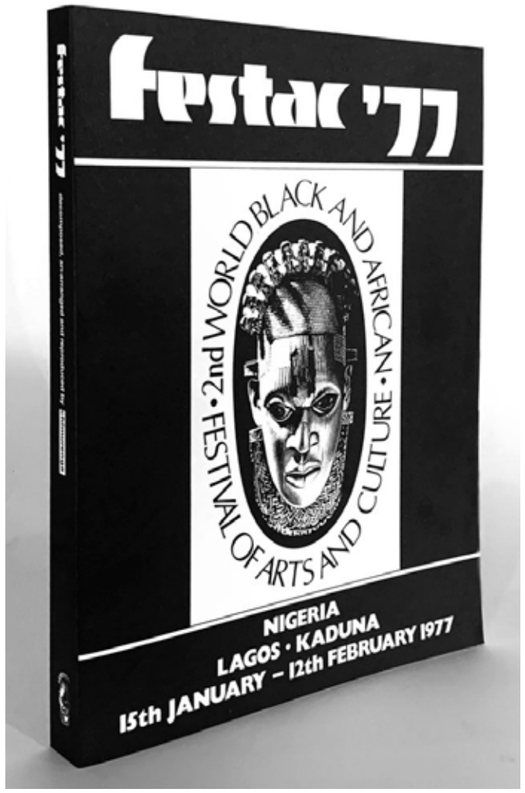
Like Pan Africanism, it is a story that begins in the diaspora and moves to the continent with the wave of independence of the 1960s — first in Nkrumah's Ghana in 1958 with the All African Peoples Conference. These gatherings take a cultural slant with the First World Festival of Negro Arts (Fesman) in 1966 in Dakar, and eight years later at the Pan-African Cultural Festival (Panaf) in Algiers. Festac '77 in Lagos marked the closing of this festival decade. And perhaps the end of Pan Africanism as a state project — so we wanted to look into that.

But the importance of Festac '77 goes beyond chronology. Each of these festivals is remembered as a singular moment in the history of the country in which it took place. Always the first of its kind and ideologically dissonant — whereas Dakar '66 manifested as a platform for Negritude's ideals of Black culture, Panaf '69, mandated by the Organisation of African Unity (OAU), looked to culture as a tool of liberation and development. However, individually and as a cluster, they functioned as laboratories for the development of new, worldwide politics and cultures. Their shared aim was to look beyond the binaries established by the cold and hot wars (East-West, North-South), and give form to universalisms that had emerged since the Haitian revolution. In other words, to institutionalize the Black World.

I think the specificity of Festac '77 is in its attempt to reconcile what Tẹjumọla Ọlaniyan called the political and cultural paradigms in Pan Africanist thought and practice. This is also the tension I see between Africans on the continent and those from its diaspora, in which "African" has come to mean the former and "Black" the latter. These divisions were of course amplified by the invention of fields such as African Studies and Black Studies in the realm of knowledge production. Anyway, following Ọlaniyan's logic, Dakar '66 would have been "cultural" (Black), and Algiers '69 "political" (African) — Festac '77, according to this logic, would be both Black *and* African, hence the renaming of the festival.

To circumvent the limits of nativism and Afro-radicalism, Festac '77 imagined Black solidarity as inclusive. So, people and communities from the Black diaspora as well as postcolonial African states would be represented. The tension between these modes of affiliation, Black/African (and plenty others), is what the festival is all about — it

"HOWEVER, INDIVIDUALLY AND AS A CLUSTER, THEY FUNCTIONED AS LABORATORIES FOR THE DEVELOPMENT OF NEW, WORLD-WIDE POLITICS AND CULTURES. THEIR SHARED AIM WAS TO LOOK BEYOND THE BINARIES ESTABLISHED BY THE COLD AND HOT WARS (EAST-WEST, NORTH-SOUTH), AND GIVE FORM TO UNIVERSALISMS THAT HAD EMERGED SINCE THE HAITIAN REVOLUTION. IN OTHER WORDS, TO INSTITUTIONALIZE THE BLACK WORLD."







Excerpts of the book *Festac '77* by Chimurenga (2020). / Courtesy of Chimurenga.

simultaneously presents and celebrates the art of statelessness and state-art, while putting all forms of political representation under pressure.

For example, members of the AfriCOBRA arts collective are part of the United States delegation — except the U.S. isn't invited, only Black Americans. They're not there as members of AfriCOBRA either, because artists are invited as individual members of a recognised political community. They end up representing a country that exists only in the Black radical imagination: Black America. But it gets better. The only state symbol at their disposal is a flag: Marcus Garvey's flag of Pan Africanism, which is itself a challenge to the idea of the nation-state. On the other hand, the South African born Miriam Makeba was a citizen of nine countries (excluding South Africa at that time) and represented them all at Festac '77. The poet Mário Pinto de Andrade, one of the founders of Angola's MPLA, appeared at the festival instead as Guinea-Bissau's minister of culture. That's the beauty and depth of the mess that Festac '77 makes visible.

The work of producing Pan Africanism as a political reality is ongoing and, sadly, what we currently celebrate as "Africa Day" is the reduction of that project into a manageable bureaucracy in the OAU — now the African Union (AU). But the questions *Who is Black? What is Africa?* are very much alive in the cultural realm. One of the questions we ask through this project is, can a past that the present has not yet caught up with be summoned to haunt the present as an alternative?

"BUT THE QUESTIONS *WHO IS BLACK? WHAT IS AFRICA?* ARE VERY MUCH ALIVE IN THE CULTURAL REALM. ONE OF THE QUESTIONS WE ASK THROUGH THIS PROJECT IS, CAN A PAST THAT THE PRESENT HAS NOT YET CAUGHT UP WITH BE SUMMONED TO HAUNT THE PRESENT AS AN ALTERNATIVE?"

KS: How did you approach the research for this? Was there a central source that provided much of the material or were you calling on existing networks across the Black worlds for material?

NE: The Centre for Black and African Art and Civilisation in Lagos is an important resource to understand Nigeria's investment in Festac '77 — three successive military governments









carried the project. It was founded by Olusegun Obasanjo in 1979, to act as custodian of the Festac archive and it holds many important planning documents and recordings of performances. But no central archive can contain the enormity of this event. Like the map in Jorge Luis Borges's famous parable, it would need to be as big as the territory.

And my colleagues and I are generally more interested in inserting ghosts into the archive than merely reproducing it. Today, the National Theatre in Lagos, which hosted many of the Festac performances, feels like a haunted space, like a monument for unrealisable dreams. What is important for us isn't the reiteration of the actual past, but the persistence of what never happened, but might have. My main collaborators at Chimurenga and on this project, Stacy Hardy, Bongani Kona, Graeme Arendse, Duduetsang Lamola, Ben Verghese, Dominique Malaquais, and Akin Adesokan, are writers, artists, designers, DJs. So music, speculative cartography, fiction are all valid tools to advance research work. The other thing is that long-term research such as this, we have to integrate it in our everyday activities — for instance we published an edition of the *Chronic* in 2015 that examines divisions between North and sub-Saharan Africa, which was a central and divisive issue at Festac '77.

This is the paradox of Festac '77. Some of our most important writers, artists, thinkers participated — 17 000 at official count. Many of them speak of it as a paradigm shift, one of the most important events they've attended. The impact of the event is somewhat visible in their artistic and political choices, yet it seldom appears as a full story. Audre Lorde and Jayne Cortez published poems, Wole Soyinka wrote an essay, and the event appears in a few memoirs. This intrigued me — the people who experienced Festac '77 seemed unwilling to write it, as if bound by an unspoken nondisclosure agreement. And so its stories circulated in the manner of a family secret — a family of millions of people.

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Both pages. Excerpts of the book *Festac '77* by Chimurenga (2020). / Courtesy of Chimurenga.

On the other hand, there are at least 40 music albums about Festac '77. It refuses to be written, it resists analysis, but it is spoken, sung and performed on record more widely than any other event I've researched. So our primary archive was never hidden, it was the dispersed recordings produced by the likes of Orchestre Poly-Rythmo de Cotonou, Gilberto Gil, Tabu Ley Rochereau, Syli Orchestre National, King Sunny Adé, and many more. Together, these LPs constitute a sound-world in which the memory of Festac is as active as it is missing in print.

Working through sound requires an embrace of opacity: there is always too much information — and never enough. I think it helps to feel surrounded by the sound, to surrender, when attempting to write stories too big, too personal, to be perceived in their fullness. Indeed, some stories are bigger than storytelling. Black music is not only the largest and most sophisticated archive at our disposal, it is also an efficient laboratory for the rebuilding of archives that are primarily inscribed in bodies.

We wanted to tell stories of Festac '77 through those who participated. But it is practically impossible to determine who was there from official records. For example, a group of South African artists and activists led by the writer Molefe Pheto travelled to Nigeria uninvited and without visas. At the Lagos airport they were welcomed as "Soweto revolutionaries" and let into the country — in fact, escorted to the festival village as VIPs. Their names do not appear in official documents, but everyone else saw and envied them! Fortunately, Pheto likes to tell this story and it reached my ears via the curator Khwezi Gule.

Gathering these stories had to be collective and public work — this kind of crowd-sourcing also served as a peer-review system. We would organise events and invite people who were rumored to have been at Festac '77 to help to identify companions in the images we collected. It didn't always go well — in one instance some of his colleagues "identified" the bass player William Parker in Marilyn Nance's extensive photographic documentation of the U.S. delegation. I hurriedly wrote to Parker to request an interview, only to learn it wasn't him. But we thought he should have been at Festac and so he was!

Learning about who was there (or wasn't) became a way of producing an alternative history of our world, a way to learn about the influence of Cheikh Anta Diop in the shaping of cultural policy in post-independence Gabon; or the struggles by the likes of Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o and Micere Mugo to produce a national theater in Kenya; or to wonder how on earth the Sun Ra Arkestra found themselves on a plane bound for Lagos, alongside the feminist poet and warrior Audre Lorde, the modernist painter Beauford Delaney, and Louis Farrakhan of the Nation of Islam. Just imagine! Mind-boggling stuff!

KS: Why, and what point, did Toni Morrison's *The Black Book* become the inspiration in terms of method of presentation?

NE: Initially we imagined the book as a collection of essays to be edited by Akin Adesokan and myself. We produced a few drafts of this book, but none felt right. There was no music, and the people were left out.

Another project had begun to take form in our minds — a publication that could be heard as well as read. A book that would represent the array of verbal and visual texts we'd received from our elders — the spoken anecdotes, newspaper reports, essays, advertisements, music sheets, posters, diary pages, artworks — and the stuff we'd made up.

Stories would have no beginning or end; everyone would be speaking at the same time and in their language. It would be polyvocal, polyglot, polyrhythmic, and many more plurals; it would demand close listening. It would have no chapters or sections; it would begin wherever the eye falls. It would have many contradictions. It wouldn't distinguish between new writing and older material. It would present each story as an invitation to produce more stories. Some stories would include a byline, others not; some pages would be numbered, others not. There would be a system, but it would be as un-

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predictable as the cataloguing of a private jazz collection, or read in all directions like Dumile Feni's scroll.

"EVERY BLACK PERSON SHOULD RECOGNIZE SOMETHING IN IT, ANYTHING — AND READ FROM THERE. EVERYONE ELSE CAN JOIN IN TOO, BUT THEY MUST KNOW WHEN TO LEAVE."

It should not feel precious but everyone should want to keep it — it should rest on the kitchen table with the family photo album. Every Black person should recognize something in it, anything — and read from there. Everyone else can join in too, but they must know when to leave. It should be read in groups. No one should be able to read it entirely — unless they speak at least nine languages. This book could only be made by many hands, page by page. Encountering Toni Morisson's *Black Book* was a revelation. It was a blessing. She had produced it in 1974 to tell the story of African Americans over three centuries. *The Black Book* is a mystery, so perfectly choreographed everything feels random. All the cues are buried in the reader's own mind.

We sat by her feet and learned to play jazz. We had to give up on the possibility of all connections being meaningful and understood, some just had to be felt: where would we feature Jayne Cortez's poem on Nigerian-American relations? Would it go with the report on the 1973 oil crisis in *The Black Panther Intercommunal News Service* — a crisis that enriched Nigeria and made Festac '77 possible? Or would it sit near Ama Ata Aidoo's story of meeting Cortez at the food queue in the Festac Village?

KS: How far do you see Festac's tentacles stretch, both in terms of how it shaped ways in which the arts could be mobilised towards liberation (with particular reference to South Africa) and in how it reshaped diasporic connections, years into its future?

"THE EXPERIENCE OF BLACK PEOPLE FROM ALL OVER THE WORLD GATHERED IN LAGOS FOR A MONTH, WITHOUT WHITE APPROVAL OR SUPERVISION CANNOT BE UNDERESTIMATED."
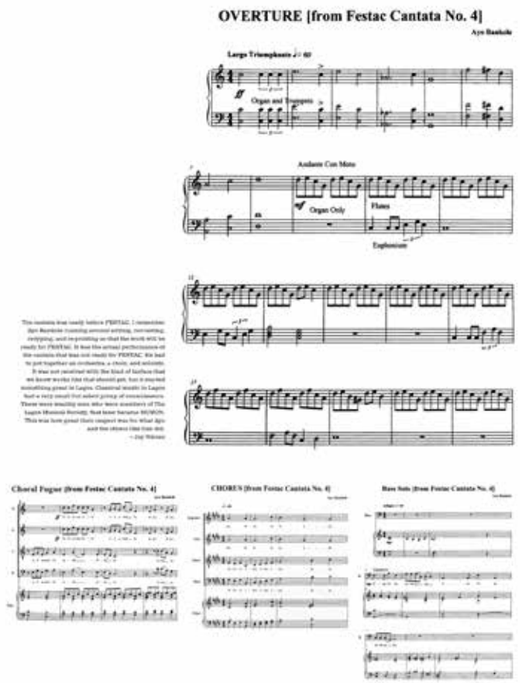
NE: Nigeria's involvement in the anti-apartheid struggle is well documented — the Pan Africanist Congress (PAC) had an office in Lagos since the 1960s. And in the aftermath of the June 16, 1976 uprisings, Tsietsi Mashinini and his Soweto Students Representative Council comrades were hosted by the Obasanjo government. Thabo Mbeki was then deployed to Lagos to woo the Nigerians, with his first task being to lead the ANC delegation at Festac '77. The South African liberation movement was there in its fullness — PAC chief diplomat David Sibeko was there. Oliver Tambo dropped in for the closing ceremony.

The festival took place in the middle of the war some historians describe as "cold," but which was very hot in these parts. The Chimurenga was intensifying in Zimbabwe and civil war was ongoing across the white redoubt in Southern Africa, instigated, of course, by the apartheid regime. The inauguration of Jimmy Carter as U.S. president took place a week into Festac '77, and he immediately dispatched Andrew Young to Lagos, who did his best there to avoid Agostinho Neto, the leader of socialist Angola. There are photographs in which the VIP section looks like a seating of OAU general assembly. Festac '77 was definitely a space for palace-political work.

"BUT MAJOR POLITICAL MOVES ALSO TOOK PLACE ON THE PERFORMANCE STAGE. FOR INSTANCE, MBEKI MANAGED TO UNITE A CROSS-GENERATIONAL GROUP OF SOUTH AFRICAN ARTISTS AND ANC ACTIVISTS BEHIND A SINGLE PROJECT LED BY THE COMPOSER AND TROMBONIST JONAS GWANGWA — A DRAMATISATION OF THE RECENT JUNE 16 EVENTS FEATURING MUSIC, DANCE, POETRY AND POPULAR THEATRE."

But major political moves also took place on the performance stage. For instance, Mbeki managed to unite a cross-generational group of South African artists and ANC activists behind a single project led by the composer and trombonist Jonas Gwangwa — a dramatisation of the recent June 16 events featuring music, dance, poetry and popular theatre. The success of this performance led to the formation of the Amandla Cultural Ensemble, a powerful, roving organ for mobilising international support for the struggle the following decade. The Medu Art Ensemble was also founded by Festac '77 alumni, and the Culture and Resistance Conference which they organized in 1982, was modelled on the Lagos festival. All of this led to the establishment of the ANC's department of arts culture — this is just a brief outline to indicate the immediate repercussions of Festac '77 on the South African liberation movement. One could argue that the event was similarly influential for many participating groups and countries.

By declaring itself a "Black" country in its constitution of 1804, Haiti changed the rules — a republic could be Black, just as Western liberal democracies assume their whiteness. The emergence of continentalism at the Pan African Conference of Manchester in 1945, which culminated with the founding of the OAU ("Seek ye first the political kingdom," as Nkrumah famously put it), allowed many African leaders to sidestep this issue. Post-Biafra Nigeria reimagined itself as a Black State for the time of a festival — the experience of Black people from all over the world gathered in Lagos for a month, without White approval or supervision cannot be underestimated. Consider this: Festac '77 facilitated the symbolic and temporary return of the largest number of Black people to the continent. And so the burning question was: is this a festival of people or a festival of states? In other words, is it the 2nd Fesman (Dakar) or the 2nd Panaf (Algiers)? Senegal, for example,





Excerpts of the book *Festac '77* by Chimurenga (2020). / Courtesy of Chimurenga.

threatened to boycott the festival if North African countries, "Arabs," were invited. A conundrum that Wole Soyinka characterised as "saline consciousness" — the belief that everything which is bounded by sea water on the continent is necessarily African, and that everything which is outside it is not. As a compromise, the festival had to be renamed "World Black and African Festival of Arts and Culture", to include the North Africans.

But the issue simply would not go away. Brazilian activists confronted their government — why were there so few Black artists, intellectuals and organisations in their country's delegation? Sudanese intellectuals asked, what of "Black *and* Arab"? Indigenous Australians claimed they were neither Black nor African and departed shortly after the opening ceremony. People took these questions home to reshape cultural politics and, in cases like Brazil, Cuba, Australia and others, to initiate a national debate on race.

The question of "national culture", anticipated by Fanon, also raised its head at Festac '77. Before the festival, only a few African states had established national cultural institutions beyond what was inherited from the colonial state. Gabon's National Theatre, Zaire's National Ballet and Cameroon's National Orchestra, for example, were founded in preparation for Festa '77. This brought intellectuals and artists face to face with the state in irreversible ways. Festac '77 became the platform on which the old confrontation between poets and politicians would take place — and between both groups and "the people".

Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o was detained in Kenya during Festac '77, even though his and Micere Mugo's play, *The Trial of Dedan* Kimathi, was presented at the festival by the very government that imprisoned him. Togolese writer Yves Dogbé was jailed and tortured for a speech he *planned* to give at the Festac Symposium. The Ugandan playwright Byron Kawadwa was killed by Idi Amin's goons for his piece at Festac '77. Sadly, there are many more examples. Typically, Fela Kuti took this opportunity to organize a "counter-Festac" at his club, the Shrine, in which everyone was invited to berate the Nigerian military government at will, as well as their own. A week after the festival, the Nigerian police responded with full force, destroying Fela's home, and killing his mother.

BY USING THE FAMOUS BENIN IVORY MASK "HEAD OF QUEEN IDIA" AS THE FESTIVAL EMBLEM, AND MAKING AN OFFICIAL REQUEST FOR HIS RETURN FROM THE BRITISH MUSEUM, FESTAC '77 POLITICIZED THE QUESTION OF RESTITUTION OF AFRICAN ARTEFACTS HELD IN WESTERN INSTITUTIONS.

By using the famous Benin ivory mask "Head of Queen Idia" as the festival emblem, and making an official request for his return from the British Museum, Festac '77 politicized the question of restitution of African artefacts held in Western institutions. Faced with British refusal to return the loot, the Nigerian government then commissioned the descendants of the original carvers to produce new versions of the mask, based on photographs of the mask held in Britain. Another wicked twist in the tale of Dr Satan's Echo Chamber. ■

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CITIES AS HINGE: THE MECHANICS OF A PAN AFRICAN DREAM

ABDOUMALIQ SIMONE

Once strategic assets for colonial powers, African cities can be discussed in the context of Pan-Africanist politics. In this article, AbdouMaliq Simone follows the many lives of Amadou Diallo across the cities of the continent and beyond, providing a fruitful backdrop to rethink African interconnectedness.

A Project Only Indirectly ///

A long-time friend and collaborator, Amadou Diallo, remarked a few days before Guinean President Sékou Touré's death in 1984, that African cities were hinges, their primary purpose to set different angles of openings and closure. As hinges, they had no intrinsic identity themselves, but rather were modulations of light and darkness, focusing alternating perspectives on things, at times widening exposures to some great outdoors; at other times, narrowing the gaze, withdrawing observers inward. Diallo started his career at age 10, selling loose cigarettes in the Chicago neighborhood of Conakry. Once a bastion of loyalty to the Pan African dreams of Touré, nevertheless the district bore the brunt of his paranoia fed by psychotic mystics from the Futa Jallon mountains. It was from these mountains that Diallo had moved to the Guinean capital when he was two years old, mountains that supplied factory workers in Nanterre, taxi drivers in the Bronx, bankers in Dakar, and gem dealers in Brazzaville.

"FOR DIALLO, HINGES WERE THE ESSENTIAL TECHNICAL FEATURE OF THRESHOLDS THAT HAD TO BE MARKED AMONG MULTIPLE BELONGINGS AND REALITIES."

For Diallo, hinges were the essential technical feature of thresholds that had to be marked among multiple belongings and realities. They permitted differentiated degrees of access, in turn mediating everyday decisions as to what and where one should be. "Africa is not something you bring home or take with you; not something to believe in or to recognize as you move around," he was fond of saying; "it is only a door never completely open or closed." By this he meant that Africa was literally an "outlook," a shifting vantage point from and through which to engage the world; something that could be narrowed down to a microscopic visibility or widened to take everything in without discrimination or discretion.

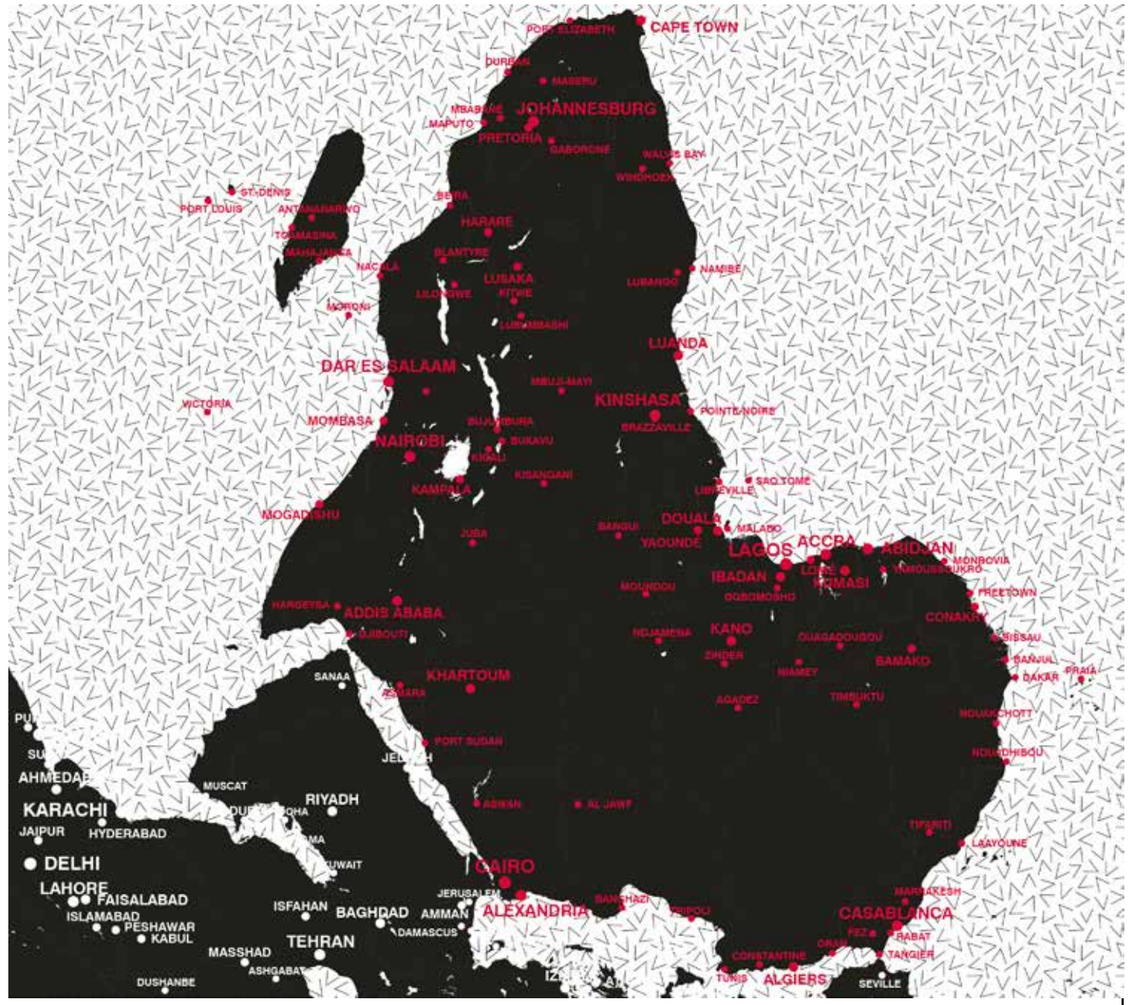
"BY THIS HE MEANT THAT AFRICA WAS LITERALLY AN "OUTLOOK," A SHIFTING VANTAGE POINT FROM AND THROUGH WHICH TO ENGAGE THE WORLD; SOMETHING THAT COULD BE NARROWED DOWN TO A MICROSCOPIC VISIBILITY OR WIDENED TO TAKE EVERYTHING IN WITHOUT DISCRIMINATION OR DISCRETION."

As such, the Pan African dreams that were the stuff of daily tutelage through Diallo's primary and secondary education, were not those of some united polity eviscerating colonial borders nor of some consolidation of Black peoples dispersed across seas, but something much simpler yet elusive: dreams of spreading out, being more or less this or that, of occupying different versions of oneself to audiences that would never be the same twice. Dreams were those of a life beyond capture, for even as many African societies had been based on the prospects of seizing or being seized, of being captivated by different streams of thought, the ethos of the Futa was essentially "never give anything away." One can be dispossessed, charitable, or sacrifice anything, but never show all of your cards. Younger and thoroughly urbanized Fulbe from the region would often complain that their elders never told them anything, never shared the essential secrets or wisdom, always invoking that what they needed to know was "right in front of them" if only they could see it, if only they altered the angle on which they looked at things. But the rule of the Futa was never divulged directly, and never stayed still long enough to ever be fully "illuminated."

Here again, the hinge points to questions of access, touching upon the preoccupations of many African societies with the politics of exposure, of modulating just how much of the world can be let in at any given time, and what has to remain closed off. For within a generalized West African Islamic ethos, every person is inscribed in and by a specific project that can only be realized through deterring constant attempts by others to extract from it, to dilute or distort it. Thus, what one performs, in all of the different versions of oneself that can be dissimulated on the basis of everything that project is not, is a constantly moving hinge that never stabilizes the lines of sight and exposure. In a twist of W.E.B. Du Bois' notion of the veil being the demarcation between white and Black life lived in the same city or country, here the public persona is itself a veil, driven by the contents of a project that remains inaccessible to all potential viewers, that only manages to realize itself indirectly, that never culminates in a single state or cultural imagination. For Diallo, this is his sense of what Pan African meant.

Accessing Worlds and Hinging on Dissimulation ///

This is not to obviate all of the other kinds of Pan African dreams that were oriented toward some concretization of unity or political coordination, some valorization of racial-cultural commonality, or at least some elaboration of critical thought that recognized its fundamental connections to multiple diasporas. These dreams were certainly for a long time mulled and deliberated across mission schools, army bases, universities, trade unions, masonic lodges, political parties, Islamic brotherhoods, women's fraternities, and market associations. Contested versions



The Continent main cities' constellation and their neighbors. / Map by Léopold Lambert (2020).

of these dreams certainly informed the responses to the protracted negotiations around eventual sovereignty and subsequent consolidations and dissolutions of regional blocks, currencies, and trade regimes. Cities that long held stranger's quarters, shifting and mobile populations from multiple elsewheres, in most respects embodied the folding in of cultural influences, political ideas, and trades that originated from across a larger Black world and actively sought to be involved in that world as a matter of national identity.

The capacity to sustain, extend, and participate in a larger world, however, remained largely dependent on the expansion of highly localized and territorially rooted extraction activities. Despite the early postcolonial emphasis on import substitution and industrialization, the imperative to circumvent being extracted from, ironically, was linked to a trajectory of an economic modernization almost exclusively based on the extraction of resources. This usually meant a concentration on gold, diamonds, oil, copper, cocoa, and palm oil. Such re-intensification of seemingly "colonial-oriented" economies raised issues about belonging-who are the original inhabitants of specific regions and to whom does the site of extraction belong? At times this meant that diverse groups who lived together for decades, if not longer, treated each other as strangers. There were pressures on people to acquire land and assets, not in the areas where they may have lived all of their lives, but in their area of family origin. Disputes broke out across the continent as to who is a citizen and who has the right to vote where. At the same time, most African cities persisted to be domains of "strange alliance." Beneath the veneer of discernible ethnic, religious, and national antagonisms, all kinds of

"SUCH RE-INTENSIFICATION OF SEEMINGLY "COLONIAL-ORIENTED" ECONOMIES RAISED ISSUES ABOUT BELONGING-WHO ARE THE ORIGINAL INHABITANTS OF SPECIFIC REGIONS AND TO WHOM DOES THE SITE OF EXTRACTION BELONG?"






1. The Kenyatta International Conference Center in Nairobi. **2.** La Pyramide in Abidjan. **3.** Kariakoo Market in Dar es Salaam. **4.** Black Star Square in Accra. / Photos by Jordi C, Newphotoservice, Ismizotz, and Jbdodane.

collaborations could be continuously, if often only provisionally, be pieced together, given the importance of dissimulation in terms of friends and enemies.

Often, fights about belonging and the rights incumbent on belonging for access to resources were more about what the control of resources meant to enhancing the possibilities to operate on the level of the larger world. The attempts were often not to bring territory under the singular control of a particular force, but to create as many possibilities of linking that territory to a plurality of allegiances and opportunities. This plurality would then enable local actors to feel that their operations in localized spaces were also conduits to or extensions of a much larger world. The fight was not so much over the terms of territorial encompassment or closure, but rather over maintaining a sense of "open-endedness." Narrow, seemingly parochial factions and groupings predominate in these conflicts. But the specific configuration of "sides" is not so much directed toward defending specific turf. Rather, the participating factions, ethnicities, or affiliations were honed to better manage shifting allegiances and participation in multiple external networks. Again, the notion of the hinge is at work, regarding territory not necessarily as culminations of attainment or manifestations of essential identities, but rather as apertures, where different representations of reality depended upon "shutter speeds" and other modulations of angle and exposure.

"NO LONGER, IF EVER, SIMPLE NODES OF EVACUATION, DIALLO'S NOTIONS OF THE HINGE ARE PARTICULARLY APPLICABLE IN THE WAYS IN WHICH AFRICAN CITIES MODULATE DIFFERENT EXPOSURES AND ANGLES FOR THEIR INHABITANTS, OF WIDENING AND NARROWING SPECIFIC VECTORS OF CONTACT AND EXCHANGE."

African cities were largely constructed as points of contact — as places to organize the evacuation of resources and to construct mechanisms through which broader territories could be administered. While they continue to play this role in the postcolonial period, critical points of convergence and articulation with the global economy do, however, take place outside these functions. No longer, if ever, simple nodes of evacuation, Diallo's notions of the hinge are particularly applicable in the ways in which African cities modulate different exposures and angles for their inhabitants, of widening and narrowing specific vectors of contact and exchange. The rhythms of long-honed local institutions may endure — the burial societies, the *tontines*, the market associations, the secret societies, the churches and mosques. But with increased media savvy and the capacity to invent all kinds of both sophisticated and make shift communication tools, new hybrid sensibilities, cultural materials, and languages are being invented that enable more voluminous lateral connections across different subregions.

Many urban streets remain tough, bastions of intensified militancy and hustle, no-go areas for many, as illegalities pile up in some urban contexts that are increasingly overwhelmed by the demands made of them by unrelenting youth bulges and inward migrations. At the same time, when it is possible, very few are sitting still. If one has a bit of extra money you are on your way somewhere, even if only a different place in the same city.

Additionally, the manner in which individuals act or behave at the interfaces or junctions with global economies






1. Lagos **2.** Cairo **3.** Casablanca **4.** Johannesburg. / Photos by Ariyo Olasunkanmi, Leonid Andronov, TinasDreamworld, and Sopotnicki.

— i.e., how they access and manipulate opportunities to acquire widely divergent volumes of extracted resources — occurs largely outside the conventions and moral economies of either village or urban-based contexts. Here, individuals, working as renegade miners, diamond purchasers, chasers, smugglers, financiers, go-betweens, and agents of multinational corporations, are continuously "re-socialized" by multiple, often ephemeral, institutions that attempt to give some shape to these engagements and economic activities. Pan Africanism as hinge is more a matter of ebbs and flows that take place across mostly indirect channels, contingent upon the willingness and the performative ability of individuals and groups to recognize themselves across various dissimulations, across various versions of what they are and could be — part of the essential toolkit for being on the road. It's always a temporary thing.

A Pan African Machine ///

"It was always going to be only temporary," Amadou Diallo said when referring to almost everything in his long life. The simple mud brick house he acquired from a cousin executed by Sékou Touré, his multifarious residencies in some 20 cities across the world and the durations of his stay. His life was always going to be on the move in order to exist even as many aspects were replete with permanence. As a young man he simply bought cloth in Togo and brought it to a simple stall in a peripheral market in Conakry. Decades later he was arranging containers of textiles, electronics, foodstuffs, and hardware from Shenzhen to ports across West Africa. Having spent years shuttling between Bangkok, Dubai, Abidjan, and Conakry, he was one of the first generation of African traders to base themselves in Guangzhou, later, spreading out across other Chinese entrepôt before heading to Mumbai as China got "overcrowded."

"HAVING SPENT YEARS SHUTTLING BETWEEN BANGKOK, DUBAI, ABIDJAN, AND CONAKRY, HE WAS ONE OF THE FIRST GENERATION OF AFRICAN TRADERS TO BASE THEMSELVES IN GUANGZHOU, LATER, SPREADING OUT ACROSS OTHER CHINESE ENTREPÔT BEFORE HEADING TO MUMBAI AS CHINA GOT "OVERCROWDED."

At first, he collected money from family members in the Futa in order to purchase wax cloth from markets in Lomé to and from which he traveled by road in a string of shared taxis, the roofs piled high with assortments of tarpaulin covered goods. After the extractions from different versions of police at seemingly endless roadblocks along the route, he made little profit from arduous efforts, sometimes shifting his forays into more obscure frontier and improvised markets, whose temporary existence sometimes meant that they had already gone by the time he arrived. At the outset his generosity was a skill, as he went out of his way to display kindness and information to fellow compatriots, offering to tend to a host of small difficulties that Guineans living or traveling across West Africa had back home. But he rarely said anything about what this help consisted of or much about himself, the helper. What I did know was that coming from a family of well-known *marabouts*, Quranic teachers and counsellors, there were networks of contacts in Conakry, Kankan, and Kissidougou — the main trading towns — to which he could appeal, and from which he could take orders for different goods. He ingrained himself into the long-resident Guinean community in Treichville, Abidjan, but then set himself somewhat apart in near-by

Koumassi where he could maneuver more freely outside the rigid Fulbe hierarchies of his home region, make contacts with related Fulani merchants coming from Nigeria, Senegal, and Niger also seeking temporary respite from prolonged periods of apprenticeships and obligations to a host of "big men." Operating outside of the order of things, these interchanges and sometimes alliances were maintained under the radar and largely could be only temporary. They, nevertheless, proved useful as a means to posit backdoor channels into otherwise tightly controlled marketing systems.

"BUT IN THIS BUSINESS, AS AMADOU PUTS IT, EVERYTHING 'LASTS ONLY FOR THE MOMENT' THAT NO MATTER HOW EFFECTIVELY A TRADER INSTITUTIONALIZES HIM OR HERSELF IN A GIVEN LOCATION OR SET OF TRADING NETWORKS, NO MATTER HOW MUCH TRUST IS CULTIVATED, THE COMPOSITION OF THE GAME ITSELF AND ITS PLAYERS EXUDE VOLATILITY DIFFICULT TO STABILIZE, PARTICULAR IN FACE OF A SWARM OF YOUNGER ITINERANTS WILLING TO TAKE CUT-THROAT RISKS AND AIM FOR QUICK MONEY."

By the early 1980s word was spreading that Dubai was a cheap place to buy textiles and clothing as well as other consumables. The city had amassed substantial warehouse space, had completed a new port, and was a relatively easy point of access to goods coming from all over Africa. Import fees were low, storage space cheap, there were almost no controls over exports, and visas were freely available. For those not knowing Dubai, initially the acquisition of visas was tied to hotel stays and to brokerage through specific trading clearing houses. While these linkages greatly facilitated efficiencies in emerging trading networks, they were also instituted by the Emirates to ensure temporary stays. But as traders converged on Dubai from all across Africa and Asia, the resultant heterogeneity of visitors and activities largely mitigated these controls, and Amadou set up his first trading company, expanding the scope of his purchases to supply markets at the peripheries of Abidjan, Accra, and Conakry to avoid the layers of middlemen that operated as gatekeepers to the major central urban markets. Initially, Amadou pursued an empty suitcase mode during his early forays to Dubai, but soon started shifting increased volumes to Porto Novo, Benin, which for years acted as a freeport for West Africa.

Islamic connections initially proved important as a means of securing places to stay and store outside the official logistical systems. For at every level, Dubai was about repeating temporariness, providing an infrastructure for coming and going without institutionalization of residence or commerce. Of course this has substantially changed over the past decades, and Amadou, himself, retains several restaurants, a freight forwarding company, and two warehouses in the Deira district. Still, a major move Amadou made was to enroll in an Islamic studies course at the then recently opened University of Sharjah, enabling him to deepen and extend his relationships with younger Emiratis themselves looking for ways to take advantage of the burgeoning international trade. Amadou's trademark generosity then could be used to assist other Guinean traders passing through and to cultivate their loyalty and work in Guinea, as well as Côte d'Ivoire. This assistance was not only extended to Guinean nationals but to Africans coming from other regions, and Amadou's ability to purchase property in both Dubai and Sharjah enabled him to establish hospitality centers that could assist with a variety of problems around documentation, fake brokerage, and onerous fees and custom duties at various African ports of entry.

"ALWAYS WORKING THE HINGE MODULATING VISIBILITY AND INVISIBILITY, SOLIDARITY AND MULTIPLE AUTONOMIES, MONEY AND SPIRIT, AMADOU DEMONSTRATES HOW THE APPARENT PAROCHIAL AND BAROQUE COMMERCIAL TIES LONG CHARACTERIZING THE ECONOMIC LIFE OF THE FUTA PRECIPITATED WIDE RANGING PROTOTYPES FOR BEING AFRICAN IN THE LARGER WORLD."

But in this business, as Amadou puts it, everything "lasts only for the moment" — that no matter how effectively a trader institutionalizes him or herself in a given location or set of trading networks, no matter how much trust is cultivated, the composition of the game itself and its players exude volatility difficult to stabilize, particular in face of a swarm of younger itinerants willing to take cut-throat risks and aim for quick money. Modulating the necessary balances between reliable information and contacts, the expansion of consumer markets, while at the same time curtailing the number of intermediaries necessary to do so, all requires constant adjustment, as in the hinge. Displays of efficacy — in acquiring cheap goods and cheap transport — often means sharing sourcing and distribution networks in order to retain visibility as a predominant player. Yet, at the same time, Amadou always had to downplay his real capacity, lessen his chances of becoming a target of envy, so operations, inputs, contacts, names on businesses, statuses within various communities had to be shifted, ever so slightly, but again imbuing everything with a sense of temporariness. Particularly as he tried to fulfill his obligations at home — something which he preferred to but could not reasonably circumvent — notoriety in commercial endeavors invited unwelcome attention from bureaucrats and politicians always willing to arbitrarily invent or apply arcane regulations that always amounted to escalating shakedowns. Particularly from a Fulbe region in a country where up until recent years Malinke ruled, Amadou remained committed to a series of modest retails outlets under his own name, even though it took the lion's share of the proceeds from some of the city's predominant commerçants.

Technical Africa ///

Amadou would go on to establish successful ventures in Bangkok, Guangzhou, Yiwa, and finally Mumbai, always staying a step ahead of crowded competition and repression of African entrepreneurship when it became too visible to Asian "hosts." Always working the hinge modulating visibility and invisibility, solidarity and multiple autonomies, money and spirit, Amadou demonstrates how the apparent parochial and baroque commercial ties long characterizing the economic life of the Futa precipitated wide ranging prototypes for being African in the larger world. Filling containers in Guangzhou destined for various ports



"Mother Africa." Artwork in the streets of Kliptown in Soweto. / Photo by Léopold Lambert (2019).

of call in West Africa were carefully curated to address the consumption needs of both an aspiring elite and itinerant farmers in the backlands of the Sahel, as commerce was viewed as both solidifying existent lines of articulation and developing new ones. Amadou's forwarding companies in Dubai existed not only to circumvent constricted customs, but also to host an often-motley crew of Islamic students, young women workers staffing offices and hotels on their own for the very first time, and adventurers without clear objectives. For commerce was to be a conduit of dispersed occupations, an unsettling of fixed expectations, all of which turned the cities he passed through into imaginary inventions.

Pan Africanism here goes beyond political aspiration or the familiar tropes of solidarity. Rather, it hinges itself on the multiplicity of more technical operations and strategic implantations across disparate terrains, using whatever means are available to engender connections, lines of stabilization and flight. As something perhaps infrastructural, it is the culmination of many like Amadou plying the world, never regarding a particular place as a definitive destination, yet never losing sight of all that the Chicago's of Conakry might very well be, right now. ■

"PAN AFRICANISM HERE GOES BEYOND POLITICAL ASPIRATION OR THE FAMILIAR TROPES OF SOLIDARITY. RATHER, IT HINGES ITSELF ON THE MULTIPLICITY OF MORE TECHNICAL OPERATIONS AND STRATEGIC IMPLANTATIONS ACROSS DISPARATE TERRAINS, USING WHATEVER MEANS ARE AVAILABLE TO ENGENDER CONNECTIONS, LINES OF STABILIZATION AND FLIGHT."

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DISTURBING THE ORDER: A 21ST CENTURY APPROACH TO AN AFRICAN FEDERAL STATE

JOAO GABRIEL

In this text, Joao Gabriell urges to make Nkrumah's dream of an African Federal State come true. This, he argues, is not only a political necessity on the continent, but also for the diaspora; not a call for the erasure of diversity in the name of unity, but a crucial step in the anti-colonial and anti-capitalist struggles.

"We face neither East nor West: we face forward." These words, pronounced by Kwame Nkrumah during the Cold War, expressed a desire to break from the long history of oppression and dependency in which Africa was retained vis-à-vis the great powers. But not only did these words address what to move away from, they also announced a path for the future. As other key figures of Pan-Africanism, such as Tanzanian Julius Nyerere and Senegalese Cheikh Anta Diop, Nkrumah had a clear vision of what "forward" meant: building a Federal African State, from north to south, east to west. Nkrumah was convinced that national independence gained from the end of the 1950s and for most African countries throughout the 1960s wasn't sufficient to secure economic and political freedom. Instead, he believed that continental unity, embodied by a concrete political entity, was to be an urgent necessity:

"*We therefore need a common political foundation for the unification of our policies for economic planning, defense, and diplomatic relations with foreign countries. There is no reason for this basis of political action to encroach upon the fundamental sovereignty of the various mays of Africa. They would continue to exercise their independent authority, except in areas reserved for joint action, in the interests of security and orderly development of the entire continent.*" (Kwame Nkrumah, *Africa Must Unite*, 1963).

This quote is crucial for at least two reasons. The first is that it highlights the three pillars of the state envisioned by Nkrumah: economic planning, which includes a shared currency; defense, with a continental army; and diplomatic relations codified by a common Constitution defining the terms of interaction with foreign countries. The second reason is that it testifies to Nkrumah's political wisdom countering caricatural depictions of this project as a utopia due to the fundamental, regional, and national specificities on the continent. Far from ignoring them, Nkrumah's goal was to create a clever articulation between continental, national and even communal interests. A Federal African State was neither conceived as an erasure of African diversity on multiple levels, nor a denial of specific political, economical and cultural stakes, all of which are rooted in the continent's diverse historical contexts. On the contrary, the state envisioned by Nkrumah was supposed to be the embodiment of this diversity, and maybe more importantly, the best bulwark against the neocolonial tendency to destroy societies and mold them to meet the capitalist productive apparatus' needs. Indeed capitalism, behind a façade of Westernization, is the driving force of homogenization. Therefore, African federal unity didn't — and still shouldn't — mean uniformity, but rather, a shield used to protect the numerous ways of organizing life displayed on the continent, as well as the possibility to sustain a living and enjoy the continent's resources.

"ON THE CONTRARY, THE STATE ENVISIONED BY NKRUMAH WAS SUPPOSED TO BE THE EMBODIMENT OF THIS DIVERSITY, AND MAYBE MORE IMPORTANTLY, THE BEST BULWARK AGAINST THE NEOCOLONIAL TENDENCY TO DESTROY SOCIETIES AND MOLD THEM TO MEET THE CAPITALIST PRODUCTIVE APPARATUS' NEEDS."

"A FEDERAL AFRICAN STATE WAS NEITHER CONCEIVED AS AN ERASURE OF AFRICAN DIVERSITY ON MULTIPLE LEVELS, NOR A DENIAL OF SPECIFIC POLITICAL, ECONOMICAL AND CULTURAL STAKES, ALL OF WHICH ARE ROOTED IN THE CONTINENT'S DIVERSE HISTORICAL CONTEXTS."

This vision, though carried by multiple generations of Pan-African activists, has yet to be translated into reality. This is due to multiple factors such as political oppositions that Nkrumah faced in Ghana, battles for leadership between African heads of states, the growing hegemony of liberal Pan-African alliances who increasingly kept their distance from the anticolonial and marxist approach of Pan-Africanism, and last but not least, with constant assault of neocolonial powers. As a result, many in Black political circles of the diaspora that I have encountered both in France and in the United States see the project of a federal state as an old fashioned dream of the 1960s. On the continent, nationalists, religious, or tribal interests seem to often prevail, furthering the notion that an African state is a naive utopia that will never see the light. To make this even more grim, the neocolonial mechanisms of foreign predations and the enrichment of the local bourgeoisie are more implanted than ever. Thus, this raises the following question: is there still value in pursuing the project of building a Federal African State? Following the stance of many contemporary Pan-Africanists, who refuse to give way to defeatism, in particular Johannesburg-based political leader Julius Malema, I believe that a United States of Africa — regardless of what we name it — is still the best option to achieve emancipation from



"Black Matter." / Artwork by Duduetsang Lamola (2020) for "The Afromap of Space," a radio show by Graeme Arendse on Ubuntu Beats Radio.

contemporary colonialism. I would even personally argue that the United States of Africa is *the* necessity of the 21st century, not only for Africans and people of African descent, but also for the entire fate of humanity. Sounds overreaching? It might be, but this statement is neither delusional or pretentious. Rather, it is an acknowledgement of both the historical role of the exploitation of Africans in order to build capitalism and the contemporary dispossession of African resources, not only by Western powers, but also by other states such as China and Russia.

Disruption of Global Equilibrium ///

For the past five centuries, Africa has been (and it remains today) the battlefield of competing empires and modern day nation states, as well as multinationals. Though not equal in power, each entity seeks either the workforce or riches of the soil to grow their wealth. In this context of crossfire from almost everywhere, where the world's economic order depends in large part on Africa's subordination, the modification of this continent's status could provoke a tremendous disruption of that global equilibrium. Transforming the current political order with a federal state could open a window for other oppressed peoples in the Global South, as well as challenging the very foundation of capitalist exploitation. How then can this be achieved? For instance, the international Pan-African-Umoja created in 2012, which replaced to initial Congo-based Pan-African League of Umoja-Congo, affirms that its goal is "the construction of an African Federal State (United States of Africa) through the conquest of African political and economic powers on a popular basis." This stance is further explained by members of the League, including one of its former presidents, in a January 2015 Kinshasa-based TV show *Entretien*, on Tele 7: the objective is to gain presidential election even in a small number of African states, and start a federation on that basis with a number of urgent demands and goals, to embody a concrete example of continental unity, offering an alternate set of politics. As explained in the TV show by the League members, the goal is to emulate and support other parties or coalitions in other nations who subscribe to ideas of both continental unity and political rupture vis-à-vis the current state of affairs, hoping that once they win the presidency, they join the federal state. This idea is not new. It draws on unitary attempts dating back to the late 1950s. The Ghana-Guinea Union, signed on November 23, 1958 by Nkrumah and Sékou Touré was an attempt to not only create a regional alliance against the signs of an emerging neocolonialism, and especially against France and De Gaulle's economic war against the newly independent Guinea. It was also a way

"IN THIS CONTEXT OF CROSSFIRE FROM ALMOST EVERYWHERE, WHERE THE WORLD'S ECONOMIC ORDER DEPENDS IN LARGE PART ON AFRICA'S SUBORDINATION, THE MODIFICATION OF THIS CONTINENT'S STATUS COULD PROVOKE A TREMENDOUS DISRUPTION OF THAT GLOBAL EQUILIBRIUM."

to develop a support system for other states fighting for their freedom. Below state level, other forms of alliances existed such as PAFMECA (Pan-African Freedom Movement of East and Central Africa) formed in September 1958 at a conference held in Tanganyika for the purpose of coordinating nationalists movements in East and Central Africa and achieving independence. The goal today is to learn from these initiatives, understand why they failed to achieve their mission, and to have a clear view of the issues at stake for us at present. This requires having a multi-scale analysis that takes both internal and external forces into account.

"THIS IS WHY UNITY CAN'T BE THE ONLY HORIZON: ANTI-COLONIALISM AS A STRATEGY HAS TO BE AN EXPLICIT GOAL OF THE FEDERAL AFRICAN STATE."

Equally important is to understand that, far from being a one-time creation with all its members already in place, the federal state envisioned by historic and contemporary radical Pan-Africanists is a *process* to remake the balance of power within Africa and outside of Africa. In other words, if a party or a coalition of Pan-Africanist organizations win presidential elections with an openly Pan-African platform in three countries for instance, they can join their forces and declare the creation of the African Federal State. With this entity *in the making*, they would progressively become an inspiration for analogous movements in other African states. The declaration of existence of the embryonic state cannot only be formal. It will exist through its actual actions. For instance, the removal of political frontiers could be one of them. People from concerned countries could travel in what would become the same territory. Other stands can come from developing voting strategies on continental or international issues. In addition to this institutional level, grassroots politics in neighborhoods, schools, villages, will have to be supported — not "implemented." What I mean by this is that local activism that already exists and already makes sense in sustaining people's lives within a specific region, neighborhood or street, will need to be supported— not replaced — by the embryonic state, in order to make positive transformations. It cannot just be a new coalition only benefiting the elite in power.

"ANTI-BLACK RACISM IN EUROPE OR NORTH AMERICA IS A CONSTANT REMINDER, EVEN FOR THOSE BORN AND RAISED THERE FOR MULTIPLE GENERATIONS, THAT BLACK PEOPLE WILL NEVER 'TRULY' BE FRENCH, SWISS, OR CANADIAN."

The more the African Federal State will grow — both in number of countries as members and in power — the more it will gain stature in the concert of nations. One may say that multiple forms of "Pan-African" alliances already exist, both regional and continental. Nonetheless, if we consider the case of the African Union, not only do its policies not offer concrete alternative strategies against Western hegemony, but the one nation-model state still prevails. Thus, instead of being a coalition of states who, despite their specificities, share continental interests, the African Union works as a platform for each head of state to advance his own strategy for mostly national (and class) purposes. This is why unity can't be the only horizon: anti-colonialism as a strategy has to be an explicit goal of the Federal African State. Pan-Africanists who believe and work toward this project are aware that a huge amount of difficulties stand in the way. Many African heads of states and the bourgeoisie comprador — i.e the African bourgeoisie that directly derives its fortune from neocolonialism — all those who have interest in the status-quo will oppose any attempt to transform the economic paradigm that governs the asymmetric relationships between great powers and Africa, as is the case of European-African relations, the Economic Partnership Agreement (EPAs). Surely, some segments of society notably in the business sector are benefiting from such agreements, but overall the economic divide between these two geopolitical regions remains.

Empowering the Diaspora ///

A Federal African State would also be of great significance for people of African descent outside of the Continent. It concerns both those who live in the West, or in the Global South as "Black minorities," as well as those who live in Black majority countries outside of Africa, such as in the islands of the Caribbean. For the first category, I would suggest that the United States of Africa could strengthen anti-racist movements in the Global North. One of the main challenges of these movements, is to define a political project, and not solely take oppositional stands against everyday expressions of racism on TV, in politics, at work, etc. But one can understand how difficult it can be to elaborate a project in hostile countries where it's impossible to completely feel that you belong. Anti-Black racism in Europe or North America is a constant reminder, even for those born and raised there for multiple generations, that Black people will never "truly" be French, Swiss, or Canadian.

At the same time, we can't invest in useless — or even dangerous — fantasies that we will all "go back" to Africa (or a Black majority country of the Caribbean). How does one resolve this paradox? I think that a solid materialist articulation of Pan-Africanism and anti-racism offers an answer: we (some of us) can be involved in issues pertaining to our *life conditions* wherever we live in the West (housing, schools, police brutality etc.) and, also, we (some of us) can be involved in *political issues* pertaining to either our country of origin, or a Federal African State to come. In other words, the goal is not to divest from issues that affect our daily lives in the West, but instead of pursuing the useless goal of making the political elite of Western countries racially diverse, we could re-orient our efforts towards the political fate of Afro-Caribbean or African countries and build concrete — and not abstract or projected — relationships with local activists and organizations.

This has nothing to do with sentimentalism and how close or not we "feel" to our countries of origin (or those of our parents, grandparents or ancestors). It has to do with the political conviction that imperialism must be defeated at its root, meaning where the main source of its power resides, namely in the neo-colonies, and especially in Africa. It is also renewing with 20th century anti-colonial efforts when activists from Africa and the Caribbean who migrated for instance, were deeply invested in the fight for independence from Europe. It's true for France-based activists of the Algerian Front de libération nationale (FLN), and also for Caribbean students and activists of *Association des Étudiants Caribéens* (AGEC), who created nationalist organizations while living in France.

"IT HAS TO DO WITH THE POLITICAL CONVICTION THAT IMPERIALISM MUST BE DEFEATED AT ITS ROOT, MEANING WHERE THE MAIN SOURCE OF ITS POWER RESIDES, NAMELY IN THE NEO-COLONIES, AND ESPECIALLY IN AFRICA."

Most importantly, I'm a firm believer that the Federal African State project can galvanize diasporas to transform our anger into a real political goal. Not because we will do this "for Africa," but because a Pan-African state is the condition to *constrain* the West and other regional powers such as Russia, to change their policies toward their Black minority and toward the African continent. It is in the diasporas' best interest that Africa's status improves. For the second category of diasporas, meaning those in their own Black majority country, a federal African state can also offer strategic support on some of the issues that they can face in isolation. As a matter of fact, I'm convinced that the issues of the state-sanctioned chlordécone poisoning of Guadeloupe and Martinique — Caribbean islands still under French rule — requires a Pan-Africanist (and overall international) struggle of countries affected by environmental colonialism. Once again, the objective is to turn the scales in favor of Africans and People of African descent, and let's face it, for now, highly fragmented diasporic struggles don't have the power to make the foundations of neo-colonialism sway, though they demonstrate our ongoing resistance and can bring us some victories locally.

The African Federal State and the Paradox of Emancipation ///

As a continuous *process* and not a finished object, the government of an African Federal State must keep a set of tensions alive to prevent the said state from freezing in a repressive and reactionary posture. For example, we must imagine modes of governance and representativeness that prevent the establishment of a political elite. Likewise, the role of the "arbiter" of the federal state will have to be constantly rethought, to know what extent and under what conditions it can be a recourse for the people and specific communities who are unfairly treated by their "national" representatives. Let's say, to illustrate the point, that a community of farmers in a region of the continent expelled from their lands by their "national" state for the sake of a business company (even one owned by an African). An African federal state driven by an anti-colonial — and thus anti-capitalist — spirit could intervene against these mechanisms of predation, if these peasants take their "national" state to court. Finally, this federal process must from the outset guarantee a great deal of autonomy to the movements of civil societies, which, having the power to stand up to it, or even to threaten it, guarantee that it will not become authoritarian. In short, the challenge is to succeed in creating a state whose existence is justified by a particular *historical sequence* (articulations between nation-states and supranational federations), fulfilling a *particular mission* (disrupt global balances by giving to Africa a more favorable place in the concert of nations). But as it progresses, it must build the conditions for its overcoming. In reality, building a United States of Africa is not so much of an utopia. However, going beyond the state form, whatever it may be, certainly looks more like it — at least for now. May Africa become the place of this achievement, for humanity's sake, even if it means taking a path, which at first glance, may seem paradoxical. ■

Joao Gabriel is a Guadelupean activist. After several years in France, he is now based in the United States where he studies History. He runs a blog, "Le blog de Joao," in which he writes about (neo)colonialism, as well as Caribbean and Pan-African issues

ON UNITY AND RESISTANCE: A PEOPLE'S LOVE LETTER TO THE BIRTHPLACE OF THE SPIRIT OF RESISTANCE

NAMATA SERUMAGA-MUSISI

In this manifesto for Pan-African futures, Namata Serumaga-Musisi shares with us the spirit of her activist engagement, in particular as Commander of Creative Arts & Advocacy for the Ghana-based organization Fighters and as Diaspora Co-ordinator for People Power, the Ugandan liberation movement.

"*So many blessings must flow from our unity; so many disasters must follow on our continued disunity, that our failure to unite today will not be attributed by posterity only to faulty reasoning and lack of courage, but to our capitulation before the forces of imperialism.*" (Osagyefo Kwame Nkrumah, Inaugural ceremony of the OAU Conference in Addis Ababa, 1963.)

We must start this text and we must end this text by saying:

Africa Must Unite. Now.

"WHEN WE SAY 'AFRICA MUST UNITE,' WE SPEAK OF THE PEOPLE, NOT THE 'LEADERS,' NEVER THESE LEADERS. HOW COULD PUPPETS EVER SPEAK FOR US ON THE RIGHTS OF BLACK PEOPLE?"

And when we say "Africa Must Unite," we speak of the People, not the "leaders," never these leaders. How could puppets ever speak for us on the rights of Black People? And when we are targeted in the Mediterranean, in Minneapolis, in Kuwait, who among them can cast the first stone?

The dictator Museveni has been torturing and murdering Ugandans since the 1970s. Not even his ascension to the presidency was enough to stop him from killing us.

The day before the murder of Lonmin employees at Marikana, non-executive Director (and now South African President) Cyril Ramaphosa wrote, "They are plainly dastardly criminals and must be characterised as such. [...] In line with this [...] there needs to be 'concomitant action to address this situation'."

"WE HAVE BEEN RELEGATED AND WE OFTEN RELEGATE OURSELVES TO THE SIDELINES OF OUR SO-CALLED DEMOCRACIES, LOUDLY CRITICIZING THOSE WHO ACTIVELY UNDERMINE US, ACTIVELY STEAL FROM US, ACTIVELY OPPRESS US, BUT TOO RARELY TAKING DEFINITIVE ACTION OURSELVES."

In August 2019, Muhammadu Buhari's Nigerian State Security Service arrested human rights activist, pro-democracy campaigner, former presidential candidate Omoyele Sowore for alleged treason after he called for #RevolutionNow. He was held for months.

Alpha Conde's military brutalized and murdered anti-referendum protestors in Guinea, as the People fought the adoption of a new Constitution which would allow him to extend his rule.

There is Gnassingbe in Togo.
Nguema in Equatorial-Guinea.
Biya in Cameroon.
The list goes on.
Who among them can possibly speak?

When we say "Africa Must Unite," we speak of the People.
The People of Africa Must Unite!

Comrade Kyagulanyi 'Bobi Wine' Ssentamu and the Comrades of the People Power Movement of Uganda, we will be free.

Comrade Farida Nabourema and the Togolese Civil League fighting oppression in Togo, Comrade Martial Pa'Nucci and Ras le Bol in Congo Brazzaville, the Comrades of Y'en a Marre in Senegal, Comrade Alice Ilunga and LUCHA in the DRC, and of course my Pan Africanist Comrades of the Economic Fighters League, fighting for economic democracy, challenging the minority elite, and working to dismantle systems of oppression in the land of Osagyefo's birth, and beyond.

Africa Must Unite. We will be free.

We live in a time ripe for positive action, but too often exist in a state of apathy, a state of fear. We have been relegated and we often relegate ourselves to the sidelines of our so-called democracies, loudly criticizing those who actively undermine us, actively steal from us, actively oppress us, but too rarely taking definitive action ourselves.

But that is the nature of systems of oppression. Such systems are designed to first, deprive us of our sense of *ownership*, over our land, our resources, our state, and force us into a state of "At-leastism," an abusive state where we accept the minimum offered to us as a deliverable, taking it as a sign of functionality, forgetting that we should be demanding improved delivery from the state and from



Members of Fighters and comrades with Osagyefo at Kwame Nkrumah Park in Accra in solidarity with the Black Lives Matter uprising, June 2020. / Fighters Archives.

the government sitting at its helm, forgetting that we are *employers* of the state and its governors, and not beggars waiting for grace from above.

We sit in "At least," and "At least," "At least," in the hope that all these tiny morsels of development or progress thrown in our direction will have the cumulative effect of sustainable development. But it never does. The roads that are hurriedly paved through dodgy contracts soon fall to ruin, while the floods carry away our brothers and sisters, and our hospitals remain without adequate support, and our produce rots in our farms, and our debt rises and rises and rises exponentially in a manner that is neither determined nor approved of by the People.

Do these scenarios sound familiar to you, my brother in Chad, my sister in Zimbabwe? Because I am speaking of the corner of Africa where my roots lie, Uganda.

Africa Must Unite, now.

In an effort to save ourselves from the "At-least" condition, we sink into individualism, erecting iron bubbles around ourselves, spending every ounce of energy we have to ensure that the small world around us remains in some form of equilibrium, a tiny boat in a stormy ocean, always on the verge of capsizing.

That tiny boat requires all of our time and all of our energy to keep upright and so, in a state of fear, exhaustion and, again, "At-leastism," we close our eyes to the growing oppression around us, focusing all of our energy on the boat, forgetting that it is floating in an ocean, an ocean that knows no borders, an ocean heaving under the turbulence of neocolonialism. In focusing on this tiny boat we consolidate a system that is highly functional, functional in its mandate to accumulate all power for a minority elite.

"WE CLOSE OUR EYES TO THE GROWING OPPRESSION AROUND US, FOCUSING ALL OF OUR ENERGY ON THE BOAT, FORGETTING THAT IT IS FLOATING IN AN OCEAN, AN OCEAN THAT KNOWS NO BORDERS, AN OCEAN HEAVING UNDER THE TURBULENCE OF NEOCOLONIALISM."

60 people are wiped out in a bus accident on a bad road, and we think, "At least it was not me or my People."

A Black man is killed by racist police in the United States, and we say, "Di wo fie asem" (Eat your house matter - Mind your own business).

A poor 90 year old woman is beaten to death by a community accusing her of witchcraft, and we have a brief collective flash of anger before we return to our bubbles, silent on the issue as we wait for the next murder or attack.



Members of the Economic Fighters League march in support of the liberation struggle in Uganda, on January 26, 2020. / Photo by Khaleb Nii Odartey Aryee.

Do these scenarios sound familiar to you, my brother in Somalia, my sister in Mali? I am now speaking of the corner of Africa where my heart beats, Ghana.

Africa Must Unite, now.

"UNTIL WE CAN SAY THAT THESE PRECIOUS BLACK LIVES MATTER IN THE ROOT THAT IS AFRICA. THIS IS THE BIRTHPLACE OF THE SPIRIT OF RESISTANCE."

We start to normalize oppressive behavior, analyzing corruption and injustice from a cynical and wilfully oppressed perspective. We shout and shout as we oscillate between issues, expressing our anger, making threats, but not often enough asserting our rights. Those oppressing us become emboldened, taking more and more liberties as we grasp, in desperation, at more and more "At least" moments. These moments become less and less fulfilling, less sustainable, less appeasing in their nature.

"IT IS HERE THAT WE BEGIN TO FACE THE FACT THAT THE STRUCTURES THAT ARE INTENDED TO PROTECT AND SERVE US HAVE BEEN WEAPONIZED AGAINST US, AGAINST THE AFRICAN PEOPLE."

It is here that we must perhaps pause, and listen, because this is the birthplace of the spirit of resistance. It is here that we begin to face the fact that the structures that are intended to protect and serve us have been weaponized against us, against the African People. The African Union is silent as our brothers and sisters are deprived of their rights, their dignity, their land.

This is the birthplace of the spirit of resistance.

We start to realize that our liberation is not only won in massive actions, but also in the smallest of victories. Our liberation lies in the refusal to compromise on what is right, resisting and challenging anything that further entrenches the rot in the system, whether it be a policeman collecting a five cedi bribe, or police brutality during mass mobilisation against an unlawful change to a beleaguered constitution.

This is the birthplace of the spirit of resistance.

We start to emerge from our bubbles, exposing ourselves to the truth of our collective reality, slowly allowing the small privileges and shaky securities we have erected to fall, in the realization that we cannot truly be free until we are ALL free. A private hospital will remain expensive as long as state hospitals are poorly resourced. The dictator Museveni, in dealing with his E.U., British, and U.S. enablers, does not just compromise Uganda, but the entire Continent. George Floyd's life cannot truly and sustainably matter in the U.S. until we can confidently say the lives of Akua Denteh in Ghana, the Chibok girls in Nigeria, the migrant Africans in Libya, the activists in Sudan, the agitators in Mozambique, the miners in South Africa and in the Congo… Until we can say that these *precious* Black lives matter in the root that is Africa.

This is the birthplace of the spirit of resistance.

In understanding this we start to take positive action, to seek our liberation, making the small steps that become our journey to freedom. We put aside the defeatist statements of "Ghana be dat" and "Uganda Zaabu" ("Uganda is gold," a sarcastic acceptance that in Uganda the impossible is possible), reclaiming ownership of our land, and our continent, and demanding accountability from those we have employed to manage it.

We, the youth, begin to recognize that we are by far the majority in this land, and that it is for us to determine what kind of Africa we seek to inherit from those who come before us. We empower ourselves with knowledge, building a critical mass of youth who are aware of what is happening in their land, on their continent, in Black lives.

We, the youth, begin to vocally reject that which is not in the interest of the People, taking ownership of processes, monitoring, auditing and pressuring the elected custodians of our collective lands.

We, the youth, begin to dismantle our iron bubbles, looking outward and taking all of the concerns we have in our single rooms and applying them to our societies, our continent. *How am I going to eat?* becomes "How are WE going to eat?", *How can I stabilise my income?* becomes "How



"Whose Utopia is It, Anyway?", drawing part of a series by Namata Serumaga -Musisi (2017).

do WE achieve economic democracy?", *What is the best school I can afford to go to?* becomes "How do WE improve our education systems?" We recognize that shady deals and stolen funds are not taken from some abstract pocket, but from our own table from which we eat. We recognize that if imperialist forces are able to make gains in the African states around us, they are making gains on us.

The move from individualist to collective thinking and organizing lightens the individual load. Our voices are amplified, and our actions begin to have impact. There is resonance in our unity.

We begin to live in the Africa we want, building cooperatives and collaborations for both collective and individual growth, forming a formidable force against oppression anywhere we see it. We use the tools and skills at our disposal to recognize the power that we hold and reclaim it from those who buy it cheaply. We stand, shout, sing, resist, act, write, paint, mobilize, march against oppression. We unite in revolutionary groups, we show up — we show UP! We embrace our brothers and sisters across the continent and in the diaspora in the knowledge that we are they and they are we and we are not free, until we are all free.

We reject the concept of "At least".
We reject the usurping of our power.

Our spirit must be one of reclamation. We must reclaim what is ours. We must recognize that we are standing on the shoulders of those who fought to defend our future, that the framework for liberation already stands, that all we have to do is occupy it.

We must begin to live by the standards of the Africa we seek. We must push for better service delivery, now. We must reject any form of oppression, now. We must demand economic democracy, now. All we have to do is love our Continent as we love our small homes, rooting our revolution in love, taking ownership of the future we desire for this continent, building our knowledge base so as to empower us, and dismantling the isolationist bubbles that divide us.

And once we, the People, have made moves towards reclamation, which must of course include reparations — dialogue must and will turn to debt repudiation, the breaking of the last chain, born under the gaze of imperialist Structural Adjustment Programs, imbalanced Partnership Agreements, and exploitative Trade Agreements, formed on the backs of our bodies, our land, our tea, our cotton, our minerals, for centuries.

But this can only work to our benefit if we, the People, hold our power.

"[...] *one of the cardinal principles of Pan-Africanism is that the People from one part of Africa are responsible for their brothers and sisters in other parts of Africa, indeed, black people in all parts of the world are to share in this responsibility.*" (Walter Rodney)

Africa Must Unite!

Our liberation is within our reach. Can you see it?
Can you see that there is hope?

"WE EMBRACE OUR BROTHERS AND SISTERS ACROSS THE CONTINENT AND IN THE DIASPORA IN THE KNOWLEDGE THAT WE ARE THEY AND THEY ARE WE AND WE ARE NOT FREE, UNTIL WE ARE ALL FREE."

And so, whether your tongue resonates in the ear of the African standing next to you, or is merely a sequence of strange words with occasional gems, shared meanings, Moyo, Bantu, Africa, our joys and our pains remain much the same. There is power and resonance in our unity.

Africa will be free, yes. It is written, it is real.
But, in order for Africa to truly be free,

Africa Must Unite. Now. ■

Namata Serumaga-Musisi is a Pan Africanist with roots in Uganda. An Architecture graduate, her work is intended to facilitate the movement towards decoloniality, focusing on the People of Africa and the Global South, and how we can facilitate the reclamation of African identity as defined by inhabited space and its making. Architecture led Namata to Socialism. She serves as Commander of Creative Arts & Advocacy with Ghana-based Nkrumahist movement the Economic Fighters League, also serving as a Diaspora Coordinator for People Power, the Ugandan liberation movement led by Kyagulanyi 'Bobi Wine' Ssentamu.

MASTHEAD

THE FUNAMBULIST

Issue 32 (November-December 2020): ***Pan-Africanism***
Next issue: 33 (January-February 2021): *Labor & Space*

funambulist: fu·nam·bu·list **(fyo͞o-năm′byə-lĭst)**
noun. One who performs on a tightrope or a slack rope. (The Free Dictionary)

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ONO
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On show from 8.11.—20.12.2020

Pauline Agustoni
Elia Castino
The Dazzle Club
Shannon Finnegan
Corinne Heyrman
Paoletta Holst
Alessandro Marchi
Jeannette Petrik
Soeria van den Wijngaard

Rights of Way

The body as witness in public space

A group-show combining soundscape, film, oral testimony, installation and writing to explore the body as witness to our movements, (in)accessibilities and wanderings in and around cities and public space.

M
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BOOKS
BOOKS
BOOKS



Onomatopee 55.3
FIELD ESSAYS - "ÉLOJ KRÉYOL" (CREOLE PRAISE)
Atelier Sophie Krier

In this fourth edition of Field Essays we explore the specific decolonial and tactile research approach in the work of Paris-based design-duo dach&zephir. Convinced of the symbolic act of transmission and the gestures objects convey they zoom into the historic making of identity.

Onomatopee Z0020
BEING IMPOSED UPON
Atelier Sophie Krier

Being is een tijdloze liefdesbrief en handleiding van en voor zwarte vrouwen. Dit boek is een collectie van reflecties over vrouw- én zwart-zijn in België. In de twee landstalen Nederlands en Frans verenigen wij, zwarte vrouwen, non-fictie essays, literaire beschouwingen, poëzie, activistische en academische teksten rond onze zoektocht naar vrijheid. Dit boek is een eerbetoon aan onze ouderen, onze heldinnen en onze zusters.



Onomatopee 182
WHAT HAS LEFT SINCE WE LEFT
Giulio Squillacciotti

"What has left since we left" articulates the fictional end of Europe with the language of love and separation. Likening the political bonds that tie together European countries to the fluctuations of romance and desire, the book unpacks the complexities of the European relationship by touching on ideas of identity, collapse, migration, conflict and hope.



Onomatopee Z0015
INTIMATE NEGROCIATIONS
Bode Owa

You might wonder: 'could these stories be true experiences of the author? Yes
or No, it doesn't matter.

The words in the texts that Bodé Owa has written for Intimate Negrociations are not cloaked in any glamorous gowns, they are bare naked. They release a reality which confronts without aggressive shouting or fierce moralising.



Onomatopee 184
HOW MANY FEMALE TYPE DESIGNERS DO YOU KNOW?
Yulia Popova

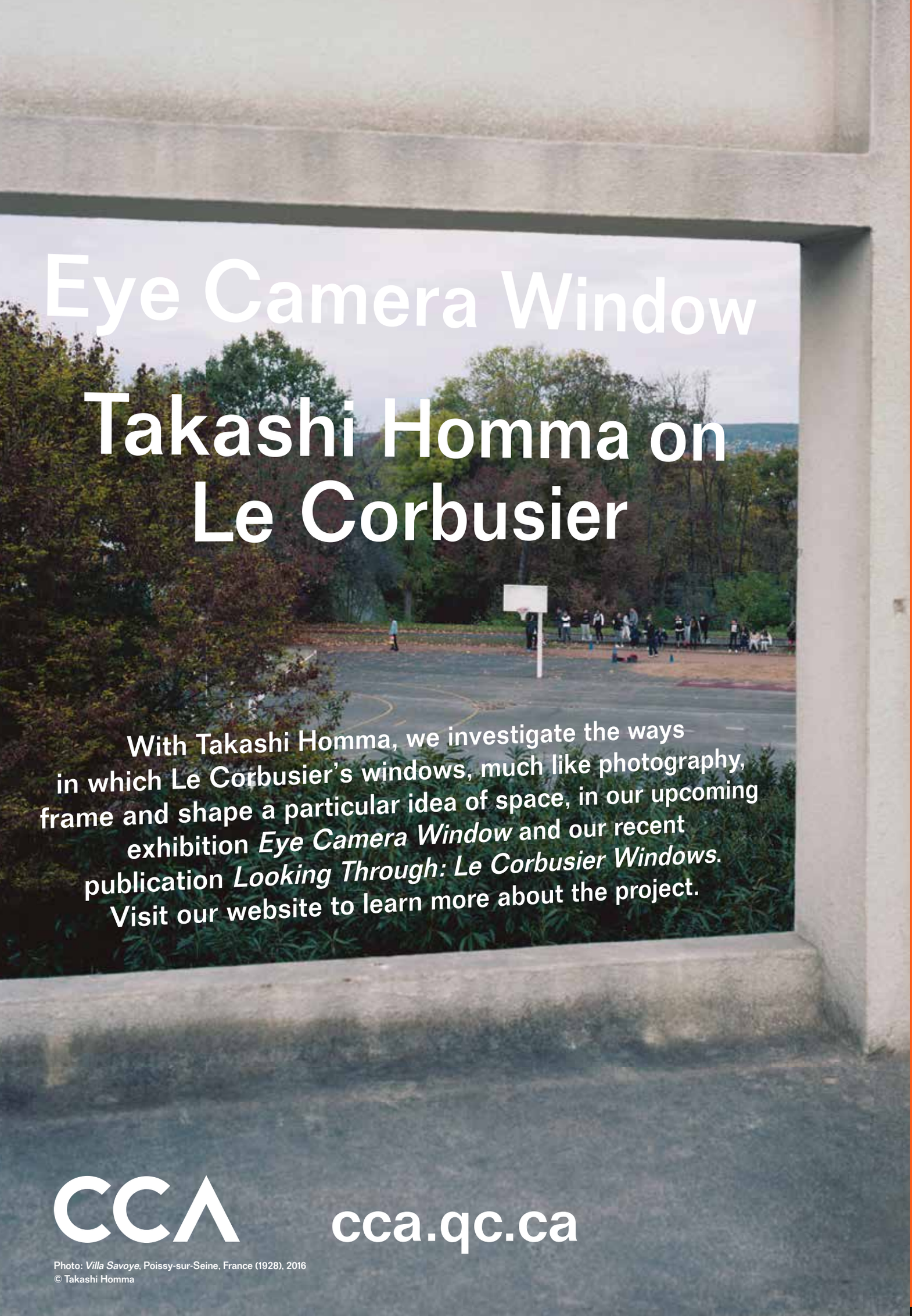
This book aims to shine light on work of women in type.
Interviews with Designers: Gayaneh Bagdasaryan, Veronika Burian, Maria Doreuli, Louise Fili, Martina Flor, Loraine Furter, Jenna Gesse, Golnar Kat Rahmani, Indra Kupferschmid, Briar Levit, Zuzana Licko, Ana Regidor, Fiona Ross and Carol Wahler.



Onomatopee 192
IN THE NAME OF <3
Giulio Squillacciotti

Who claims love?
The benign and seemingly innocent heart symbol hides a much more complex story than its surface suggests. The heart is often described as a universal symbol for love, yet its history suggests otherwise; it is closer to a corporate and political medium, embedded with contemporary imbalances of class, gender, and race.

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Eye Camera Window

Takashi Homma on Le Corbusier

With Takashi Homma, we investigate the ways in which Le Corbusier's windows, much like photography, frame and shape a particular idea of space, in our upcoming exhibition *Eye Camera Window* and our recent publication *Looking Through: Le Corbusier Windows*. Visit our website to learn more about the project.

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Photo: *Villa Savoye*, Poissy-sur-Seine, France (1928), 2016
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